

1: Nahri

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Nahri

He was an easy mark.

Nahri smiled behind her veil, watching the two men bicker as they approached her stall. The younger one glanced anxiously

down the alley while the older man--her client--sweated in the cool dawn air. Save for the men, the alley was empty; fajr had

already been called and anyone devout enough for public prayer--not that there were many in her neighborhood--was already ensconced in the small mosque at the end of the street.

She fought a yawn. Nahri was not one for dawn prayer, but her client had chosen the early hour and paid handsomely for discretion.

She studied the men as they approached, noting their light features and the cut of their expensive coats. Turks, she suspected.

The eldest might even be a basha, one of the few who hadn't fled Cairo when the Franks invaded. She crossed her arms over

her black abaya, growing intrigued. She didn't have many Turkish clients; they were too snobbish. Indeed, when the Franks

and Turks weren't fighting over Egypt, the only thing they seemed to agree on was that the Egyptians couldn't govern it themselves.

God forbid. It's not as though the Egyptians were the inheritors of a great civilization whose mighty monuments still littered

the land. Oh, no. They were peasants, superstitious fools who ate too many beans.

Well, this superstitious fool is about to swindle you for all you're worth, so insult away

. Nahri smiled as the men approached.

She greeted them warmly and ushered them into her tiny stall, serving the elder a bitter tea made from crushed fenugreek seeds

and coarsely chopped mint. He drank it quickly, but Nahri took her time reading the leaves, murmuring and singing in her native

tongue, a language the men most certainly wouldn't know, a language not even she had a name for. The longer she took, the

more desperate he would be. The more gullible.

Her stall was hot, the air trapped by the dark scarves she hung on the walls to protect her clients' privacy and thick with

the odors of burnt cedar, sweat, and the cheap yellow wax she passed off as

frankincense. Her client nervously kneaded the
hem of his coat, perspiration pouring down his ruddy face and dampening the
embroidered collar.

The younger man scowled. "This is foolish, brother," he whispered in Turkish. "The doctor
said there's nothing wrong with
you."

Nahri hid a triumphant smile. So they were Turks. They wouldn't expect her to understand
them--they probably assumed an Egyptian
street healer barely spoke proper Arabic--but Nahri knew Turkish as well as she
knew her native tongue. And Arabic and Hebrew,
scholarly Persian, high-class Venetian, and coastal Swahili. In her twenty or so
years of life, she had yet to come upon a
language she didn't immediately understand.

But the Turks didn't need to know that, so she ignored them, pretending to study the dregs
in the basha's cup. Finally she
sighed, her veil fluttering against her lips in a way that drew the gazes of both men,
and dropped the cup on the floor.

It broke as it was meant to, and the basha gasped. "By the Almighty! It's bad, isn't it?"

Nahri glanced up at the man, languidly blinking long-lashed black eyes. He'd gone pale, and
she paused to listen for the pulse
of his heart. It was fast and uneven due to fright, but she could sense it pumping
healthy blood throughout his body. His
breath was clean of sickness, and there was an unmistakable brightness in his dark
eyes. Despite the graying hairs in his
beard--ill hidden by henna--and the plumpness in his belly, he suffered from nothing
other than an excess of wealth.

She'd be glad to help him with that.

"I am so sorry, sir." Nahri pushed back the small cloth sack, her quick fingers estimating the
number of dirhams it held.

"Please take back your money."

The basha's eyes popped. "What?" he cried. "Why?"

She dropped her gaze. "There are some things that are beyond me," she said quietly.

"Oh, God . . . do you hear her, Arslan?" The basha turned to his brother, tears in his eyes.
"You said I was crazy!" he accused,
choking back a sob. "And now I'm going to die!" He buried his head in his hands and
wept; Nahri counted the gold rings on
his fingers. "I was so looking forward to marrying . . ."

Arslan shot her an irritated look before turning back to the basha. "Pull yourself together, Cemal," he hissed in Turkish.

The basha wiped his eyes and looked up at her. "No, there must be something you can do. I've heard rumors-- People say you
made a crippled boy walk by just

looking

at him. Surely you can help me."

Nahri leaned back, hiding her pleasure. She had no idea what cripple he was referring to, but God be praised, it would certainly
help her reputation.

She touched her heart. "Oh, sir, it grieves me so to deliver such news. And to think of your dear bride being deprived of
such a prize . . ."

His shoulders shook as he sobbed. She waited for him to grow a bit more hysterical, taking the opportunity to appraise the
thick gold bands circling his wrists and neck. A fine garnet, beautifully cut, was pinned to his turban.

Finally she spoke again. "There might be something, but . . . no." She shook her head. "It wouldn't work."

"What?" he cried, clutching the narrow table. "Please, I'll do anything!"

"It will be very difficult."

Arslan sighed. "And expensive, I bet."

Oh, now you speak Arabic?

Nahri gave him a sweet smile, knowing her veil was gauzy enough to reveal her features. "All of my prices are fair, I assure
you."

"Be silent, brother," the basha snapped, glowering at the other man. He looked at Nahri, his face set. "Tell me."

"It's not a certainty," she warned.

"I must try."

"You are a brave man," she said, letting her voice tremble. "Indeed, I believe your affliction has come about from the evil
eye. Someone is envious of you, sir. And who wouldn't be? A man of your wealth and beauty could attract only envy. Perhaps

even someone close . . ." Her glance at Arslan was brief but enough to make his cheeks redden. "You must clear your home of any darkness the envy has brought in."

"How?" the basha asked, his voice hushed and eager.

"First, you must promise to follow my instructions exactly."

"Of course!"

She leaned forward, intent. "Obtain a mixture of one part ambergris to two parts cedar oil, a good amount. Get them from Yaqub, at the apothecary down the alley. He has the best stuff."

"Yaqub?"

"Aywa. Ask for some powdered lime rind and walnut oil as well."

Arslan watched his brother with open disbelief, but hope brightened in the basha's eyes. "And then?"

"This is where it might get difficult, but, sir . . ." Nahri touched his hand, and he shuddered. "You must follow my instructions exactly."

"Yes. By the Most Merciful, I swear."

"Your house needs to be cleansed, and that can only be done if it is abandoned. Your entire family must leave, animals, servants, all. There must not be a living soul in the house for seven days."

"Seven days!" he cried, then lowered his voice at the disapproval in her eyes. "Where are we to go?"

"The oasis at Faiyum." Arslan laughed, but Nahri continued. "Go to the second smallest spring at sunset with your youngest son," she said, her voice severe. "Gather some water in a basket made of local reeds, say the throne verse over it three times, and then use it for your ablutions. Mark your doors with the ambergris and oil before you leave and by the time you return, the envy will be gone."

"Faiyum?" Arslan interrupted. "My God, girl, even you must know there's a war on. Do you imagine Napoleon eager to let any of us leave Cairo for some useless desert trek?"

"Be

quiet

!" The basha banged on the table before turning back to Nahri. "But such a thing will be difficult."

Nahri spread her hands. "God provides."

"Yes, of course. So it is to be Faiyum," he decided, looking determined. "And then my heart will be cured?"

She paused; it was the heart he was worried about? "God willing, sir. Have your new wife put the powdered lime and oil into

your evening tea for the next month." It wouldn't do anything for his nonexistent heart problem, but perhaps his bride would

better enjoy his breath. Nahri let go of his hand.

The basha blinked as if released from a spell. "Oh, thank you, dear one, thank you." He pushed back the small sack of coins

and then slipped a heavy gold ring from his pinkie and handed that over as well. "God bless you."

"May your marriage be fruitful."

He rose heavily to his feet. "I must ask, child, where are your people from? You've a Cairene accent, but there's something

about your eyes . . ." He trailed off.

Nahri pressed her lips together; she hated when people asked after her heritage. Though she wasn't what many would call beautiful--years

of living on the streets had left her much thinner and far dirtier than men typically preferred--her bright eyes and sharp

face usually spurred a second glance. And it was that second glance, the one that revealed a line of midnight hair and uncommonly

black eyes--

unnaturally

black eyes, she'd heard it said--that provoked questions.

"I'm as Egyptian as the Nile," she assured him.

"Of course." He touched his brow. "In peace." He ducked under the doorway to leave.

Arslan stayed behind; Nahri could feel his eyes on her as she gathered her payment. "You do realize you just committed a crime,

yes?" he asked, his voice sharp.

"I'm sorry?"

He stepped closer. "A crime, you fool. Witchcraft is a crime under Ottoman law."

Nahri couldn't help herself; Arslan was only the latest in a long line of puffed-up Turkish

officials she'd had to deal with

growing up in Cairo under Ottoman rule. "Well, then I suppose I'm lucky the Franks are in charge now."

It was a mistake. His face instantly reddened. He raised his hand, and Nahri flinched, her fingers reflexively tightening

over the basha's ring. One sharp edge cut into her palm.

But he didn't hit her. Instead, he spat at her feet. "By God as my witness, you thieving witch . . . when we clear the French

out of Egypt, filth like you will be the next to go." He shot her another hate-filled glare and then left.

She took a shaky breath as she watched the arguing brothers disappear into the early morning gloom toward Yaqub's apothecary.

But it wasn't the threat that unsettled her: It was the rattle she'd heard when he shouted, the smell of iron-rich blood in

the air. A diseased lung, consumption, maybe even a cancerous mass. There was no outward sign of it yet, but soon.

Arslan had been right to suspect her: there was nothing wrong with his brother. But he wouldn't live to see his people reconquer

her country.

She unclenched her fist. The gash in her palm was already healing, a line of new brown skin knitting together beneath the

blood. She stared at it for a long moment and then sighed before ducking back inside her stall.

She pulled off her knotted headdress and crumpled it into a ball.

You fool. You know better than to lose your temper with men like that.

Nahri didn't need any more enemies, especially not ones now likely to post guards around the basha's house while he was in

Faiyum. What he'd paid today was a pittance compared to what she could steal from his empty villa. She wouldn't have stolen

much--she'd been doing her tricks long enough to avoid the temptations of excess. But some jewelry that could have been blamed

on a forgetful wife, a quick-fingered servant? Baubles that would have meant nothing to the basha and a month's rent to Nahri?

Those she would take.

Muttering another curse, she rolled back her sleeping mat and dislodged a few bricks from the floor. She dropped the basha's

coins and ring in the shallow hole, frowning at her meager savings.

It's not enough. It's never going to be enough.

She replaced the bricks, calculating how much she still needed to pay for this month's rent and bribes, the inflated costs

of her increasingly unsavory profession. The number always grew, pushing away her dreams of Istanbul and tutors, of a respectable trade and actual healing instead of this "magical" nonsense.

But there was nothing to be done about it now, and Nahri wasn't about to take time from earning money to bemoan her fate.

She stood, winding a rumpled headscarf around her messy curls and gathering up the amulets she'd made for the Barzani women

and the poultice for the butcher. She'd need to come back later to prepare for the zar, but for now, she had someone far more important to see.

Yaqub's apothecary was located at the end of the alley, crammed between a moldering fruit stand and a bread bakery. No one

knew what had led the elderly Jewish pharmacist to open an apothecary in such a grim slum. Most of the people living in her

alley were desperate: prostitutes, addicts, and garbage-pickers. Yaqub had moved in quietly several years ago, settling his

family into the upper floors of the cleanest building. The neighbors wagged their tongues, spreading rumors of gambling debts

and drunkenness, or darker charges that his son had killed a Muslim, that Yaqub himself took blood and humors from the alley's

half-dead addicts. Nahri thought it all nonsense, but she didn't dare ask. She didn't question his background, and he didn't

ask why a former pickpocket could diagnose illnesses better than the sultan's personal physician. Their strange partnership rested on avoiding those two subjects.

She entered the apothecary, quickly sidestepping the battered bell meant to announce customers. Crowded with supplies and

impossibly chaotic, Yaqub's shop was her favorite place in the world. Mismatched wooden shelves crammed with dusty glass vials,

tiny reed baskets, and crumbling ceramic jars covered the walls. Lengths of dried herbs, animal parts, and objects she couldn't

identify hung from the ceiling while clay amphorae competed for the small amount of floor space. Yaqub knew his inventory

like the lines of his palms, and listening to his stories of ancient Magi or the hot spice lands of the Hind transported her

to worlds she could hardly imagine.

The pharmacist was bent over his workbench, mixing something that gave off a sharp,

unpleasant scent. She smiled at the sight
of the old man with his even older instruments. His mortar alone looked like something from the reign of Salah ad-Din. "Sabah el-hayr," she greeted him.

Yaqub made a startled noise and glanced up, knocking his forehead into a hanging garlic braid. Swatting it away, he grumbled,
"Sabah el-noor. Can't you make some noise when you enter? Scared me half to death."

Nahri grinned. "I like to surprise you."

He snorted. "Sneak up on me, you mean. You get more like the devil each day."

"That's a very unkind thing to say to someone who brought you a small fortune this morning." She pushed up on her hands to perch on his workbench.

"Fortune? Is that what you call two bickering Ottoman officials banging down my door at dawn? My wife nearly had a heart attack."

"So buy her some jewelry with the money."

Yaqub shook his head. "And ambergris! You're lucky I even had some in stock! What, could you not convince him to paint his
door in molten gold?"

She shrugged, picking up one of the jars near his elbow and taking a delicate sniff. "They looked like they could afford it."

"The younger one had quite an earful to say about you."

"You can't please everyone." She picked up another jar, watching as he added some candlenut kernels to his mortar.

He put the pestle down with a sigh, holding his hand out for the jar, which she reluctantly handed back. "What are you making?"

"This?" He returned to grinding the kernels. "A poultice for the cobbler's wife. She's been dizzy."

Nahri watched another moment. "That won't help."

"Oh, really? Tell me again, Doctor, who did you train under?"

Nahri smiled; Yaqub hated when she did this. She turned back to the shelves, hunting for the familiar pot. The shop was a

mess, a chaos of unlabeled jars and supplies that seemed to get up and move on their own. "She's pregnant," she called over
her shoulder. She picked up a vial of peppermint oil, swatting away a spider that

crawled over the top.

"Pregnant? Her husband said nothing."

Nahri pushed the vial in his direction and added a gnarled root of ginger. "It's early. They probably don't know yet."

He gave her a sharp look. "And you do?"

"By the Compassionate, don't you? She vomits loudly enough to wake Shaitan, may he be cursed. She and her husband have six

children. You think they'd know the signs by now." She smiled, trying to reassure him. "Make her a tea from these."

"I haven't heard her."

"Ya, grandfather, you don't hear me come in either. Maybe the fault lies with your ears."

Yaqub pushed away the mortar with a disgruntled noise and turned to the back corner where he kept his earnings. "I wish you'd

stop playing Musa bin Maimon and find yourself a husband. You're not too old, you know." He pulled out his trunk; the hinges groaned as he opened the battered top.

Nahri laughed. "If you could find someone willing to marry the likes of me, you'd put every matchmaker in Cairo out of business."

She pawed through the random assortment of books, receipts, and vials on the table, searching for the small enamel case where

Yaqub kept sesame candies for his grandchildren, finally finding it beneath a dusty ledger. "Besides," she continued, plucking out two of the candies, "I like our partnership."

He handed her a small sack. Nahri could tell from its weight that it was more than her usual cut. She started to protest,

but he cut her off. "Stay away from men like that, Nahri. It's dangerous."

"Why? The Franks are in charge now." She chewed her candy, suddenly curious. "Is it true Frankish women go about naked in the street?"

The pharmacist shook his head, used to her impropriety. "French, child, not Frankish. And God prevent you from hearing such wickedness."

"Abu Talha says their leader has the feet of a goat."

"Abu Talha should stick to mending shoes . . . But don't change the subject," he said, exasperated. "I'm trying to warn you."

"Warn me? Why? I've never even talked to a Frank." That wasn't for lack of effort. She'd tried selling amulets to the few

French soldiers she'd encountered, and they'd backed away like she was some sort of snake, making condescending remarks about her clothing in their strange language.

He locked eyes with her. "You're young," he said quietly. "You have no experience with what happens to people like us during a war. People who are different. You should keep your head down. Or better yet, leave. What happened to your grand plans of Istanbul?"

After counting her savings this morning, the mere mention of the city soured her. "I thought you said I was being foolish," she reminded him. "That no physician would take on a female apprentice."

"You could be a midwife," he offered. "You've delivered babies before. You could go east, away from this war. Beirut, perhaps."

"You sound eager to be rid of me."

He touched her hand, his brown eyes filled with concern. "I'm eager to see you safe

. You've no family, no husband to stand up for you, to protect you, to--"

She bristled. "I can take care of myself."

"--to

advise

you against doing dangerous things," he finished, giving her a look. "Things like leading zars."

Ah

. Nahri winced. "I hoped you wouldn't hear about those."

"Then you're a fool," he said bluntly. "You shouldn't be getting caught up in that southern magic." He gestured behind her.

"Get me a tin."

She fetched one from the shelf, tossing it to him with a bit more force than was necessary. "There's no 'magic' to it at all," she dismissed. "It's harmless."

"Harmless!" Yaqub scoffed as he shoveled tea into the tin. "I've heard rumors about those zars . . . blood sacrifices, trying

to exorcise djinn . . ."

"It's not really meant to

exorcise

them," Nahri corrected lightly. "More like an effort to make peace."

He stared at her in utter exasperation. "You shouldn't be trying to do anything with djinn!"

He shook his head, closing the

tin and rubbing warm wax over the seams. "You're playing with things you don't understand, Nahri. They're not your traditions.

You're going to get your soul snapped up by a demon if you're not more careful."

Nahri was oddly touched by his concern--to think that just a few years ago he'd dismissed her as a black-hearted fraudster.

"Grandfather," she started, trying to sound more respectful. "You needn't worry. There's no magic, I swear." Seeing the doubt

on his face, she decided to be more frank. "It's nonsense, all of it. There's no magic, no djinn, no spirits waiting to eat

us up. I've been doing my tricks long enough to learn none of it's real."

He paused. "The things I've seen you do--"

"Maybe I'm just a better trickster than the rest," she cut in, hoping to assuage the fear she saw in his face. She didn't

need to scare off her only friend simply because she had a few strange skills.

He shook his head. "There are still djinn. And demons. Even scholars say so."

"Well, the scholars are wrong. No spirit has come after me yet."

"That's very arrogant, Nahri. Blasphemous, even," he added, looking taken aback. "Only a fool would speak in such a way."

She lifted her chin defiantly. "They don't exist."

He sighed. "No one can say I didn't try." He pushed the tin over. "Give that to the cobbler on your way out, will you?"

Nahri pushed off the table. "Are you doing inventory tomorrow?" Arrogant she might be, but she rarely passed on an opportunity

to learn more about the apothecary. Yaqub's knowledge had greatly advanced her own instincts for healing.

"Yes, but come early. We have a lot to get through."

She nodded. "God willing."

"Now go buy some kebab," he said, nodding at the purse. "You're all bones. The djinn will

want more to eat should they come
for you."

By the time Nahri reached the neighborhood where the zar was taking place, the sun had blinked behind the crowded landscape
of stone minarets and mud-brick flats. It vanished into the distant desert, and a low-voiced muezzin began the call to maghrib
prayer. She paused, briefly disoriented by the loss of light. The neighborhood was in southern Cairo, squeezed between the
remains of ancient Fustat and the Mokattam hills, and it wasn't an area she knew well.

The chicken she was carrying took advantage of Nahri's distraction to kick her in the ribs, and Nahri swore, tucking it tighter
under her arm as she pushed past a thin man balancing a board of bread on his head and narrowly avoided a collision with a
gaggle of giggling children. She picked her way through a growing pile of shoes outside an already packed mosque. The neighborhood
was crowded; the French invasion had done little to stop the waves of people coming to Cairo from the countryside. The new
migrants arrived with little more than the clothing on their backs and the traditions of their ancestors, traditions often
denounced as perversions by some of the city's more irritated imams.

The zars were certainly denounced as such. Like belief in magic, belief in possession was widespread in Cairo, blamed for
everything from a young bride's miscarriage to an old woman's lifelong dementia. Zar ceremonies were held to placate the spirit
and heal the afflicted woman. And while Nahri didn't believe in possession, the basketful of coins and the free meal earned
by the kodia, the woman who led the ceremony, were too tempting to pass up. And so, after spying on a number of them, she
started hosting her own--albeit extremely abbreviated--version.

Tonight would be the third one she held. She'd met with an aunt from the afflicted girl's family last week and arranged to
hold the ceremony in an abandoned courtyard near their home. By the time she arrived, her musicians, Shams and Rana, were
already waiting.

Nahri greeted them warmly. The courtyard had been swept clean, and a narrow table, covered with a white cloth, set in the
center. Two copper platters sat at either end of the table, laden with almonds, oranges, and dates. A fair-size group had
gathered, the female members of the afflicted girl's family as well as about a dozen

curious neighbors. Though all looked
poor, no one would dare come to a zar empty-handed. It would be a good take.

Nahri beckoned to a pair of small girls. Still young enough to find the whole thing terribly exciting, they raced over, their
little faces eager. Nahri knelt and folded the chicken she'd been carrying into the arms of the elder.

"Hold him tight for me, okay?" Nahri asked. The girl nodded, looking self-important.

She handed her basket to the younger girl. She was precious, with big dark eyes and curly hair pulled into messy braids. No

one would be able to resist her. Nahri winked. "You make sure everyone puts something in the basket." She tugged one of her

braids and then waved the girls away before turning her attention to the reason she was here.

The afflicted girl's name was Baseema. She looked about twelve and had been outfitted in a long white dress. Nahri watched

as an older woman attempted to tie a white scarf around her hair. Baseema fought back, her eyes wild, her hands flapping.

Nahri could see that her fingertips were red and raw from where she'd bitten her nails. Fear and anxiety radiated off her

skin, and kohl streaked her cheeks from where she'd tried to rub it from her eyes.

"Please, beloved," the older woman begged. Her mother; the resemblance was obvious. "We're just trying to help you."

Nahri kneeled beside them and took Baseema's hand. The girl stilled, only her eyes darting back and forth. Nahri pulled her

gently to her feet. The group fell silent as she laid a hand upon Baseema's brow.

Nahri could no more explain the way she healed and sensed illness than she could explain how her eyes and ears worked. Her

abilities had so long been a part of her that she had simply stopped questioning their existence. It had taken her years as

a child--and a number of painful lessons--to even realize how different she was from the people around her, like being the only

sighted person in a world of the blind. And her abilities were so natural, so organic, that it was impossible to think of

them as anything out of the ordinary.

Baseema felt unbalanced, her mind alive and sparking beneath Nahri's fingertips but misdirected.

Broken

. She hated how quickly the cruel word leaped to mind, but Nahri knew there was little she could do for the girl other than temporarily soothing her.

And put on a good show in the process--she wouldn't get paid otherwise. Nahri pushed back the scarf from the girl's face, sensing she felt trapped. Baseema held one end in a clenched fist, giving it a shake as her eyes locked on Nahri's face.

Nahri smiled. "You can keep that if you like, dear one. We're going to have fun together, I promise." She raised her voice and turned to the audience. "You were right to bring me. There is a spirit in her. A strong one. But we can calm it, yes?

Bring about a happy marriage between the two?" She winked and motioned to her musicians.

Shams started on her darbuka, banging out a fierce beat on the old skin drum. Rana took up her pipe and handed Nahri a tambourine--the one instrument she could use without making a fool of herself.

Nahri tapped it against her leg. "I will sing to the spirits I know," she explained over the music, though there were very few southern women who didn't know how a zar worked. Baseema's aunt took up an incense burner, waving plumes of aromatic smoke over the crowd. "When her spirit hears its song, it will make her excitable, and we can proceed."

Rana started on her pipe, and Nahri beat the tambourine, her shoulders shaking, her fringed scarf swaying with every movement. Transfixed, Baseema followed her.

"Oh, spirits, we beseech thee! We implore and honor thee!" Nahri sang, keeping her voice low so it didn't crack. While legitimate kodia were trained singers, Nahri was anything but. "Ya, amir el Hind! Oh, great prince, join us!" She started with the song of the Indian prince and moved on to that of the Sea Sultan and then the Great Qarina, the music changing for each one. She'd been careful to memorize their lyrics if not their meanings; she was not particularly worried about the origins of such things.

Baseema grew more animated as they went on, her limbs loosening, the tense lines in her face gone. She swayed with less effort, tossing her hair with a small, self-contained smile. Nahri touched her every time they passed, feeling for the dim areas of her mind and pulling them closer to calm the restless girl.

It was a good group, energetic and involved. Several women stood, clapping their hands and joining the dance. People typically

did; zars were as much an excuse to socialize as to deal with troublesome djinn. Baseema's mother watched her daughter's face,

looking hopeful. The little girls clutched their prizes, jumping up and down in excitement as the chicken squawked in protest.

Her musicians also looked to be enjoying themselves. Shams suddenly struck out a faster beat on the darbuka, and Rana followed

her lead, playing a mournful, almost unsettling tune on the pipe.

Nahri drummed her fingers on the tambourine, growing inspired by the group's mood. She grinned; maybe it was time to give

them something a little different.

She closed her eyes and hummed. Nahri had no name for her native tongue, the language she must have shared with her long-dead

or forgotten parents. The only clue to her origins, she had listened for it since she was a child, eavesdropping on foreign

merchants and haunting the polyglot crowd of scholars outside El Azhar University. Thinking it similar to Hebrew, she'd once

spoken it to Yaqub, but he'd adamantly disagreed, adding, unnecessarily, that his people had enough problems without her being one of them.

But she knew it sounded unusual and eerie. Perfect for the zar. Nahri was surprised she hadn't thought of using it before.

Though she could have sung her market list and no one would have been any the wiser, she stuck to the zar songs, translating

the Arabic into her native language.

"Sah, afshin e-daeva . . . ," she started. "Oh, warrior of the djinn, we beseech thee! Join us, calm the fires in this girl's

mind." She closed her eyes. "Oh, warrior, come to me! Vak!"

A bead of sweat snaked past her temple. The courtyard grew uncomfortably warm, the press of the large group and crackling

fire too much. She kept her eyes closed and swayed, letting the movement of her headdress fan her face. "Great guardian, come

and protect us. Watch over Baseema as if--"

A low gasp startled Nahri, and she opened her eyes. Baseema had stopped dancing; her limbs were frozen, her glassy gaze fixed

on Nahri. Clearly unnerved, Shams missed a beat on the darbuka.

Afraid of losing the crowd, Nahri struck her tambourine against one hip, silently praying

Shams would copy her. She smiled

at Baseema and picked up the incense brazier, hoping the musky fragrance would relax the girl. Maybe it was time to wrap things

up. "Oh, warrior," she sang more softly, returning to Arabic. "Is it you who sleeps in the mind of our gentle Baseema?"

Baseema twitched; sweat poured down her face. Closer now, Nahri could see that the blank expression in the girl's eyes had

been replaced by something that looked a lot more like fear. A bit unsettled, she reached for the girl's hand.

Baseema blinked, and her eyes narrowed, focusing on Nahri with an almost feral curiosity.

WHO ARE YOU?

Nahri blanched and dropped her hand. Baseema's lips hadn't moved, yet she heard the question as though it had been shouted

in her ear.

Then the moment was gone. Baseema shook her head, the blank look reappearing as she began to dance again. Startled, Nahri

took a few steps back. A cold sweat erupted across her skin.

Rana was at her shoulder. "Ya, Nahri?"

"Did you hear that?" she whispered.

Rana raised her brows. "Hear what?"

Don't be a fool

. Nahri shook her head, feeling ridiculous. "Nothing." Raising her voice, she faced the crowd. "All praise is due to the Almighty,"

she declared, trying not to stammer. "Oh, warrior, we thank you." She beckoned for the girl holding the chicken. "Please accept

our offering and make peace with dear Baseema." Her hands shaking, Nahri held the chicken over a battered stone bowl and whispered

a prayer before cutting its throat. Blood spurted into the bowl, spattering her feet.

Baseema's aunt took the chicken away to be cooked, but Nahri's job was far from over. "Tamarind juice for our guest," she

requested. "The djinn like their sours." She forced a smile and tried to relax.

Shams brought over a small glass of the dark juice. "Are you well, kodia?"

"God be praised," Nahri said. "Just tired. Can you and Rana distribute the food?"

"Of course."

Baseema was still swaying, her eyes half closed, a dreamy smile on her face. Nahri took

her hands and gently pulled her to

the ground, aware that much of the group was watching. "Drink, child," she said, offering the cup. "It will please your djinn."

The girl clutched the glass, spilling nearly half the juice down her face. She gestured at her mother, making a low noise

in the back of her throat.

"Yes, habibti

.

" Nahri stroked her hair, willing her to be calm. The child was still unbalanced, but her mind didn't feel as frantic. God

only knew how long it would last. She beckoned Baseema's mother over and joined their hands.

There were tears in the older woman's eyes. "Is she cured? Will the djinn leave her in peace?"

Nahri hesitated. "I have made them both content, but the djinn is a strong one and has likely been with her since birth. For

such a tender thing . . ." She squeezed Baseema's hand. "It was probably easier for her to submit to his wishes."

"What does that mean?" the other woman asked, her voice breaking.

"Your daughter's state is the will of God. The djinn will keep her safe, provide her with a rich inner life," she lied, hoping

it would give the woman some comfort. "Keep them both content. Let her stay with you and your husband, give her things to do with her hands."

"Will . . . will she ever speak?"

Nahri looked away. "God willing."

The older woman swallowed, obviously picking up on Nahri's discomfort. "And the djinn?"

She tried to think of something easy. "Have her drink tamarind juice every morning--it will please him. And take her to the

river to bathe on the first jumu'ah, the first Friday, of every month."

Baseema's mother took a deep breath. "God knows best," she said softly, seemingly more to herself than to Nahri. But there

were no more tears. Instead, as Nahri watched, the older woman took her daughter's hand, looking more at peace already. Baseema smiled.

Yaqub's words stole into Nahri's heart at the tender sight.

You've no family, no husband to stand up for you, to protect you . . .

Nahri stood up. "You'll excuse me."

As kodia, she had no choice but to stay until the meal was served, nodding politely at the women's gossip and trying to avoid

an elderly cousin whom she sensed had a mass spreading in both breasts. Nahri had never tried to heal anything like that and

didn't think it was a good night to experiment--though that didn't make the woman's smiling face easier to stomach.

The ceremony finally drew to a close. Her basket was flush, filled with a random assortment of the various coins used in Cairo:

battered copper fils, a scattering of silver paras, and a single ancient dinar from Baseema's family. Other women had put

in small pieces of cheap jewelry, all exchanged for the blessings she was supposed to bring them. Nahri gave Shams and Rana

each two paras and let them take most of the jewelry.

She was securing her outer wrap and ducking the repeated kisses of Baseema's family when she felt a slight prickling at the

back of her neck. She'd spent too many years stalking marks and being followed herself not to recognize the feeling. She glanced
up.

From the opposite side of the courtyard, Baseema stared back. She was completely still, her limbs in perfect control. Nahri

met her gaze, surprised by the girl's calm.

There was something curious and calculating in Baseema's dark eyes. But then, just as Nahri really took notice, it was gone.

The younger girl pressed her hands together and began to sway, dancing as Nahri had shown her.

2: Nahri

2

Nahri

Something happened to that girl

.

Nahri picked through the pastry crumbs of her long-devoured feteer. Her mind spinning after the zar, she'd stopped in a local

coffeehouse rather than head home and, hours later, she was still there. She swirled her glass; the red dregs of her hibiscus tea raced across the bottom.

Nothing happened, you idiot. You didn't hear any voices

. She yawned, propping her elbows up on the table and closing her eyes. Between her predawn appointment with the basha and her long walk across the city, she was exhausted.

A small cough caught her attention. She opened her eyes to find a man with a limp beard and a hopeful expression idling by her table.

Nahri drew her dagger before he could speak and slammed the hilt against the wooden surface. The man vanished, and a hush fell across the coffeehouse. Someone's dominos clattered to the floor.

The owner glared, and she sighed, knowing that she was about to be thrown out. He'd initially refused her service, claiming

no honorable woman would dare venture out unaccompanied at night, let alone visit a coffeehouse full of strange men. After

repeatedly demanding to know if her menfolk knew where she was, the sight of the coins from the zar had finally shut him up,

but she suspected that brief welcome was about to end.

She stood up, dropped some money on the table, and left. The street was dark and unusually deserted; the French curfew had

scared even the most nocturnal of Egyptians into staying inside.

Nahri kept her head down as she walked, but it wasn't long before she realized she was lost. Though the moon was bright, this

part of the city was unfamiliar to her, and she circled the same alley twice, looking for the main road without success.

Tired and annoyed, she stopped outside the entrance to a quiet mosque, contemplating the idea of sheltering there for the
night. The sight of a distant mausoleum towering over the mosque's dome caught her eye. She stilled. El Arafa: the City of
the Dead.

A sprawling, beloved mass of burial fields and tombs, El Arafa reflected Cairo's obsession with all things funerary. The cemetery
ran along the city's eastern edge, a spine of crumbling bones and rotting tissue where everyone from Cairo's founders to its
addicts were buried. And until plague had dealt with Cairo's housing shortage a few years ago, it had even served as shelter
for migrants with nowhere else to go.

It was an idea that made her shudder. Nahri didn't share the comfort most Egyptians felt around the dead, let alone the desire
to move in with a pile of decaying bones. She found corpses offensive; their smell, their silence, it was all wrong. From
some of the more well-traveled traders, she heard stories of people who burned their dead, foreigners who thought they were
being clever in hiding from God's judgment--geniuses, Nahri thought. Going up in a crackling fire sounded delightful compared
to being buried under the smothering sands of El Arafa.

But she also knew that the cemetery was her best hope of getting home. She could follow its border north until she reached
more familiar neighborhoods, and it was a good place to hide if she came across any French soldiers looking to enforce the
curfew; foreigners usually shared her apprehension toward the City of the Dead.

Once inside the cemetery, Nahri stuck to the outermost lane. It was even more deserted than the street; the only hints of
life were the smell of a long-extinguished cooking fire and the shrieks of fighting cats. The spiky crenellations and smooth
domes of the tombs cast wild shadows against the sandy ground. The ancient buildings looked neglected; Egypt's Ottoman rulers
had preferred to be buried in their Turkish homeland and therefore hadn't seen the upkeep of the cemetery as important--one
of many insults they'd visited upon her countrymen.

The temperature seemed to have dropped rather suddenly, and Nahri shivered. Her worn leather sandals, threadbare things long
overdue for replacement, padded on the soft ground. There was no other sound save the jingling coins in her basket. Already
unnerved, Nahri avoided looking at the tombs, instead contemplating the far more

pleasant topic of breaking into the basha's

house while he was in Faiyum. Nahri would be damned if she was going to let some consumptive little brother keep her from a lucrative take.

She hadn't been walking long when there was a hush of breath behind her, followed by a flit of movement she caught out of the corner of her eye.

It could be someone else taking a shortcut

, she told herself, her heart racing. Cairo was relatively safe, but Nahri knew there were few good outcomes to a young woman being followed at night.

She kept her pace but moved her hand toward her dagger before making an abrupt turn deeper into the cemetery. She hurried down the lane, startling a sleepy cur, and then ducked behind the entrance to one of the old Fatimid tombs.

The footsteps followed. They stopped. Nahri took a deep breath and raised her blade, getting ready to bluster and threaten whoever was there. She stepped out.

She froze. "

Baseema?

"

The young girl stood in the middle of the alley about a dozen paces away, her head uncovered, her abaya stained and torn.

She smiled at Nahri. Her teeth gleamed in the moonlight as a breeze blew back her hair.

"Speak again," Baseema demanded in a voice strained and hoarse from disuse.

Nahri gasped. Had she actually helped the girl? And if so, why in God's name was she wandering around a cemetery in the middle of the night?

She dropped her arm and hurried toward her. "What are you doing out here all alone, child? Your mother will be worried."

She stopped. Though it was dark, sudden clouds veiling the moon, she could see strange splotches staining Baseema's hands.

Nahri drew in a sharp breath, catching the scent of something smoky and charred and

wrong

.

"Is that . . . blood? By the Most High, Baseema, what happened?"

Clearly oblivious to Nahri's worry, Baseema clapped her hands together in delight. "Could it really be you?" She circled Nahri

slowly. "About the right age . . .," she mused. "And I'd swear that I see that witch in your features, but you otherwise look so

human

." Her gaze fell on the knife in Nahri's hand. "Though I suppose there's only one real way to tell."

The words had no sooner left her mouth than she snatched the dagger away, her movements impossibly fast. Nahri stumbled back

with a surprised cry, and Baseema laughed. "Don't worry, little healer. I'm no fool; I've no intention of testing your blood myself." She wagged the dagger in one hand. "Though I think I'll take

this

before you get any ideas."

Nahri was speechless. She took Baseema in with new eyes. Gone was the flapping, tormented child. Her bizarre declarations

aside, she stood with a new confidence, the wind whipping through her hair.

Baseema narrowed her eyes, perhaps picking up on Nahri's confusion. "Surely you know what I am. The marid must have warned you about us."

"The

what

?" Nahri held up a hand, trying to protect her eyes from a sandy gust of wind. The weather had worsened. Behind Baseema, dark

gray and orange clouds swirled across the sky, obliterating the stars. The wind howled again, like the worst of the khamaseen, but it was not yet the season for Cairo's spring sandstorms.

Baseema glanced at the sky. Alarm bloomed in her small face. She whirled on Nahri. "That human magic you did . . . who did you call for?"

Magic?

Nahri raised her hands. "I didn't do any magic!"

Baseema moved in the blink of an eye. She shoved Nahri against the nearest tomb wall, pressing an elbow hard against her throat.

"Who did you sing for?"

"I . . ." Nahri gasped, shocked by the strength in the girl's thin arms. "A . . . warrior, I think. But it was nothing. Just
an old zar song."

Baseema stepped back as a hot breeze tore down the alley, smelling of fire. "That's not possible," she whispered. "He's dead.

They're all dead."

"Who's dead?" Nahri had to shout over the wind. "Wait, Baseema!" she cried as the young girl fled down the opposite alley.

"Where are you going?"

She didn't have long to wonder. A crack snapped the air, louder than a cannon. All was silent, too silent, and then Nahri

was thrown off her feet, blasted against one of the tombs.

She hit the stone hard as a bright flash of light blinded her. She crumpled to the ground, too dazed to protect her face from

the rain of scorching sand.

The world went quiet, returning with the steady beat of her heart, the blood rushing to her head. Black dots blossomed across

her eyes. She flexed her fingers and twitched her toes, relieved they were still attached. The thud of her heart was slowly

replaced by ringing in her ears. She tentatively touched the throbbing bulge on the back of her skull, stifling a cry at the
sharp pain.

She tried to twist free of the sand that half-buried her, still blinded by the flash. No, not from the flash, she realized.

The white bright light was still in the alley, just condensing, growing smaller to reveal fire-scorched tombs as it collapsed

in on itself. As it collapsed in on

something

.

Baseema was nowhere to be seen. Frantically, Nahri began to work her legs loose. She had just managed to uncover them when

she heard the voice, clear as a bell and angry as a tiger, in the language she'd been listening for all her life.

"Suleiman's eye!" it roared. "I will

kill

whoever called me here!"

There's no magic, no djinn, no spirits waiting to eat us up.

Nahri's own decisive words to Yaqub came back to her, mocking her as she peeked over the headstone she'd dashed behind when

she first heard his voice. The air still smelled of ash, but the light filling the alley dimmed, almost like it had been sucked

in by the figure at its center. It looked like a man, swathed in a dark robe that swirled around his feet like smoke.

He stepped forward as the remaining light vanished into his body and immediately lost his balance, grabbing for a desiccated

tree trunk. As he steadied himself, the bark burst into flames beneath his hand. Instead of pulling back, he leaned against

the burning tree with a sigh, the flames licking harmlessly at his robe.

Too stunned to form a coherent thought, let alone flee, Nahri rolled back against the headstone as the man called out again.

"Khayzur . . . if this is your idea of a jest, I swear on my ancestors to pluck you apart feather by feather!"

His bizarre threat rang in her mind, the words meaningless, but the language so familiar it felt tangible.

Why is some lunatic fire creature speaking my language?

Unable to fight her curiosity, she turned back, peering past the headstone.

The creature dug through the sand, muttering to himself and swearing. As Nahri watched, he pulled free a curved scimitar and

secured it to his waist. It was quickly joined by two daggers, an enormous mace, an ax, a long quiver of arrows, and a gleaming silver bow.

The bow in hand, he finally staggered up and glanced down the alley, obviously searching for whoever had--what had he said?--"called"

him. Though he didn't look much taller than her, the vast array of weapons--enough to fight a whole troop of French soldiers--was

terrifying and slightly ridiculous. Like what a little boy might do when playing at being some ancient warrior.

A warrior. Oh, by the Most High . . .

He was looking for her. Nahri was the one who had called him.

"Where are you?" he bellowed, striding forward with his bow raised. He was getting dangerously close to Nahri's headstone.

"I will tear you into fours!" He spoke her language with a cultured accent, his poetic tone at odds with the terrifying threat.

Nahri had no desire to learn what being "torn into fours" meant. She slipped off her sandals. Once he was past her headstone,

she quickly rose and silently fled down the opposite lane.

Unfortunately, she had forgotten about her basket. As she moved, the coins rang out in the silent night.

The man roared, "Stop!"

She sped up, her bare feet pounding the ground. She turned down one twisting lane and then another, hoping to confuse him.

Spotting a darkened doorway, she ducked inside. The cemetery was silent, free of the sounds of pursuing feet or angry threats.

Could she have lost him?

She leaned against the cool stone, trying to catch her breath and wishing desperately for her dagger--not that her puny blade

would offer much protection against the excessively armed man hunting her.

I can't stay here.

But Nahri could see nothing but tombs in front of her and had no idea how to get back to the streets. She gritted her teeth,

trying to muster up some courage.

Please, God . . . or whoever is listening,

she prayed

. Just get me out of this, and I swear I'll ask Yaqub for a bridegroom tomorrow. And I'll

never

do another zar.

She took a hesitant step.

An arrow whistled through the air.

Nahri shrieked as it sliced across her temple. She staggered forward and reached for her head, her fingers immediately sticky

with blood.

The cold voice spoke. "Stop where you are or the next one goes through your throat."

She froze, her hand still pressed against her wound. The blood was already clotting, but she didn't want to give the creature
an excuse to put another hole in her.

"Turn around."

She swallowed back her fear and turned, keeping her hands still and her eyes on the ground. "Pl-please don't kill me," she
stammered. "I didn't mean to--"

The man--or whatever he was--sucked in his breath, a noise like an extinguished coal. "You . . . you're human," he whispered.

"How do you know Divasti? How can you even
hear
me?"

"I . . ." Nahri paused, startled to finally learn the name of the language she'd known since childhood.

Divasti

.

"Look at me." He moved closer, the air between them growing warm with the smell of burnt citrus.

Her heart was beating so hard she could hear it in her ears. She took a deep breath, forcing herself to meet his gaze.

His face was covered like a desert traveler, but even if it had been visible, she doubted she would have seen anything but
his eyes. Greener than emeralds, they were almost too bright to look into directly.

His eyes narrowed. He pushed back her headscarf, and Nahri flinched as he touched her right ear. His fingertips were so hot
that even his brief press was enough to scald her skin.

"Shafit," he said softly, but unlike his other words, the term remained incomprehensible in her mind. "Move your hand, girl.
Let me see your face."

He pushed her hand away before she could comply. By now, the blood had clotted. Exposed to the air, her wound itched; she
knew the skin was stitching back together before his eyes.

He leaped back, nearly crashing into the opposite wall. "Suleiman's eye!" He looked her up

and down again, sniffing the air

like a dog. "How . . . how did you do that?" he demanded. His bright eyes flashed. "Is this some sort of trick? A trap?"

"No!" She held her hands up, praying she looked innocent. "No trick, no trap, I swear!"

"Your voice . . . you are the one who called me." He raised his sword and laid the curved blade against her neck, soft as a lover's hand. "How? Who are you working for?"

Nahri's stomach tied itself into a tight knot. She swallowed, resisting the urge to jerk back from the blade at her throat--no doubt such a motion would end poorly.

She thought fast. "You know . . . there was this other girl here. I bet she called you." She pointed down the opposite lane with one finger, trying to force some confidence into her voice. "She went that way."

"Liar!" he hissed, and the cold blade pressed closer. "Do you think I don't recognize your voice?"

Nahri panicked. She was normally good under pressure, but she had little practice outwitting enraged fire spirits. "I'm sorry!"

I-I just sang a song . . . I didn't mean to . . . ow!" she cried as he pressed the blade harder, nicking her neck.

He pulled it away and then brought it to his face, studying the smear of red blood on the blade's metal surface. He sniffed it, pressing it close against his face covering.

"Oh, God . . ." Nahri's stomach turned. Yaqub was right; she'd tangled with magic she didn't understand and now was going to pay for it. "Please . . . just make it quick." She tried to steady herself. "If you're going to eat me--"

"

Eat

you?" He made a disgusted sound. "The smell of your blood alone is enough to put me off eating for a month." He dropped the sword. "You smell dirt born. You're no illusion."

She blinked, but before she could question that bizarre proclamation, the ground gave a sudden and violent rumble.

He touched the tomb beside them and then gave the trembling headstones a distinctly nervous look. "Is this a burial ground?"

Nahri thought that fairly obvious. "The largest in Cairo."

"Then we don't have much time." He looked up and down the alley before turning back to her. "Answer me, and be quick and honest about it. Did you mean to call me here?"

"No."

"Do you have any other family here?"

How could that possibly be important?

"No, it's just me."

"And have you done anything like this before?" he demanded, his voice urgent. "Anything out of the ordinary?"

Only my whole life

. Nahri hesitated. But terrified as she was, the sound of her native language was intoxicating, and she didn't want the mysterious stranger to stop speaking.

And so the answer rushed out of her before she could think better of it. "I've never 'called anyone' before, but I heal. Like you saw." She touched the skin on her temple.

He stared at her face, his eyes growing so bright she had to look away. "Can you heal others?" He asked the question in a strangely soft and desperate tone, as if he both knew and feared the answer.

The ground buckled, and the headstone between them crumbled into dust. Nahri gasped and looked over the buildings surrounding them, suddenly aware of just how ancient and unsteady they appeared. "An earthquake . . ."

"We should be so fortunate." He deftly swept past the crumbled headstone and snatched her arm.

"Ya!" she protested; his hot touch burned through her thin sleeve. "Let me go!"

He gripped her tighter. "How do we get out of here?"

"I'm not going anywhere with you!" She tried to twist free and then froze.

Two thin, bowed figures stood at the end of one of the narrow cemetery paths. A third hung out a window, the smashed screen on the ground below. Nahri didn't need to listen for the absence of their heartbeats to know all three were dead. The tattered remains of burial shrouds hung from their desiccated frames, the scent of rot filling

the air.

"God be merciful," she whispered, her mouth going dry. "What-what are--"

"Ghouls," the man answered. He let go of her arm and shoved his sword in her hands. "Take this."

Nahri could barely lift the damned thing. She held it awkwardly in both hands as the man pulled free his bow and notched an
arrow.

"I see you've found my servants."

The voice came from behind them, young and girlish. Nahri whirled around. Baseema stood a few paces away.

The man had an arrow aimed at the young girl in the blink of an eye. "Ifrit," he hissed.

Baseema smiled politely. "Afshin," she greeted. "What a pleasant surprise. Last I heard, you were dead, having gone completely
insane in the service of your human masters."

He flinched and drew the bow back farther. "Go to hell, demon."

Baseema laughed. "Aye, there's no need for that. We're on the same side now, haven't you heard?" She grinned and drew nearer.
Nahri could see a malicious glint in her dark eyes. "Surely you'll do

anything

to help the newest Banu Nahida."

The newest

what

?

But the term must have meant something to the man: his hands trembled on the bow.

"The Nahids are dead," he said in a shaky voice. "You fiends killed them all."

Baseema shrugged. "We tried. All in the past now, I suppose." She winked at Nahri. "Come." She beckoned her forth. "There's
no reason to make this difficult."

The man--Afshin, Baseema had called him--stepped between them. "I will rip you from that poor child's body if you come any nearer."

Baseema gave a rude nod to the tombs. "Look around, you fool. Do you have any idea how many here owe debts to my kind? I have
but to say a word and you will both be devoured."

Devoured?

Nahri immediately stepped away from Afshin. "Wait! You know what? Maybe I should just--"

Something cold and sharp grabbed her ankle. She glanced down. A bony hand, the rest of its arm still buried, held her tight.

It yanked hard, and she tripped, falling just as an arrow whizzed over her head.

Nahri slashed at the skeletal hand with Afshin's sword, trying not to accidentally amputate her own foot. "Get off, get off!"

she shrieked, the sensation of bones on her skin causing every hair on her body to stand on end. From the corner of her eye, she saw Baseema collapse.

Afshin rushed to her side, pulling her to her feet as she crushed the hand holding her ankle with the hilt of the sword. She

twisted free and swung the sword. "You killed her!"

He jumped back to avoid the blade. "You were going to go over to her!" The ghouls moaned, and he snatched back the sword before

grabbing Nahri's hand. "There's no time to argue. Come on!"

They raced down the nearest lane as the ground shook. One of the tombs burst open, and two corpses flung themselves at Nahri.

Afshin's sword flashed, sending their heads tumbling.

He pulled her into a narrow alley. "We need to get out of here. The ghouls likely can't leave the burial ground."

"

Likely?

You mean there's a chance these things might get out and start feasting on everyone in Cairo?"

He looked thoughtful. "That would provide a distraction . . ." Perhaps noticing her horror, he quickly changed the subject.

"Either way, we need to leave."

"I . . ." She glanced around, but they were deep in the cemetery. "I don't know how."

He sighed. "Then we'll need to make our own exit." He jerked his head at the surrounding mausoleums. "Do you think I can find a rug in any of these buildings?"

"A

rug

? How is a rug going to help us?"

The headstones near them shuddered. He made a hushing noise. "Be quiet," he whispered. "You'll wake up more."

She swallowed hard, ready to throw her lot in with this Afshin if it was the best way to avoid becoming a meal for the dead.

"What do you need me to do?"

"Find a rug, a tapestry, curtains--something fabric and big enough for us both."

"But why--"

He cut her off, motioning with one finger toward the ghastly sounds coming from the opposite alley. "No more questions."

She studied the tombs. A broom rested outside one, and its wooden window screens looked new. It was large, probably the kind

that held a small room for visitors. "Let's try that one."

They crept down the alley. She tried the door, but it didn't budge.

"It's locked," she said. "Give me one of your daggers, I'll pick it."

He raised his palm. The door burst inward, wooden splinters spraying the ground. "Go, I'll guard the entrance."

Nahri glanced back. The noise had already drawn attention; a group of ghouls rushed in their direction. "Are they getting . . .

faster

?"

"The curse takes time to warm up."

She blanched. "You can't possibly kill them all."

He gave her a shove. "Then hurry!"

She scowled but hastily clambered over the ruined door. The tomb was even darker than the alley, the only illumination coming

from the moonlight that pierced the carved screens and threw elaborate designs on the floor.

Nahri let her eyes adjust. Her heart raced.

It's just like casing a house. You've done this a hundred times.

She knelt to run her hands over the contents of an open crate on the ground. Inside was a dusty pot and several cups, stacked

neatly inside each other, awaiting thirsty visitors. She moved forward. If the tomb

was set up for guests, there would be

a place to visit. And if God was kind and the family of this particular deceased respectable, they would have carpets there.

She moved farther inside, keeping one hand on the wall to orient herself as she tried to guess how the space was laid out.

Nahri had never been inside a tomb before; no one she knew would want someone like her anywhere near their ancestors' bones.

The guttural cry of a ghoul pierced the air, rapidly followed by a heavy thump against the outer wall. Moving more quickly,

she peered into the darkness, making out two separate rooms. The first had four heavy sarcophagi crammed inside, but the next

looked like it contained a tiny sitting area. Something was rolled up in one dark corner. She hurried over and touched it:

a carpet. Thank the Most High.

The rolled carpet was longer than she was, and heavy. Nahri dragged it through the tomb but had gotten only halfway when a

soft noise drew her attention. She glanced up, catching a mouthful of sandy dust as it blew past her face. More sand swept

past her feet, as if it was being sucked from the tomb.

It had grown eerily quiet. A little worried, Nahri dropped the carpet and peered through one of the window screens.

The smell of rot and decay nearly overwhelmed her, but she caught sight of Afshin, standing alone among a pile of bodies.

His bow was gone; in one hand he held the mace, covered in viscera, and in the other the sword, dark fluid dripping from the

gleaming steel. His shoulders were slumped, his head lowered in defeat. Down the lane, she could see more ghouls still coming.

By God, did everyone buried here owe a debt to a demon?

He tossed his weapons to the ground. "What are you doing?" she cried as he slowly raised his empty hands as if in prayer.

"There are more . . ." Her warning trailed off.

Every particle of sand, every mote of dust in sight, rushed to meet the motion of his hands, condensing and swirling into

a twisting funnel in the center of the lane. He took a deep breath and flung his hands outward.

The funnel exploded toward the rushing ghouls, a snap breaking across the air. Nahri felt a wave of pressure rock the wall,

sand blasting her from the open screen.

And they shall control the winds and be lords of the deserts. And any traveler who strays across their land shall be doomed . . .

The line came unbidden to her, something she'd heard during her years of pretending to be wise about the supernatural. There

was only one creature that line ever referred to, only one being that struck terror in hardened warriors and savvy merchants

from the Maghrib to the Hind. An ancient being said to live for deceiving and terrorizing mankind. A djinn.

Afshin was a djinn. An honest-to-goodness djinn.

It was a distracting realization, one that made her momentarily forget where she was. So when a bony hand yanked her back

and teeth sank into her shoulder, she was understandably caught off guard.

Nahri shouted, more in surprise than pain as the bite wasn't deep. She struggled to get the ghoul off her back, but it wrapped

its legs around her and knocked her to the ground, clinging to her body like a crab.

Managing to wrench an elbow free, she shoved it hard. The ghoul fell away but took a good piece of her shoulder with it. Nahri

gasped; the burn of exposed flesh sent spots blossoming across her vision.

The ghoul snapped at her neck, and she scrambled away. Its body wasn't too old; swollen flesh and a tattered burial shroud

still covered its limbs. But its eyes were a horrifying, pestilent wreck of writhing maggots.

Nahri sensed movement behind her too late. A second ghoul yanked her close, pinning her arms.

She screamed, "Afshin!"

The ghouls dragged her to the ground. The first ripped a gash in her abaya, raking sharp nails across her stomach. It sighed

with contentment as it ran a rough tongue over her bloodied skin, and her entire body shuddered in response, revulsion coursing

in her blood. She thrashed against them, finally succeeding in smashing her fist into the second ghoul's face as it leaned

in toward her neck. "Get off me!" she screamed. She tried to hit it again, but it grabbed her fist, wrenching her arm away.

Something popped in her elbow, but the pain barely registered.

Because at the same time, it tore into her throat.

Blood filled her mouth. Her eyes rolled back. The pain was receding, her sight dimming, so she didn't see the djinn approach,

only heard an enraged roar, the swoosh of a blade, and two thuds. One of the ghouls collapsed onto her.

Sticky, warm blood pooled on the floor beneath her body. "No . . . no, don't," she murmured as she was picked up off the floor

and carried out of the tomb. The night air chilled her skin.

She was on something soft and then suddenly weightless. There was the faint sensation of movement.

"Sorry, girl," a voice whispered, in a language that until today, Nahri had never heard another speak. "But you and I are not done."

3: Nahri

3

Nahri

Nahri knew something was wrong before she opened her eyes.

The sun was bright--too bright--against her still-closed lids, and her abaya clung wetly to her stomach. A gentle breeze played

across her face. She groaned and rolled over, trying to take refuge in her blanket.

Instead, she got a faceful of sand. Sputtering, she sat up and wiped her eyes. She blinked.

She was definitely not in Cairo.

A shady grove of date palms and scrubby brush surrounded her; rocky cliffs blocked part of the bright blue sky. Through the

trees, there was nothing but desert, gleaming golden sand in every direction.

And across from her was the djinn.

Crouched like a cat over the smoldering remains of a small fire--the sharp smell of burnt green wood filling the air--the djinn

stared at her with a sort of wary curiosity in his bright green eyes. A fine dagger, its handle set with a swirling pattern

of lapis and carnelians, was in one soot-covered hand. He trailed it across the sand as she watched, the blade glinting in

the sunlight. His other weapons were piled behind him.

Nahri snatched up the first stick her hand landed on and held it out in what she hoped was at least a somewhat menacing manner.

"Stay back," she warned.

He pursed his lips, clearly unimpressed. But the motion drew her attention to his mouth, and Nahri was startled by her first

good look at his uncovered face. Though there was nary a wing nor a horn in sight, his light brown skin shone with an unnatural

gleam, and his ears twisted into elongated points. Curly hair--as impossibly black as her own--fell to the top of his shoulders,

framing a sharply handsome face with long-lashed eyes and heavy brows. A black tattoo marked his left temple, a single arrow

crossed over a stylized wing. His skin was unlined, but there was something ageless about his jewel-bright gaze. He might

have been thirty or a hundred and thirty.

He was beautiful--strikingly,

frighteningly

beautiful, with the type of allure Nahri imagined a tiger held right before it ripped out your throat. Her heart skipped

a beat even as her stomach constricted in fear.

She closed her mouth, suddenly aware it had fallen open. "Wh-where have you taken me?" she stammered in--what had he called

her language again? Divasti? Right, that was it. Divasti.

He didn't take his eyes off her, his arresting face unreadable. "East."

"

East

?" she repeated.

The djinn tilted his head, staring at her like she was an idiot. "The opposite direction of the sun."

A spark of irritation lit inside her. "I know what the word means . . ." The djinn frowned at her tone, and Nahri gave the

dagger a nervous glance. "You . . . you're clearly occupied with that," she said in a more conciliatory tone, motioning to

the weapon as she climbed to her feet. "So why don't I just leave you alone and--"

"Sit."

"Really, it's no--"

"

Sit

."

Nahri dropped to the ground. But as the silence grew too long between them, she snapped, her nerves finally getting the better

of her. "I sat. So what now? Are you going to kill me like you killed Baseema or are we just going to stare at each other until I die of thirst?"

He pursed his lips again, and Nahri tried not to stare, feeling a sudden stab of sympathy for some of her more lovestruck

clients. But what he said next put such thoughts out of mind.

"What I did to that girl was a mercy. She was doomed the moment the ifrit possessed her: they burn through their hosts."

Nahri reeled.

Oh, God . . . Baseema, forgive me

. "I-I didn't mean to call it . . . to hurt her. I swear." She took a shaky breath. "When you killed her . . . did you kill the ifrit as well?"

"I tried. It may have escaped before she died."

She bit her lip, remembering Baseema's gentle smile and her mother's quiet strength. But she had to push away the guilt for now. "So . . . if that was an ifrit, then you're what? Some kind of djinn?"

He made a disgusted face. "I am no djinn, girl. I am Daeva." His mouth curled in contempt. "Daeva who call themselves djinn have no respect for our people. They are traitors, worthy only of annihilation."

The hatred in his voice sent a fresh rush of fear coursing through her body. "Oh," she choked out. She had little idea what the difference between the two was, but it seemed wise not to press the matter. "My mistake." She pressed her palms against her knees to hide their trembling. "Do . . . do you have a name?"

His bright eyes narrowed. "You should know better than to ask that."

"Why?"

"There is power in names. It's not something my people give out so freely."

"Baseema called you Afshin."

The daeva shook his head. "That's merely a title . . . and an old and rather useless one at that."

"So you won't tell me your actual name?"

"No."

He sounded even more hostile than he had last night. Nahri cleared her throat, trying to maintain her calm. "What do you want with me?"

He ignored the question. "You are thirsty?"

Thirsty was an understatement; Nahri's throat felt like sand had been poured down it, and considering the events of last night, there was a fair chance that was actually true. Her stomach rumbled as well, reminding her that she hadn't eaten anything in hours.

The daeva removed a waterskin from his robe, but when she reached for it, he held it back.

"I am going to ask you some questions
first. You will answer them. And

honestly

. You strike me as a liar."

You have no idea

. "Fine." She kept her tone even.

"Tell me of yourself. Your name, your family. Where your people are from."

She raised an eyebrow. "Why do you get to know my name if I can't know yours?"

"Because I have the water."

She scowled but decided to tell him the truth--for now. "My name is Nahri. I have no family. I have no idea where my people
are from."

"Nahri," he repeated, drawing the word out with a frown. "No family at all . . . you are certain?"

It was the second time he had asked about her family. "As far as I know."

"Then who taught you Divasti?"

"No one taught me. I think it's my native tongue. At least, I've always known it. Besides . . ."
Nahri hesitated. She never
spoke of these things, having learned the consequences as a child.

Oh, why not? Maybe he'll actually have some answers for me

. "I've been able to learn any language since I was a child," she added. "Every dialect. I can understand, and respond to,
any tongue spoken to me."

He sat back, inhaling sharply. "I can test that," he said. But not in Divasti, rather in a new language with oddly rounded,
high-pitched syllables.

She absorbed the sounds, letting them wash over her. The response came to her as soon as she opened her lips. "Go ahead."

He leaned forward, his eyes bright with challenge. "You look like an urchin who's been dragged through a charnel house."

This language was even stranger, musical and low, more like murmuring than speech. She glared back. "I wish someone would
drag you through a charnel house."

His eyes dimmed. "It is as you say then," he murmured in Divasti. "And you have no idea of your origins?"

She threw up her hands. "How many times must I say so?"

"Then what of your life now? How do you live? Are you married?" His expression darkened. "Do you have children?"

Nahri couldn't take her eyes off the waterskin. "Why do you care? Are you

married?" she shot back, annoyed. He glared. "Fine. I'm not married. I live alone. I work in an apothecary . . . as an assistant of sorts."

"Last night you mentioned lock picking."

Damn, he was observant. "Sometimes I take . . . alternative

. . . assignments to supplement my income."

The djinn--no, the daeva, she corrected herself--narrowed his eyes. "You're some kind of thief, then?"

"That's a very narrow-minded way of looking at it. I prefer to think of myself as a merchant of delicate tasks."

"That doesn't make you any less a criminal."

"Ah, and yet there's a fine difference between djinn and daeva?"

He glowered, the hem of his robe turning to smoke, and Nahri quickly changed the subject. "I do other things. Make amulets, provide some healing . . ."

He blinked, his eyes growing brighter, more intense. "So you can

heal others?" His voice turned hollow. "How?"

"I don't know," she admitted. "I can usually sense sickness better than I can heal it. Something will smell wrong, or there'll

be a shadow over the body part." She paused, trying to find the right words. "It's difficult to explain. I can deliver babies

well enough because I can sense their position. And when I lay my hands on people . . . I sort of wish them well . . . think about the parts fixing themselves; sometimes it works. Sometimes it doesn't."

His face grew stormier as she spoke. He crossed his arms; the outline of well-muscled limbs pressed against the smoky fabric.

"And those you can't heal . . . I assume you reimburse them?"

She started to laugh and then realized he was serious. "Sure."

"This is impossible," he declared. He rose to his feet, pacing away with a grace that belied his true nature. "The Nahids
would never . . . not with a human."

Taking advantage of his distraction, Nahri snatched the waterskin off the ground and ripped out the plug. The water was delicious,
crisp and sweet, like nothing she'd ever tasted.

The daeva turned back to her. "So you just live quietly with these powers?" he demanded. "Haven't you ever wondered why you
have them? Suleiman's eye . . . you could be overthrowing governments, and instead you steal from peasants!"

His words enraged her. She dropped the skin. "I do not
steal

from peasants," she snapped. "And you know nothing of my world, so don't judge me. You try living on the streets when you're
five and speak a language no one understands. When you get thrown out of every orphanage after predicting which child will
die next of consumption and telling the mistress that she has a shadow growing in her head." She seethed, briefly overcome
by her memories. "I do what I need to survive."

"And calling me?" he asked, no apology in his voice. "Did you do that to survive?"

"No, I did that as part of some foolish ceremony." She paused. Not so foolish after all; Yaqub had been right about the dangers
of interfering with traditions that weren't her own. "I sang one of the songs in Divasti--I had no idea what would happen."

Saying it aloud did little to alleviate the guilt she felt about Baseema, but she pressed on. "Aside from what I can do, I've
never seen anything else strange. Nothing magical, certainly nothing like
you

. I didn't think such things existed."

"Well, that was idiotic." She glared at him, but he only shrugged. "Were your own abilities not evidence enough?"

She shook her head. "You don't understand." He couldn't. He hadn't lived her life, the

constant rush of business she had to

bring in to keep herself afloat, her bribes paid. There wasn't time for anything else. All that mattered were the coins in her hand, the only true power she had.

And speaking of which

. . . Nahri looked around. "The basket I was carrying--where is it?" At his blank look, she panicked. "Don't tell me you left it behind!" She jumped to her feet to search but saw nothing besides the rug spread out in the shade of a large tree.

"We were fleeing for our lives," he said sarcastically. "Did you expect me to waste time accounting for your belongings?"

Her hands flew to her temples. She'd lost a small fortune in a night. And she had even more to lose stashed in her stall back

home. Nahri's heart quickened; she needed to return to Cairo. Between whatever rumors would undoubtedly fly around after the zar and her absence, it wouldn't be long before her landlord sacked the place.

"I need to get back," she said. "Please. I didn't mean to call you. And I'm grateful you saved me from the ghouls," she added, figuring a little appreciation couldn't hurt. "But I just want to go home."

A dark look crossed his face. "Oh, you're going home, I suspect. But it won't be to Cairo."

"Excuse me?"

He was already walking away. "You can't go back to the human world." He sat heavily on the carpet under the shade of a tree

and pulled off his boots. He seemed to have aged during their brief conversation, his face shadowed by exhaustion. "It's against our law, and the ifrit are likely already tracking you. You wouldn't last a day."

"That's not your problem!"

"It is." He lay down, crossing his arms behind his head. "As are you, unfortunately."

A chill went down Nahri's back. The pointed questions about her family, the barely concealed disappointment when he learned

of her abilities. "What do you know about me? Do you know why I can do these things?"

He shrugged. "I have my suspicions."

"Which

are

?" she prodded when he fell silent. "Tell me."

"Will you stop pestering me if I do?"

No

. She nodded. "Yes."

"I think you're a shafit."

He had called her that in the cemetery too. But the word remained unfamiliar. "What's a shafit?"

"It's what we call someone with mixed blood. It's what happens when my race gets a bit . . .

indulgent

around humans."

"Indulgent?" She gasped, the meaning of his words becoming clear. "You think I have daeva blood? That I'm like you?"

"Believe me when I say I find such a thing equally distressing." He clucked his tongue in disapproval. "I never would have

thought a Nahid capable of such a transgression."

Nahri was growing more confused by the minute. "What's a Nahid? Baseema called me something like that too, didn't she?"

A muscle twitched in his jaw, and she caught a flicker of emotion in his eyes. It was brief, but it was there. He cleared

his throat. "It's a family name," he finally answered. "The Nahids are a family of daeva healers."

Daeva

healers

? Nahri gaped, but before she could respond, he waved her off.

"No. I told you what I think, and you promised to leave me alone. I need to rest. I did a lot of magic last night and I want

to be ready should the ifrit come sniffing for you again."

Nahri shuddered, her hand instinctively going to her throat. "What do you mean to do with me?"

He made an irritated sound and reached into his pocket. Nahri jumped, expecting a weapon, but instead he pulled free a pile

of clothing that looked too big to have fit the space and tossed it in her direction without opening his eyes. "There is a

pool near the cliff. I suggest you visit it. You smell even viler than the rest of your kind."

"You didn't answer my question."

"Because I don't know yet." She could hear the uncertainty in his voice. "I've called someone for help. We will wait."

Just what she needed--a second djinn to weigh in on her fate. She picked up the bundle of clothes. "Aren't you worried I'll
escape?"

He let out a drowsy laugh. "Good luck getting out of the desert."

The oasis was small, and it wasn't long before she came upon the pool he had mentioned, a shadowy pond fed by the steady trickle
of springs from a rocky ledge and surrounded by scrubby brush. She saw no sign of horses or camels; she couldn't imagine how
they'd gotten here.

With a shrug, Nahri pulled off her ruined abaya, stepped in, and submerged.

The press of the cool water was like the touch of a friend. She closed her eyes, trying to digest the madness of the past
day. She'd been kidnapped by a djinn. A daeva. Whatever. A magical creature with too many weapons who didn't seem particularly
enamored of her.

She drifted on her back, tracing shapes in the water and staring at the palm-fringed sky.

He thinks I have daeva blood

. The idea that she was in any way related to the creature who'd summoned a sandstorm last night seemed laughable, but he
had a point about ignoring the implications of her healing abilities. Nahri had spent her entire life trying to blend in with
those around her just to survive. Those instincts were warring even now: her thrill at learning what she was and her urge
to flee back to the life she'd worked so hard to establish for herself in Cairo.

But she knew her odds of surviving the desert alone were low, so she tried to relax, enjoying the pool until her fingertips
wrinkled. She scoured her skin with a palm husk and massaged her hair in the water, relishing the sensation of being clean.

It wasn't often she got to bathe--back home, the women at the local hammam made it clear she was unwelcome, perhaps fearing
she'd put a hex on the bathwater.

There was little that could be done to save her abaya, but she washed what remained, stretching it out on a sunny rock to

dry before turning her attention to the clothing the daeva had given her.

It was obviously his; it smelled of burnt citrus and was cut to accommodate a muscular man, not a chronically famished woman.

Nahri rubbed the ash-colored fabric between her fingers and marveled at its quality. It was soft as silk, yet sturdy as felt.

It was also completely seamless; try as she might, she couldn't find a single stitch. She could likely sell it for a good sum if she escaped.

It took effort to get the clothes to fit; the tunic hung comically large around her waist and ended past her knees. She rolled

the sleeves up as best she could and then turned her attention to the pants. After ripping a strip from her abaya to use as

a belt and rolling up the hems, they stayed on reasonably well, but she could only imagine how ridiculous she looked.

With a sharp rock, she cut a longer section of her abaya for a headscarf. Her hair had dried in a wild mess of black curls

that she attempted to braid before tying the makeshift scarf around her head. She drank her fill from the waterskin--it seemed

to refill on its own--but the water did little to help the hunger gnawing at her stomach.

The palm trees were thick with swollen gold dates, and overripe ones, covered in ants, littered the ground. She tried everything

she could think of to get at the ones in the trees: shaking the trunks, throwing rocks, even a particularly ill-fated attempt at climbing, but nothing worked.

Did daevas eat? If so, he must have some food, probably hidden in that robe of his. Nahri made her way back to the small grove.

The sun had risen, hot and searing, and she hissed as she crossed a patch of scorched sand. God only knew what had happened to her sandals.

The daeva was still asleep; his gray cap was tipped over his eyes, his chest slowly rising and falling in the fading light.

Nahri crept closer, studying him in a way she'd been too wary to do before. His robe rippled in the breeze, undulating like

smoke, and hazy heat drifted from his body as though he was a hot stone oven. Fascinated, she moved even closer. She wondered

if daeva bodies were like those of humans: full of blood and humors, a beating heart and swelling lungs. Or perhaps they were

smoke through and through, their appearance only an illusion.

Closing her eyes, she stretched her fingers toward him and tried to concentrate. It would have been better to touch him, but

she didn't dare. He struck her as the type to wake in a foul mood.

After a few minutes, she stopped, growing disturbed. There was nothing. No beating heart, no surging blood and bile. She could

sense no organs, nothing of the sparks and gurgles of the hundreds of natural processes that kept her and every other person

she'd ever met alive. Even his breathing was wrong, the movement of his chest false. It was as though someone had created

an image of a person, a man out of clay, but forgotten to give it a final spark of life. He was . . . unfinished.

Not an ill-formed piece of clay, though . . .

Nahri's gaze lingered on his body, and then she stilled, catching sight of a green flash on the daeva's left hand.

"God be praised," she whispered. An enormous emerald ring--large enough for a sultan--rested on the daeva's middle finger. The

base looked to be badly battered iron, but she could tell from a single glance that the jewel was priceless. Dusty but perfectly cut, with not a single blemish. Something like that had to be worth a fortune.

As Nahri contemplated the ring, a shadow passed overhead. Idly, she glanced up. Then, with a yelp, she dove into the thick brush to hide.

Nahri peeked through a screen of leaves as the creature flew across the oasis, enormous against the spindly trees, and then

landed next to the sleeping daeva. It was something only a deviant mind could dream up, an unholy cross between an old man,

a green parrot, and a mosquito. All bird from the chest down, it bobbed like a chicken as it moved forward on a pair of thick,

feathered legs ending in sharp talons. The rest of its skin--if it could be called skin--was covered in silvery gray scales

that flashed as it moved, reflecting the light of the setting sun.

It paused to stretch a pair of feathered arms. Its wings were extraordinary, the brilliant, lime-colored feathers nearly as

long as she was tall. Nahri started to rise, wondering whether to warn the daeva. The creature was focused on him and seemingly

oblivious to her, a situation she preferred. Yet if it killed him, there'd be no one to get her out of the desert.

The birdman let out a chirp that made every hair on her body rise, and the sound roused the daeva, solving her problem. He

blinked his emerald eyes slowly, shading his face to see who stood before him. "Khayzur . . ." He exhaled. "By the Creator, am I glad to see you."

The creature extended a delicate hand and pulled the daeva into a brotherly embrace. Nahri's eyes widened. Was

this

the person the daeva had been waiting for?

They settled themselves back on the rug. "I came as soon as I got your signal," the creature squawked. Whatever language they

were speaking it wasn't Divasti; it was full of staccato bursts and low whoops like birdsong. "What's wrong, Dara?"

The daeva's expression soured. "It's better seen than explained." He glanced about the oasis, and his eyes locked on Nahri's

hiding spot. "Come on out, girl."

Nahri bristled, annoyed to be found so easily and then ordered about like a dog. But she emerged anyway, shoving the leaves

aside and coming forward to join them.

She stifled a gasp when the birdman turned to her--the gray tone of his skin reminded her far too much of the ghouls. It was

at odds with his small, almost pretty pink mouth and the neat green brows that met in the middle of his forehead. His eyes were colorless, and he had just the barest wisps of a gray beard.

He gaped, looking equally surprised at the sight of her. "You . . . you've a companion," he said to the daeva. "Not that I'm

displeased, but I must say, Dara . . . I did not take humans as your type."

"She's not my companion." The daeva scowled. "And she's not entirely human. She's shafit. She . . ." He cleared his throat,

his voice suddenly strained. "She would appear to have some Nahid blood."

The creature whirled around. "Why do you think that?"

The daeva's mouth twisted in distaste. "She healed before my eyes. Twice. And she has their gift with languages."

"The Maker be praised." Khayzur lurched closer, and Nahri skittered back. His colorless eyes swept her face. "I thought the

Nahids were wiped out years ago."

"As did I," the daeva said. He sounded unnerved. "And to heal the way she did . . . she can't merely be a distant descendant.

But she looks entirely human--I plucked her from some human city even farther west than we are now." The daeva shook his head.

"Something's wrong, Khayzur. She claims she knew nothing of our world until last night, but she somehow dragged me halfway across the--"

"

She

can speak for herself," Nahri said acidly. "And I didn't mean to drag you anywhere! I'd have been happier never to have met you."

He snorted. "You'd have been murdered by that ifrit if I hadn't shown up."

Khayzur abruptly raised his hands to silence them. "The ifrit know about her?" he asked sharply.

"More than I do," the daeva admitted. "One showed up just before I did and wasn't at all surprised to see her. That's why

I called you." He waved his hand. "You peris always know more than the rest of us."

Khayzur's wings drooped. "Not on this matter--though I wish I did. You're right, the circumstances are strange." He pinched

the bridge of his nose, the gesture oddly human. "I need a cup of tea." He abruptly returned to the rug, motioning for Nahri to follow. "Come, child."

He dropped into a half perch, and a large samovar, fragrant with peppercorns and mace, suddenly appeared in his hands. He

snapped his fingers, and three glass cups appeared. He filled them and handed her the first.

She examined the cup in awe; the glass was so thin it seemed almost like the steaming tea floated in her hand. "What

are

you?"

He gave her a gentle smile that revealed sharply pointed teeth. "I am a peri. My name is Khayzur." He touched his brow. "An honor to meet you, my lady."

Well, whatever a peri was, they clearly had better manners than daevas. Nahri took a sip of her tea. It was thick and peppery,

burning down her throat in an oddly pleasant way. In an instant, her whole body felt suffused with warmth--and more important, her hunger was sated.

"That's delicious!" She smiled, her skin tingling from the liquid.

"My own recipe," Khayzur said proudly. He gave a sidelong glance at the daeva and nodded to the third cup. "If you'd like to stop glowering and join us, that's yours, Dara."

Dara. It was the third time the peri had called him that. She flashed him a triumphant smile. "Yes,

Dara

," she said, all but purring his name. "Why don't you join us?"

He threw her a dark look. "I'd prefer something stronger." But he took the cup and dropped down beside her.

The peri sipped his tea. "Do you think the ifrit will come after her?"

Dara nodded. "It was hell-bent on taking her. I tried to kill it before it abandoned its host, but there's a good chance it escaped."

"Then it may have already told its fellows." Khayzur shuddered. "You've no time to puzzle out her origins, Dara. You need to get her to Daevabad as soon as possible."

Dara was already shaking his head. "I can't. I won't

. Suleiman's eye, do you know what the djinn would say if I brought in a Nahid shafit?"

"That your Nahids were hypocrites," Khayzur replied. Dara's eyes flashed. "And what of it? Is saving her life not worth embarrassing her ancestors?"

Nahri certainly thought her life was a hell of a lot more important than the reputation of some dead daeva relatives, but

Dara didn't look convinced. "You could take her," he urged the peri. "Leave her at the banks of the Gozan."

"And hope she finds her way past the veil? Hope the Qahtani family believes the word of some lost, human-looking girl should

she somehow make it to the palace?" Khayzur looked appalled. "You are an Afshin, Dara. Her life is your responsibility."

"Which is why she'd be better off in Daevabad without me," Dara argued. "Those sand flies would likely murder her just to
punish me for the war."

The

war

? "Wait," Nahri cut in, not liking the sound of this Daevabad at all. "What war?"

"One that ended fourteen centuries ago and over which he's still holding a grudge," Khayzur answered. At that, Dara knocked

over his teacup and stalked off. "A skill at which he's most adept," the peri added. The daeva threw him a jewel-eyed glare,

but the peri pressed on. "You're only one man, Dara; you can't hold the ifrit off forever. They will kill her if they find

her. Slowly and gleefully." Nahri shivered, a prickle of fear running over her skin. "And it will be entirely your fault."

Dara paced the edge of the rug. Nahri spoke up again, not particularly keen on a pair of bickering magical beings deciding

her fate without any input from her.

"Why would this Daevabad be safer than Cairo?"

"Daevabad is your family's ancestral home," Khayzur replied. "No ifrit can pass its veil--none can, save your race."

She glanced at Dara. The daeva stared out at the setting sun, muttering angrily under his breath as smoke curled around his

ears. "So it's full of people like him?"

The peri gave her a weak smile. "I'm sure you will find a greater . . .

breadth

of temperaments in the city itself."

How encouraging

. "Why are the ifrit after me in the first place?"

Khayzur hesitated. "I'm afraid I'll have to leave that explanation to your Afshin. It's a lengthy one."

My

Afshin? Nahri wanted to ask. But Khayzur had already turned his attention back to Dara.

"Have you come to your senses yet?

Or do you intend to let this nonsense over blood purity ruin another life?"

"No," the daeva grumbled, but she could hear the indecision in his voice. He clasped his hands behind his back, refusing to
look at either of them.

"By the Maker . . . go

home

, Dara," Khayzur urged. "Have you not suffered enough for this ancient war? The rest of the Daeva tribe made peace long ago.

Why can't you?"

Dara twisted his ring, his hands trembling. "Because they didn't witness it," he said softly.

"But you are correct about the

ifrit." He sighed and turned around, his face still troubled. "The girl is safest--from them anyway--in Daevabad."

"Good." Khayzur looked relieved. He snapped his fingers, and the tea supplies disappeared. "Then go. Travel as fast as you

can. But discreetly." He pointed to the rug. "Do not overly rely on this. Whoever sold it to you did a terrible job on the

charm. The ifrit might be able to track it."

Dara scowled again. "

I

did the charm."

The peri lifted his delicate brows. "Well . . . then perhaps keep those close," he suggested with a nod to the weapons piled

under the tree. He rose to his feet, shaking out his wings. "I will not delay you further. But I'll see what I can learn of

the girl--should it be useful, I'll try to find you." He bowed in Nahri's direction. "An honor to meet you, Nahri. Good luck

to you both."

With a single flap of his wings, he rose in the air and vanished into the crimson sky.

Dara stepped into his boots and swung the silver bow over one shoulder before smoothing the carpet out. "Let's go," he said,

tossing his other weapons onto the rug.

"Let's

talk

," she countered, crossing her legs. She wasn't moving from the carpet. "I'm not going anywhere until I get some answers."

"No." He dropped beside her on the rug, his voice firm. "I saved your life. I'm escorting you to the city of my enemies. That's

enough. You can find someone in Daevabad to bother with your questions." He sighed. "I suspect this journey will already be long enough."

Enraged, Nahri opened her mouth to argue and then stopped, realizing the rug now held all their supplies, as well as she and

Dara both.

No horses. No camels

. Her heart skipped a beat. "We're not really going to--"

Dara snapped his fingers, and the carpet shot into the air.

4: Ali

4

Ali

It was a miserable morning in Daevabad.

Though the adhan, the call to dawn prayer, rang out across the wet air, there was no sign of the sun in the misty sky. Fog

shrouded the great city of brass, obscuring its towering minarets of sandblasted glass and hammered metal and veiling its

golden domes. Rain seeped off the jade roofs of marble palaces and flooded its stone streets, condensing on the placid faces

of its ancient Nahid founders memorialized on the murals covering its mighty walls.

A chilly breeze swept through the winding streets, past intricately tiled bathhouses and the thick doors protecting fire temples

whose altars had burned for millennia, bringing the smell of damp earth and tree sap from the thickly forested mountains that

surrounded the island. It was the type of morning that sent most djinn scurrying indoors like cats fleeing rain, back to beds

of smoky silk brocade and warm mates, burning away the hours until the sun reemerged hot and proper to scald the city to life.

Prince Alizayd al Qahtani was not one of them. He pulled the tail of his turban across his face and shivered, hunching his

shoulders against the cold rain as he walked. His breath came in a steamy hush, the sound amplified against the damp cloth.

Rain dripped from his brow, evaporating as it crossed his smoky skin.

He went over the charges again in his mind.

You have to talk to him

, he told himself.

You have no choice. The rumors are getting out of hand

.

Ali stuck to the shadows as he neared the Grand Bazaar. Even at this early hour, the bazaar would be busy: sleepy merchants

undoing the curses that had protected their wares throughout the night, apothecaries brewing potions to energize their first

customers, children carrying messages made of burnt glass that shattered upon revealing their words--not to mention the bodies

of barely conscious addicts wasted on smuggled human intoxicants. With little desire to be seen by any of them, Ali turned

down a dark lane, a detour that took him so deep into the city that he could no longer glimpse the tall brass walls that enclosed it.

The neighborhood he entered was an old one, crowded with ancient buildings mimicking human architecture lost to time: columns

carved with Nabatean graffiti, friezes of Etruscan satyrs, and intricate Mauryan stupas. Civilizations long dead, their memory

captured by the curious djinn who'd passed through--or by nostalgic shafit trying to re-create their lost homes.

A large stone mosque with a striking spiral minaret and black and white archways stood at the end of the street. One of the

few places in Daevabad where djinn purebloods and shafit still worshipped together, the mosque's popularity with traders and

travelers from the Grand Bazaar made for an unusually transient community . . . and a good place to be invisible.

Ali ducked inside, eager to escape the rain. He'd no sooner slipped off his sandals than they were snatched away by a zealous

ishtas, the small, scaled creatures obsessed with organization and footwear. For a bit of fruit and negotiation, Ali's shoes

would be returned to him after prayer, scrubbed and fragrant with sandalwood. He continued, passing a pair of matching marble

ablution fountains, one flowing with water for the shafit while its partner swirled with the warm black sand most purebloods preferred.

One of the oldest in Daevabad, the mosque consisted of four covered halls enclosing a courtyard open to the gray sky. Worn

down by the feet and brows of centuries of worshippers, its red and gold carpet was thin but immaculate--whatever self-cleaning

enchancements had been woven in with its threads still held. Large, hazy glass lanterns filled with enchanted flames hung from

the ceiling, and nuggets of frankincense smoldered in corner braziers.

It was mostly empty this morning, the benefits of communal prayer perhaps not outweighing the vile weather for many of its

usual congregants. Ali took a deep breath of the fragrant air as he scanned the scattered worshippers, but the man he was

looking for had yet to arrive.

Maybe he's been arrested

. Ali tried to dismiss the dark thought as he approached the gray marble mihrab, the niche in the wall indicating the direction

of prayer. He raised his hands. Despite his nerves, as Ali began to pray, he felt a small measure of peace. He always did.

But it didn't last long. He was finishing his second rakat of prayer when a man knelt quietly beside him. Ali stilled.

"Peace be upon you, brother," the man whispered.

Ali avoided his gaze. "And upon you peace," he said softly.

"Were you able to get it?"

Ali hesitated. "It" was the fat purse concealed in his robe that contained a small fortune from his overflowing personal vault

at the Treasury. "Yes. But we need to talk."

From the corner of his eye, Ali saw his companion frown, but before he could respond, the mosque's imam approached the mihrab.

He gave the rain-damp group of men a weary look. "Straighten your lines," he admonished. Ali stood as the dozen or so sleepy

worshippers shuffled into place. He tried to concentrate while the imam led them in prayer, but it was difficult. Rumors and

accusations swirled in his mind, charges he felt ill-prepared to lay on the man whose shoulder brushed his.

When prayer was over, Ali and his companion stayed seated, silently waiting as the rest of the worshippers filed out. The

imam was last. He climbed to his feet, muttering under his breath. As he glanced at the two remaining men, he froze.

Ali dropped his gaze, letting his turban shadow his face, but the imam's attention was focused on his companion. "Sheikh Anas . . .

," he gasped. "P-peace be upon you."

"And upon you peace," Anas replied calmly. He touched his heart and gestured to Ali.

"Would you mind giving the brother here

and me a moment alone?"

"Of course," the imam rushed on. "Take all the time you need; I'll make sure no one disturbs you." He hurried out, pulling

the inner door shut.

Ali waited another moment before speaking, but they were alone, the only sound the steady patter of rain in the courtyard.

"Your reputation grows," he noted, a little unnerved by the imam's deference.

Anas shrugged and leaned back on his palms. "Or he's off to warn the Royal Guard."

Ali startled. His sheikh smiled. Though Anas Bhatt was in his fifties--an age at which pureblooded djinn were still considered

young adults--Anas was shafit, and gray dusted his black beard, lines creasing his eyes. Though there must have been a drop

or two of djinn blood in his veins--his ancestors couldn't have crossed into Daevabad without it--Anas could have passed for

human and had no magical abilities. He was dressed in a white kurta and embroidered cap and had a thick Kashmiri shawl wrapped around his shoulders.

"It was a jest, my prince," he added when Ali didn't return his smile. "But what's wrong, brother? You look as though you've seen an ifrit."

I'd take an ifrit over my father

. Ali scanned the dark mosque, half-expecting to see spies nestled in its shadows. "Sheikh, I'm starting to hear . . . certain

things

about the Tanzeem again."

Anas sighed. "What is the palace claiming we did now?"

"Tried to smuggle a cannon past the Royal Guard."

"A cannon?" Anas gave him a skeptical look. "What would I do with a cannon, brother? I'm shafit. I know the law. Possessing

even an overly large kitchen knife would get me thrown in prison. And the Tanzeem are a charitable organization; we deal in

books and food, not weapons. Besides, how would you purebloods know what a cannon looks like anyway?" He scoffed. "When's

the last time someone in the Citadel visited the human world?"

He had a point there, but Ali pressed on. "There've been reports for months that the Tanzeem is trying to buy weapons. People

say your rallies have grown violent, that some of your supporters are even calling for the Daevas to be killed."

"Who spreads such lies?" Anas demanded. "That Daeva infidel your father calls the grand wazir?"

"It's not just Kaveh," Ali argued. "We arrested a shafit man just last week for stabbing two purebloods in the Grand Bazaar."

"And I'm responsible?" Anas threw up his hands. "Am I to be called to account for the

actions of every shafit man in Daevabad?

You know how desperate our lives are here, Alizayd. Your people should be happy more of us haven't resorted to violence!"

Ali recoiled. "Are you condoning such a thing?"

"Of course not," Anas replied, sounding annoyed. "Don't be absurd. But when our girls are snatched off the street to be used

as bed slaves, when our men are blinded for looking at a pureblood the wrong way . . . is it not to be expected that some

will fight back any way they can?" He gave Ali an even stare. "It's your father's fault things have gotten this bad--if the

shafit were afforded equal protection, we wouldn't be forced to take the law into our own hands."

It was a low, albeit justified, blow, but Anas's angry denial wasn't doing much to assuage Ali's concerns. "I was always clear

with you, Sheikh. Money for books, food, medicine, anything like that . . . but if your people are taking up arms against

my father's citizens, I can't be part of that. I won't."

Anas raised a dark eyebrow. "What are you saying?"

"I want to see how you're spending my money. Surely you've kept some type of records."
"

Records?

"His sheikh looked incredulous . . . and then offended. "Is my word not enough? I run a school, an orphanage, a medical clinic . . .

I have widows to house and students to teach. A thousand responsibilities and now you want me to waste time on what exactly . . .

an audit from my teenage patron who fancies himself an accountant?"

Ali's cheeks burned, but he wasn't backing down. "Yes." He pulled the purse from his robe. The coins and jewels inside jingled

together when they hit the ground. "Otherwise this will be the last of it." He rose to his feet.

"Alizayd," Anas called. "Brother." His sheikh scrambled to his feet, putting himself between Ali and the door. "You're acting rashly."

No, I was acting rashly when I started funding a shafit street preacher without checking into his story

, Ali wanted to say, but he held his tongue, avoiding the older man's eyes. "I'm sorry,

Sheikh."

Anas's hand shot out. "Just wait. Please." There was an edge of panic in his normally calm voice. "What if I could show you?"

"Show me?"

Anas nodded. "Yes," he said, his voice growing firm, as if he had come to a decision. "Can you get away from the Citadel again tonight?"

"I-I suppose." Ali frowned. "But I don't see what that has to do with--"

The sheikh cut him off. "Then meet me at Daeva Gate tonight, after isha prayer." He glanced down Ali's body. "Dress as a nobleman from your mother's tribe, with all the finery you have to spare. You'll easily pass."

Ali flinched at the comment. "That doesn't--"

"You will learn tonight what my organization does with your money."

Ali followed his sheikh's instructions exactly, slipping out after isha prayer with a bundle tucked under one arm. After taking

a circuitous route through the Grand Bazaar, he ducked into a dark, windowless lane. He unrolled the bundle--one of the rich

teal robes the Ayaanle, his mother's kinsmen, were fond of--and pulled it on over his uniform.

A turban of the same color went on next, wrapped loosely around his neck in Ayaanle fashion, and then a deeply ostentatious

collar of gold worked with corals and pearls. Ali hated jewelry--truly a more useless waste of resources had never been devised--but

he knew that no Ayaanle nobleman worth his salt would dare go out unadorned. Though his vault brimmed with treasure from his

mother's wealthy homeland of Ta Ntry, the collar had already been on hand, some family heirloom his sister Zaynab had insisted

he wear to an Ayaanle wedding he'd been forced to attend a few months ago.

Finally, he pulled a tiny glass vial from his pocket. A potion that looked like swirled cream churned inside, a cosmetic enchantment

that would turn his eyes the bright gold of an Ayaanle man for a few hours. Ali hesitated; he didn't want to change the color

of his eyes, not for a moment.

There weren't many people in Daevabad like Ali and his sister, pureblooded djinn nobles of mixed tribal heritage. Separated

into six tribes by the human prophet-king Suleiman himself, most djinn preferred the company of their kinsmen; indeed, Suleiman

had supposedly divided them with the express purpose of causing as much dissent as possible. The more time djinn spent fighting each other, the less they spent harassing humans.

But Ali's parents' marriage had been equally purposeful, a political match meant to strengthen the alliance between the Geziri

and the Ayaanle tribes. It was a strange, often strained, alliance. The Ayaanle were a wealthy people who prized scholarship

and trade, rarely leaving the fine coral palaces and sophisticated salons of Ta Ntry, their homeland on the East African coast.

In contrast, Am Gezira, with its heart in the most desolate deserts of southern Arabia, must have seemed a wasteland, its

forbidding sands filled with wandering poets and illiterate warriors.

And yet Am Gezira owned Ali's heart completely. He'd always preferred the Geziri, an allegiance his appearance thoroughly

mocked. Ali resembled his mother's people so strikingly that it would have provoked gossip had his father not been king. He

shared their lanky height and black skin, his stern mouth and sharp cheeks near replicas of his mother's. All he'd inherited

from his father was his dark steel eyes. And tonight, he'd have to give even those up.

Ali opened the vial and tapped a few drops into each eye. He bit back a curse. God, it burned. He'd been warned that it would,

but the pain took him aback.

He made his bleary-eyed way to the midan, the central plaza at Daevabad's heart. It was empty at this late hour; the neglected

fountain in its center cast wild shadows on the ground. The midan was enclosed by a copper wall gone green with age, the wall

in turn broken up by seven equally spaced gates. Each gate led to a different tribal district with the seventh opening into

the Grand Bazaar and its overcrowded shafit neighborhoods.

The midan's gates were always a sight to behold. There was the Sahrayn Gate, black-and-white-tiled pillars wrapped in grapevines

heavy with purple fruit. Beside it was that of the Ayaanle, two narrow, studded pyramids crowned with a scroll and a salt

tablet. The Geziri Gate was next, nothing but a perfectly cut stone archway, his father's people preferring function over

form as always. It looked even plainer beside the richly decorated Agnivanshi Gate with its rose-colored sandstone sculpted

into dozens of dancing figures, their delicate hands holding flickering oil lamps so small that they resembled stars. Next

to that was the Tukharistani Gate, a screen of polished jade reflecting the night sky, carved in an impossibly intricate pattern.

And yet impressive as they all were, the final gate--the gate that would catch the first rays of sunlight each morning, the gate of Daevabad's original people--outshone them all.

The Daeva Gate.

The entrance to the Daevas' quarter--for the fire worshippers had arrogantly taken their race's original name as their own

tribal one--sat directly across from the Grand Bazaar, its enormous paneled doors painted a pale blue that could have been

plucked directly from a fresh-washed sky, and embedded with white and gold sandstone disks set in a triangular pattern. The

doors were held open by two massive brass shedu, the statues all that were left of the mythical winged lions the ancient Nahids

were said to have ridden into battle against the ifrit.

He made his way toward the entrance, but he'd barely gotten halfway there when two figures stepped out from beneath the gate's

shadow. Ali stopped. One of the men quickly raised his hands and moved into the moonlight. Anas.

His sheikh smiled. "Peace be upon you, brother." He was dressed in a homespun tunic the color of dirty wash water, his head

uncharacteristically bare.

"And upon you peace." Ali eyed the second man. He was shafit--that much was apparent from his rounded ears--but looked Sahrayn,

with the North African tribe's fiery red-black hair and copper eyes. He wore a striped galabiyya, its tasseled hood half drawn.

The man's eyes widened at the sight of Ali. "

This

is your new recruit?" He laughed. "Are we so desperate for fighters that we're taking crocodiles barely out of their shell?"

Outraged by the slur against his Ayaanle blood, Ali opened his mouth to protest, but Anas cut in. "Watch your tongue, Brother

Hanno," he warned. "We are all djinn here."

Hanno didn't look bothered by the admonishment. "Does he have a name?"

"Not one that concerns you," Anas said firmly. "He's here merely to observe." He nodded at Hanno. "So go on. I know you like

to show off."

The other man chuckled. "Fair enough." He clapped his hands, and a swirl of smoke shrouded his body. When it dissipated, his

dirty galabiyya had been replaced by an iridescent shawl, a mustard-colored turban decorated with pheasant feathers, and a

bright green dhoti, the waist cloth typically worn by Agnivanshi men. As Ali watched, his ears lengthened, and his skin brightened

to a dark, luminous brown. Black braids crawled out from under his turban, stretching to sweep the hilt of the Hindustani

talwar now sheathed at his waist. He blinked, his copper eyes turning the tin color of an Agnivanshi pureblood. A steel relic

band clanged into place around his wrist.

Ali's mouth fell open. "You're a

shapeshifter

?" he gasped, hardly believing the sight before him. Shape-shifting was an incredibly rare ability, one which only a few families

in each tribe possessed and even fewer managed to master. Talented shapeshifters were worth their weight in gold. "By the

Most High . . . I didn't think the shafit even capable of such advanced magic."

Hanno snorted. "You purebloods always underestimate us."

"But . . ." Ali was still stunned. ". . . if you can look pureblooded, why even live as shafit?"

The humor vanished from Hanno's new face. "Because I

am

shafit. That I can wield my magic better than a pureblood, that the sheikh here could spin intellectual circles around the

scholars of the Royal Library--that is proof that we're not so different from the rest of you." He glared at Ali. "It's not

a thing I mean to hide."

Ali felt like a fool. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean--"

"It's fine," Anas interrupted. He took Ali's arm. "Let's go."

Ali drew to a halt when he realized where the sheikh was leading him. "Wait . . . you don't mean to actually go

in

the Daeva Quarter, do you?" He assumed the gate had only been a meeting place.

"Afraid of a few fire worshippers?" Hanno teased. He tapped the hilt of his talwar. "Don't

worry, boy. I won't let any Afshin
ghost gobble you up."

"I'm not afraid of the Daevas," Ali snapped. He'd had just about enough of this man. "But I know the law. They don't allow
foreigners in their quarter after sunset."

"Well, then I guess we'll just have to be discreet."

They passed under the snarling shedu statues and into the Daeva Quarter. Ali got a brief glance at the main boulevard--bustling
at this time of night with shoppers browsing in the market and men playing chess over endless cups of tea--before Anas pulled
him toward the back of the nearest building.

A dark alley stretched before them, lined with neatly stacked crates of garbage awaiting disposal. It snaked away, vanishing
into the gloomy distance.

"Stay low and stay quiet," Anas warned. It quickly became clear that the Tanzeem men had done this before; they navigated
the maze of alleys with ease, darting into the shadows every time a back door banged open.

When they finally emerged, it was in a neighborhood that bore little resemblance to the gleaming central boulevard. The ancient
buildings looked hewn directly from Daevabad's rocky hills, ramshackle wooden huts squashed in every available space. A squat
brick complex stood at the end of the street, firelight winking from behind its tattered curtains.

As they drew closer, Ali could hear drunken laughter and the strains of some sort of stringed instrument pouring out from
the open door. The air was hazy; smoke drifted about the men lounging on stained cushions, swirling past steam pipes and dark
goblets of wine. The patrons were all Daeva, many with black caste tattoos and family sigils emblazoned on their golden-brown
arms.

A burly man in a stained vest with a scar splitting one cheek guarded the entrance. He climbed to his feet as they approached,
blocking the door with an enormous ax.

"You lost?" he growled.

"We're here to see Turan," Hanno said.

The guard's black eyes shifted to Anas. He sneered. "You and your crocodile friend can

come in, but the dirt-blood stays out
here."

Hanno stepped up to him, his hand on his talwar. "For what I'm paying your boss, my servant stays with me." He jerked his
head at the ax. "Mind?"

The other man didn't look happy, but he stepped away and Hanno entered the tavern, Anas and Ali following.

Besides a few hostile glances--mostly aimed at Anas--the patrons ignored them. It looked like the type of place people came
to be forgotten, but Ali struggled not to stare. He'd never been to a tavern--he'd never even spent much time around the fire
worshippers. Few Daevas were permitted to serve in the Royal Guard, and of those who did, Ali suspected none were interested
in befriending the youngest Qahtani.

He dodged out of the way as a drunk man fell from his ottoman with a smoky snort. The sound of feminine laughter caught his
attention, and Ali glanced over to find a trio of Daeva women conversing in rapid-fire Divasti over a mirrored table covered
in brass game pieces, half-empty goblets, and glittering coins. Though their conversation was gibberish--Ali had never bothered
to learn Divasti--each woman was more stunning than the last, their black eyes sparkling as they laughed. They wore embroidered
blouses that were cut low and tight across their breasts, their slender golden waists wrapped in jeweled chains.

Ali abruptly lost the battle he'd been waging against staring. He'd never seen an adult Daeva woman uncovered, let alone one
displaying the charms of these three. The most conservative of the tribes, Daeva women veiled themselves when leaving their
homes, with many--especially from highborn families--refusing to speak to foreign men at all.

Not these three. Noticing Ali, one of the women straightened up, boldly meeting his eyes with a wicked grin. "Aye, darling,
do you like what you see?" she asked in accented Djinnistani. She licked her lips, causing his heart to skip several beats,
and nodded to the jeweled collar around his neck. "You look like you could afford me."

Anas stepped between them. "Lower your eyes, brother," he chided gently.

Embarrassed, Ali dropped his gaze. Hanno snickered, but Ali didn't look up until they were

led into a small back room. It

was better adorned than the tavern; intricately woven rugs depicting fruit trees and dancers covered the floor while chandeliers of cut glass hung from the ceiling.

Hanno pushed Ali onto one of the plush cushions lining the wall. "Keep quiet," he warned as he took a seat beside him. "It

took me a long time to set this up." Anas stayed standing, his head bowed in an uncharacteristically subservient manner.

A thick felt curtain in the center of the room swept away to reveal a Daeva man in a crimson coat standing at the entrance to a dark corridor.

Hanno beamed. "Greetings, sahib," he boomed in an Agnivanshi accent. "You must be Turan. May the fires burn brightly for you."

Turan didn't return the smile or the blessing. "You're late."

The shapeshifter lifted his dark brows in surprise. "Is the market for stolen children a punctual one?"

Ali startled, but before he could open his mouth, Anas caught his eye from across the room and gave a slight shake of his head. Ali stayed quiet.

Turan crossed his arms, looking irritated. "I can find another buyer if your conscience bothers you."

"And disappoint my wife?" Hanno shook his head. "Absolutely not. She's already set up the nursery."

Turan's eyes slid to Ali. "Who's your friend?"

"Two friends," Hanno corrected, tapping the sword at his waist. "Do you expect me to wander about the Daeva Quarter with the ridiculous amount of money you're demanding and not bring protection?"

Turan's cold gaze stayed fixed upon Ali's face. His heart raced; Ali could think of few places worse to be recognized as a

Qahtani prince than a Daeva tavern filled with drunk men of various criminal persuasions.

Anas spoke for the first time. "He is delaying, master," he warned. "He probably already sold the boy."

"Shut your mouth, shafit," Turan snapped. "No one gave you permission to speak."

"Enough." Hanno cut in. "But come, man, do you have the boy or not? All this complaining

about my tardiness and now you're
wasting time leering at my companion."

Turan's eyes flashed, but he disappeared behind the felt curtain.

Hanno rolled his eyes. "And the Daevas wonder why nobody likes them."

There was an angry burst of Divasti from behind the curtain, and then a dirty little girl carrying a large copper tray was

pushed into the room. She looked as human as Anas. Her skin was dull, and she was dressed in a linen shift wholly inadequate

for the night's chill, her hair shaved so roughly there were scarred nicks on her bare scalp. Keeping her gaze down, she approached

on bare feet, mutely offering the tray upon which sat two steaming cups of apricot liquor. She couldn't have been any older
than ten.

Ali spotted the bruises on the girl's wrist at the same time as Hanno, but the shapeshifter straightened up first.

He hissed. "I'll kill that man."

The little girl scrambled back, and Anas hurried to her side. "It's okay, little one, he didn't mean to scare you . . . Hanno,

put your weapon away

," he warned as the shapeshifter drew his talwar. "Don't be a fool."

Hanno snarled but sheathed the blade as Turan reentered.

The Daeva man took one look at the scene before him and then glared at Anas. "Get away from my servant." The girl retreated

to a dark corner, cowering behind her tray.

Ali's temper flashed. He'd heard Anas speak for years about the plight of the shafit, but to actually

witness

it, to hear how the Daevas spoke to Anas, to see the bruises on the terrified little girl . . .

Maybe Ali had been wrong

to question him earlier.

Turan approached. A baby--well-swaddled and fast asleep--was nestled in his arms. Hanno immediately reached for him.

Turan held back. "The money first."

Hanno nodded at Anas, and the sheikh stepped forward with the purse Ali had given him

earlier. He spilled the contents on
the rug, a mix of currencies including human dinars, Tukharistani jade tablets, salt nuggets, and a single small ruby.

"Count it yourself," Hanno said curtly. "But let me see the boy."

Turan passed him over, and Ali had to work to contain his surprise. He'd expected another shafit child, but the baby's ears
were as peaked as his own, and his brown skin gleamed with the luminescence of a pureblood. Hanno briefly opened one closed
lid, revealing tin-colored eyes. The baby let out a smoky whimper of protest.

"He'll pass," Turan assured him. "Trust me. I've been in this business long enough to know. No one will ever suspect that
he's a shafit."

Shafit?

Ali looked at the boy again, taken aback. But Turan was right: he didn't look like a mixed-blood in the slightest.

"Did you have any trouble getting him away from his parents?" Hanno asked.

"The father wasn't an issue. Agnivanshi pureblood who just wanted the money. The mother was a maid who ran off when he got
her pregnant. Took a while to track her down."

"And she agreed to sell the child?"

Turan shrugged. "She's shafit. Does it matter?"

"It does if she's going to make problems for me later."

"She threatened to go to the Tanzeem." Turan scoffed. "But those dirt-blooded radicals are nothing to worry about, and the
shafit breed like rabbits. She'll have another baby to distract her in a year."

Hanno smiled, but the expression didn't meet his eyes. "Maybe another business opportunity for you." He glanced at Ali. "And
what do you think?" he asked, his voice intent. He turned the sleeping baby around to face him. "Could he pass as my own?"

Ali frowned, a little confused by the question. He glanced between the baby and Hanno, but of course Hanno didn't look like
himself. He'd shapeshifted. He'd shapeshifted into a very particular Agnivanshi visage, and it suddenly became terribly clear
why.

"Y-yes," he choked out, swallowing back the lump in his throat and trying to conceal the

horror in his voice. It was the truth,
after all. "Easily."

Hanno didn't seem as pleased. "Perhaps. But he's older than promised--certainly not worth the ridiculous price you're demanding,"
he complained to Turan. "Is my wife to have given birth to a toddler?"

"Then go." Turan raised his palms. "I'll have another buyer in a week, and you'll return to a wife waiting beside an empty
crib. Spend another half century trying to conceive. It's all the same to me."

Hanno appeared to deliberate another moment. He glanced at the little girl still crouched in the shadows. "We're looking for
a new servant. Include that one with the boy, and I will pay your price."

Turan scowled. "I'm not going to sell you a house slave for nothing."

"I'll buy her," Ali cut in. Hanno's eyes flashed, but Ali didn't care. He wanted to be done with this Daeva demon, to get
these innocent souls away from this hellish place where their lives were weighed solely upon their appearance. He fumbled
for the clasps on his golden collar, and it landed heavily in his lap. He thrust it at Turan, the pearls glistening in the
soft light. "Is this enough?"

Turan didn't touch it. There was no greed, no anticipation in his black eyes. Instead, he glanced at the collar and then looked
at Ali.

He cleared his throat. "What did you say your name was?"

Ali suspected he'd just made a terrible mistake.

But before he could stammer a response, the door leading to the tavern swung open, and one of the wine bearers hurried in.

He bent to whisper in Turan's ear. The slaver's frown deepened.

"Problem?" Hanno prompted.

"A man whose desire to drink outweighs his ability to pay." Turan rose to his feet, his mouth pressed in an irritated line.

"If you will excuse me a moment . . ." He headed for the tavern, the wine bearer at his heels. They shut the door behind them.

Hanno whirled on Ali. "You

idiot

. Didn't I tell you to keep your mouth shut?" He gestured at the collar. "That thing could buy

a dozen girls like her!"

"I-I'm sorry," Ali rushed. "I was just trying to help!"

"Forget that for now." Anas pointed to the baby. "Does he have the mark?"

Hanno shot Ali another aggrieved look but then gently coaxed one of the baby's arms out of his swaddling and turned his wrist

to the light. A small blue birthmark--like a dashed pen stroke--marred the soft skin.

"Yes. Same story as the mother's, as well.

It's him." He pointed to the little girl still cowering in the corner. "But she's not staying here with that monster."

Anas eyed the shapeshifter. "I didn't say she was."

Ali was thunderstruck by what he'd just witnessed. "The boy . . . is this common?"

Anas sighed, his face somber. "Quite. The shafit have always been more fertile than purebloods, a blessing and a curse from

our human ancestors." He gestured to the small fortune glittering on the rug. "It's a lucrative business--one that's gone on

for centuries. There are probably thousands in Daevabad like this boy, raised as purebloods with no idea of their true heritage."

"But their shafit parents . . . can't they petition m--the king?"

""

Petition the king'

?" Hanno repeated, his voice thick with scorn. "By the Most High, is this the first time you've left your family's mansion,

boy? Shafit can't petition the king. They come to us--we're the only ones who can help."

Ali dropped his gaze. "I had no idea."

"Then perhaps you will think on this night should you decide to question me again about the Tanzeem," Anas cut in, his voice

colder than Ali had ever heard it. "We do what's necessary to protect our people."

Hanno suddenly frowned. He stared at the money on the floor, shifting the sleeping baby still nestled in his arms. "Something's

not right." He stood. "Turan shouldn't have left us here with the money and the boy."

He reached for the door leading to the

tavern and then jumped back with a yelp, the sizzle of burned flesh scenting the air.

"The bastard cursed us in!"

Awakened by Hanno's shout, the baby started to cry. Ali shot to his feet. He joined them at

the door, praying Hanno was wrong.

He let his fingertips hover just over the wooden surface, but Hanno was right: it simmered with magic. Fortunately, Ali was

Citadel trained--and the Daevas were troublemakers enough that breaking through the enchantments they used to guard their homes

and businesses was a skill taught to the youngest cadets. He closed his eyes, murmuring the first incantation that came to mind. The door swung open.

The tavern was empty.

It had been abandoned in a hurry. Goblets were still full, smoke curled around forgotten pipes, and scattered game pieces

glittered on the table where the Daeva women had been playing. Even so, Turan had been careful to douse the lamps, throwing

the tavern into darkness. The only illumination came from the moonlight piercing the tattered curtains.

Behind him, Hanno swore and Anas whispered a prayer of protection. Ali reached for his hidden zulfiqar, the forked copper

scimitar he always carried, and then stopped. The famed Geziri weapon in the hands of a young Ayaanle-looking man would give

him away at once. Instead, he crept through the tavern. Taking care to remain hidden, he peeked past the curtain.

The Royal Guard stood on the other side.

Ali sucked in his breath. A dozen soldiers--nearly all of whom he recognized--were quietly lining up in formation across the

street from the tavern, their coppery zulfiqars and spears gleaming in the moonlight. More were coming; Ali could see shadowy movement from the direction of the midan.

He stepped back. Dread, thicker than anything he'd ever felt, ensnared him, like vines tightening around his chest. He returned to the others.

"We need to leave." He was surprised at the calm in his voice; it certainly didn't match the panic rising inside him. "There are soldiers outside."

Anas paled. "Can we make it to the safe house?" he asked Hanno.

The shapeshifter bounced the squalling baby. "We'll have to try . . . but it won't be easy with this one carrying on."

Ali thought fast, glancing around the room. He spotted the copper tray, abandoned by the

shafit girl now clutching Anas's

hand. He crossed the room, snatching up one of the cups of apricot liquor. "Would this work?"

Anas looked aghast. "Have you lost your mind?"

But Hanno nodded. "It might." He held the baby while Ali clumsily attempted to pour the liquor into his wailing mouth. He

could feel the weight of the shapeshifter's gaze. "What you did to the door . . ." Hanno's voice brimmed with accusation.

"You're Royal Guard, aren't you? One of those kids they lock up in the Citadel until their first quarter century?"

Ali hesitated.

I'm more than that.

"I'm here with you now, aren't I?"

"I suppose you are." Hanno swaddled the boy with practiced ease. The baby finally fell silent, and Hanno drew his talwar,

the gleaming steel blade the length of Ali's arm. "We'll need to look for an exit out the back." He jerked his head at the

red curtain. "You'll understand if I insist you go first."

Ali nodded, his mouth dry. What choice did he have? He pushed the curtain aside and stepped into the dark corridor.

A maze of storerooms greeted him. Barrels of wine were stacked to the ceiling, and towering crates of hairy onions and overripe

fruit scented the air. Broken tables, half-constructed walls, and shrouded pieces of furniture were haphazardly scattered

everywhere. Ali saw no exits, only spots to hide.

A perfect place to be ambushed

. He blinked; his eyes had stopped burning. The potion must have worn off. Not that it mattered--Ali had grown up with the

men outside; they would recognize him either way.

There was a small tug on his robe. The little girl raised a trembling hand and pointed to a black doorway at the end of the

corridor. "That goes to the alley," she whispered, her dark eyes wide as saucers.

Ali smiled down at her. "Thank you," he whispered back.

They headed down the corridor toward the last storeroom. In the distance, he spotted a line of moonlight near the floor: a

door. Unfortunately, that was all he saw. The storeroom was blacker than pitch and,

judging from the distance to the door,
enormous. Ali slipped inside, his heart pounding so loudly he could hear it in his ears.

It wasn't all he heard.

There was a hush of breath, and then something whooshed past his face, grazing his nose and smelling of iron. Ali whirled

around as the little girl screamed, but he couldn't see anything in the black room, his eyes not yet adjusted to the darkness.

Anas cried out. "Let her go!"

To hell with discretion

. Ali drew his zulfiqar. The hilt warmed in his hands.

Brighten

, he commanded.

It burst into flames.

Fire licked up the copper scimitar, scorching its forked tip and throwing wild light across the room. Ali spotted two Daevas:

Turan and the guard from the tavern, his massive ax in hand. Turan was trying to pull the screaming girl from Anas's arms,

but he turned at the sight of the fiery zulfiqar. His black eyes filled with fear.

The guard wasn't as impressed. He lunged at Ali.

Ali brought the zulfiqar up in the nick of time, sparks flying from where the blade hit the ax. The ax head must have been

iron, the metal one of the few substances that could weaken magic. Ali pushed hard, shoving the man off.

The Daeva came at him again. Ali ducked the next blow, the entire situation surreal. He'd spent half of his life sparring;

the motion of his blade, his feet, it was all familiar. Too familiar; it seemed impossible to imagine that his opponent actually wanted to

kill

him, that a misstep wouldn't result in trash-talking over coffee, but a bloody death on a dirty floor in a dark room where

Ali had no business being in the first place.

Ali dodged another blow. He'd yet to attack the other man himself. How could he? He'd had the best martial training available,

but he'd never killed anyone--he'd never even intentionally harmed another. He was underage, years from seeing combat. And he was the king's son! He couldn't murder one of his father's citizens--a

Daeva

, of all people. He'd start a war.

The guard raised his weapon again. And then he went white. The ax stayed frozen in midair. "Suleiman's eye," he gasped. "You . . . you're Ali--"

A steel blade burst through his throat.

"--al Qahtani," Hanno finished. He twisted the blade, stealing the man's last words as he stole his life. He pushed the dead man off the talwar with one foot, letting him slide to the floor. "Alizayd

fucking al Qahtani

." He turned to Anas, his face bright with outrage. "Oh, Sheikh . . . how could you?"

Turan was still there. He glanced at Ali and then at the Tanzeem men. Horrified realization lit his face. He lunged for the door, fleeing into the corridor.

Ali didn't move, didn't speak. He was still staring at the dead Daeva guard.

"Hanno . . ." Anas's voice was shaky. "The prince . . . no one can know."

The shapeshifter let out an aggravated sigh. He handed the baby to Anas and picked up the ax. He followed Turan.

The realization came to Ali too late. "W-wait. You don't have to--"

There was a short scream in the corridor followed by a crunching sound. Then a second. A third. Ali swayed on his feet, nausea threatening to overwhelm him.

This isn't happening

.

"Alizayd." Anas was before him. "Brother, look at me." Ali tried to focus on the sheikh's face. "He sold children. He would have revealed you. He needed to die."

There was the distinct sound of the tavern door smashing open. "Anas Bhatt!" a familiar voice shouted.

Wajed . . . oh, God, no . . .

"We know you're here!"

Hanno rushed back into the room. He snatched up the baby and kicked open the door.
"Come on!"

The thought of Wajed--Ali's beloved Qaid, the sly-eyed general who'd all but raised him--finding Ali standing over the bodies

of two murdered purebloods snapped him to attention. He raced after Hanno, Anas at his heels.

They emerged in another trash-strewn alley. They ran until they reached its end, the towering copper wall that separated the

Tukharistani and Daeva quarters. Their only escape was a narrow breach leading back to the street.

Hanno peeked out of the breach and then jerked back. "They've Daeva archers."

"

What?

"Ali joined him, ignoring the sharp elbow to his side. At the distant end of the street was the tavern, lit up by the fiery

zulfiquars of soldiers pouring through the entrance. A half-dozen Daeva archers waited on elephants, their silver bows gleaming
in the starlight.

"We have a safe house in the Tukharistani Quarter," Hanno explained. "There's a spot we can get over the wall, but we need
to cross the street first."

Ali's heart sank. "We'll never make it." The soldiers might have been focused on the tavern, but there was no way one of them

wouldn't notice three men, a girl child, and a baby dashing across the street. The fire worshippers were devilishly good archers--the

Daevas as devoted to their bows as the Geziris were to their zulfiquars--and it was a wide street.

He turned to Anas. "We'll have to find another way."

Anas nodded. He glanced at the baby in Hanno's arms and then at the little girl clutching his hand. "All right," he said softly.

He knelt to face the girl, untangling her fingers from his own. "My dear, I need you to go with the brother here." He pointed

at Ali. "He's going to take you someplace safe."

Ali stared at Anas, dumbstruck. "What? Wait . . . you don't mean . . ."

"I'm the one they're after." Anas stood. "I'm not going to risk the lives of children to save my

own." He shrugged, but his

voice was strained when he spoke again. "I knew this day would come . . . I-I'll try to distract them . . . to give you as much time as possible."

"Absolutely not," Hanno declared. "The Tanzeem need you. I'll go. I've got a better chance at taking out some of those purebloods anyway."

Anas shook his head. "You're better equipped than I to get the prince and the children to safety."

"

No

." The word tore from Ali's throat, more prayer than plea. He could not lose his sheikh, not like this. "I'll go. Surely I can negotiate some sort of--"

"You'll negotiate nothing," Anas cut in, his voice severe. "If you tell your father about tonight, you're dead, do you understand?"

The Daevas would riot if they learned of your involvement. Your father won't risk that." He placed a hand on Ali's shoulder.

"And you're too valuable to lose."

"The hell he is," Hanno retorted. "You're going to get yourself killed just so some Qahtani brat can--"

Anas cut him off with a sharp motion of his hand. "Alizayd al Qahtani can do more for the shafit than a thousand groups like

the Tanzeem. And he will," he added, giving Ali an intent look. "Earn this. I don't care if you have to dance on my grave.

Save yourself, brother. Live to fight again." He pushed the little girl toward him. "Get them out of here, Hanno." Without another word, he turned back, heading for the tavern.

The shafit girl looked up at Ali, her brown eyes enormous with fear. He blinked back tears. Anas had sealed his fate; the

least Ali could do was follow his last order. He picked up the girl, and she clung to his neck, her heart thudding against his chest.

Hanno shot him a look of pure venom. "You and I, al Qahtani, are going to have a long chat when this is over." He snatched

the turban from Ali's head, quickly fashioning it into a sling for the baby.

Ali immediately felt more exposed. "Was there something wrong with yours?"

"You'll run faster if you're worried about being recognized." He nodded at Ali's zulfiqar. "Put that away."

Ali shoved the zulfiqar under his robe, shifting the girl to his back as they waited. There was a shout from the tavern, followed
by a second, more exultant cry.

God protect you, Anas

.

The archers turned toward the tavern. One drew back his silver bow, aiming an arrow at the entrance.

"Go!" Hanno said and shot out, Ali at his heels. Ali didn't look at the soldiers, his world reduced to sprinting across the
cracked paving stones as fast as his legs would take him.

One of the archers shouted a warning.

Ali was halfway across when the first arrow whizzed over his head. It burst into fiery fragments, and the little girl screamed.

The second tore through his robe, grazing his calf. He kept running.

They were across. Ali threw himself behind a stone balustrade, but his refuge was short-lived. Hanno lunged for an intricate
wooden trellis attached to the building. It was covered with sprawling roses in a rainbow of colors, stretching three stories
to reach the distant roof.

"Climb!"

Climb?

Ali's eyes went wide as he stared at the delicate trellis. The thing barely looked strong enough to hold its flowers, let
alone the weight of two grown men.

An arrow doused in blazing pitch hit the ground near his feet. Ali jumped back, and the sound of trumpeting elephants filled
the air.

The trellis it was.

The wooden frame shook violently as he climbed, the thorny vines shredding his hands. The little girl clung to his back, half-choking

Ali as she buried her face in his neck, her cheeks wet with tears. Another arrow whizzed past their heads, and she shrieked--in
pain this time.

Ali had no way to check on her. He kept climbing, trying to stay as flat as possible against the building.

Please, God, please

, he begged; he was far too terrified to come up with a more coherent prayer.

He was nearly at the roof, Hanno already clear, when the trellis began to peel away from the wall.

For one heart-stopping moment, Ali was falling backward. The wooden frame came apart in his hands. A scream bubbled up in
his throat.

Hanno grabbed his wrist.

The shafit shapeshifter dragged him onto the roof, and Ali promptly collapsed. "The g-girl . . .," he breathed. "An arrow . . ."

Hanno pulled her from his back and quickly examined the back of her head. "It's all right, little one," he assured her. "You'll
be okay." He glanced at Ali. "She'll need a few stitches, but the wound doesn't look deep." He undid the sling. "Let's switch."

Ali took the baby, slipping into the sling.

There was a shout from below. "They're on the roof!"

Hanno yanked him to his feet. "Go!"

He dashed away, and Ali followed. They ran across the roof, leaping over the narrow space to the next building and then doing
it again, racing past lines of drying laundry and potted fruit trees. Ali tried not to look at the ground as they jumped,
his heart in his throat.

They reached the last roof, but Hanno didn't stop, instead speeding up as he neared the edge. And then--to Ali's horror--he
launched himself over.

Ali gasped, drawing to a stop just before the edge. But the shapeshifter wasn't dashed on the ground below; instead, he'd
landed atop the copper wall separating the tribal quarters. The wall was perhaps half a body length lower than the roof and
a good ten paces away. It was an impossible jump, pure fortune that Hanno had made it.

He gave the shapeshifter an incredulous look. "Are you
insane

?"

Hanno grinned, baring his teeth. "Come on, al Qahtani. Surely if a shafit can do it, so can you."

Ali hissed in response. He paced the edge of the roof. Every sensible instinct he had screamed at him not to jump.

The sound of the pursuing soldiers grew louder. They'd be up on the roof any minute. Ali took a few steps back, trying to
work up the courage to take a running leap.

This is madness.

He shook his head. "I can't."

"You don't have a choice." The humor vanished from Hanno's voice. "Al Qahtani . . .

Alizayd

," he pressed when Ali didn't respond. "Listen to me. You heard what the sheikh said. You think you can turn back now? Beg

your abba for mercy?" He shook his head. "I know Geziris. Your people don't fuck around with loyalty." Hanno met Ali's gaze,

his eyes dark with warning. "What do you think your father will do when he learns his own blood betrayed him?"

I never meant to betray him

. Ali took a deep breath.

And then he jumped.

5: Nahri

5

Nahri

"Don't fall asleep, little thief. We're landing soon."

Nahri's eyelids were as heavy as a sack of dirhams, but she wasn't asleep. There was no way she could be, with only a scrap

of fabric preventing her from plummeting to her death. She rolled over on the carpet, a chilly wind caressing her face as

they flew. The dawn sky blushed at the approach of the sun, the dark of night giving way to light pinks and blues as the stars

winked out. She stared at the sky. Exactly one week ago, she'd been looking at another dawn in Cairo, waiting for the basha,

unaware of how drastically her life was about to change.

The djinn--no, the daeva, she corrected herself; Dara had a tendency to fly into a rage when she called him a djinn--sat beside

her, the smoky heat from his robe tickling her nose. His shoulders were slumped, and his emerald eyes were dim and focused

on something in the distance.

My captor looks particularly tired this morning

. Nahri didn't blame him; it had been the most bizarre, challenging week of her life, and though Dara appeared to be softening

toward her, she sensed they were both thoroughly exhausted. The haughty daeva warrior and scheming human thief were not the

most natural of pairings; at times, Dara could be as chatty as a girlhood friend, asking a hundred questions about her life,

from her favorite color to what types of cloth they sold in the Cairo bazaars. Then, with little warning, he'd turn sullen

and hostile, perhaps disgusted to find himself enjoying a conversation with a mixed-blood.

On Nahri's part, she was largely forced to check her own curiosity; asking Dara anything about the magical world immediately

put him in a bad mood. "You can bother the djinn in Daevabad with all your questions," he'd dismiss her, returning to polishing

his weapons.

But he was wrong.

She couldn't do that. Because she was definitely

not

going to Daevabad.

One week with Dara was enough for her to know there was no way she was trapping herself in a city filled with more ill-tempered

djinn. She would be better off on her own. Surely she could find a way to avoid the ifrit; they couldn't possibly search the

entire human world, and there was no way in hell she'd ever perform a zar again.

And so, eager to escape, she'd kept an eye out for an opportunity--but there'd been nowhere to flee in the vast, unbroken monolith

of desert they traveled, all moonlit sands by night and shady oases by day. Yet as she sat up now and caught a glimpse of

the ground below, hope bloomed in her chest.

The sun had broken across the horizon to illuminate a changed landscape. Instead of desert, limestone hills melted into a

wide, dark river that twisted southeast as far as the eye could see. White clusters of buildings and cooking fires hugged

its banks. The arid plains directly below were rocky, broken up by scrub and slender, conical trees.

She scanned the ground, growing alert. "Where are we?"

"Hierapolis."

"

Where?

" She and Dara might speak the same language, but they were centuries apart in geography. He knew everything by a different

name, rivers, cities, even the stars in the sky. The words he used were entirely unknown, and the stories he told to describe

such places even more bizarre.

"Hierapolis." The carpet swept toward the ground, Dara directing it with one hand. "It has been too long since I've been back.

When I was young, Hierapolis was home to a very . . .

spiritual

people. Very devoted to their rituals. Though I suppose anyone would be devoted, considering they worshipped phalluses and

fish and preferred orgies to prayer." He sighed, his eyes creasing in pleasure.

"Humans can be so delightfully inventive."

"I thought you hated humans."

"Not at all. Humans in their world, and my people in ours. That is the best way of things," he said firmly. "It is when we
cross that trouble arises."

Nahri rolled her eyes, knowing he believed her to be the result of such a crossing. "What river is that?"

"The Ufratu."

Ufratu . . .

She rolled the word in her mind. "Ufratu . . . el-Furat . . . that's the Euphrates?" She was stunned. They were

much

farther east than she expected.

Dara took her dismay the wrong way. "Yes. Don't worry, it's too massive to cross here."

Nahri frowned. "What do you mean? We're flying over it anyway, aren't we?"

She would swear that he blushed, a hint of embarrassment in his bright eyes. "I . . . I don't like flying over that much water,"

he finally confessed. "Especially when I'm tired. We'll rest, then fly farther north to find a better spot. We can get horses
on the other side. If Khayzur was right about the enchantment I used on the rug being easy to track, I don't want to fly much
farther on it."

Nahri barely heard what he said about the rug, her mind racing as she appraised the dark river.

This is my chance

, she realized. Dara might refuse to talk about himself, but Nahri had studied him all the same, and his confession about
flying over the river confirmed her suspicion.

The daeva was

terrified

of water.

He'd refused to put even a toe in the shady pools of the oases they visited and seemed convinced she was going to drown in

the shallowest of ponds, declaring her enjoyment of water unnatural, a shafit perversion. He wouldn't dare cross the mighty

Euphrates without the carpet; he probably wouldn't even go near its banks.

I just need to get to the river

. Nahri would swim its whole damn length if that was the only way to freedom.

They landed on the rocky ground, and her knee slammed into a hard lump. She cursed, rubbing it as she climbed to her feet

to look around. Her mouth dropped open. "

When

did you say you last visited?"

They hadn't landed on rocky ground; they'd landed on a flattened building. Broken and bare marble columns lined the avenues,

most of which were missing sections of paving stones. The buildings were destroyed, though the height of a few remaining yellowed

walls hinted at previous glory. There were grand arched entrances that led to nothing, and blackened weeds and brush growing

between the stonework and snaking up the columns. Across from the rug, an enormous stone pillar the color of washed sky lay

smashed on the ground. Carved into its side were the grimy contours of a veiled woman with a fish tail.

Nahri moved away from the rug and startled a dust-colored fox. It vanished behind a crumbling wall. She glanced back at Dara.

He looked equally stunned, his green eyes wide with shock. He caught her glance and forced a small smile.

"Well, it has been

some

time . . ."

"Some time?" She gestured to the abandoned remains surrounding them. Across the broken road was an enormous fountain filled

with murky black water; foul scum stained the marble from where it had started to evaporate. It had to take centuries for

a place to get like this. There were similar ruins in Egypt, and it was said that they belonged to an ancient race of sun

worshippers who lived and died before the holy books were even written. She shivered. "How old

are

you?"

Dara gave her an annoyed look. "It's not your concern." He shook the carpet out with more force than necessary, rolled it

up, and then threw it over one shoulder before stalking off into the largest of the ruined buildings. Voluptuous fish-women

were carved around the entrance; perhaps it was one of the temples where people had "worshipped."

Nahri followed. She needed that rug. "Where are you going?" She stumbled over a broken column, envying the graceful way the

daeva moved over the uneven ground, and then paused as she entered the temple, dazzled by the grand decay.

The temple's roof and eastern wall were gone, opening the ruin to the dawn sky. Marble pillars stretched far above her head,

and crumbled stone walls outlined what must once have been an enormous maze of different rooms. Most of the interior was gloomy,

shaded by the remaining walls and a few determined cypress trees that split through the floor.

To her left was a tall stone dais. Three statues were poised on top: another fish-woman, as well as a stately female riding

a lion, and a man wearing a loincloth and holding a discus. All were stunning, their muscled figures and regal poise entrancing.

The pleats in their stone garments looked so real that she was tempted to touch them.

But glancing around, she saw that Dara had vanished, his footsteps silent in the grand ruin. Nahri followed the trail he'd

made in the thick layer of dust coating the floor.

"Oh . . ." A small sound of appreciation escaped her throat. The large temple was dwarfed by the enormous theater she entered.

Hundreds, perhaps thousands, of stone seats were carved into the hill in a semicircle surrounding the large stage upon which she stood.

The daeva stood at the edge of the stage. The air was still and silent save for the early morning trill of songbirds. His

midnight blue robe smoked and swirled about his feet, and he'd unwrapped his turban to let it fall to his shoulders, his head

covered only by the flat charcoal cap. Its white embroidery shone pink in the rosy morning light.

He looks like he belongs here

, she thought.

Like a ghost forgotten in time, searching for its long-dead companions

. Judging from the way he spoke of Daevabad, Nahri assumed him to be some sort of exile. He probably missed his people.

She shook her head; she didn't intend to let a flash of sympathy convince her to keep playing companion to a lonely daeva.

"Dara?"

"I saw a play here once with my father," he reminisced. "I was young, probably my first tour of the human world . . ." He

studied the stage. "They had actors waving brilliant blue silks to represent the ocean. I thought it magical."

"I'm sure it was lovely. Can I have the carpet?"

He glanced back. "What?"

"The carpet. You sleep on it every day." She let a note of complaint slip into her voice. "It's my turn."

"So share with me." He nodded at the temple. "We'll find a place in the shade."

She felt her cheeks grow slightly hot. "I'm not sleeping alongside you in some temple dedicated to fish orgies."

He rolled his eyes and dropped the rug. It landed hard on the ground, sending up a cloud of dust. "Do as you wish."

I intend to

. Nahri waited until he had stalked back into the temple before dragging the carpet to the far end of the stage. She pushed

it off and flinched at the heavy thump, half-expecting the daeva to run out and tell her to hush. But the theater stayed empty.

She knelt on the rug. Though the river was a long, hot walk away, she didn't want to leave until she was certain Dara was

fast asleep. It didn't usually take long. The comment about flying over the river wasn't the first time he'd mentioned becoming

exhausted by magic. Nahri supposed it was a type of labor like any other.

She reviewed her supplies. It wasn't much. Besides the clothes on her back and a sack she'd made from the remains of her abaya,

she had the waterskin and a tin of manna--stale-tasting crackers Dara had given her that landed in her stomach like weights.

The water and manna might keep her fed, but they wouldn't put a roof over her head.

It doesn't matter. I might not get another opportunity like this

. Pushing away her doubts, she tied the bag closed and rewrapped her headscarf. Then she picked up some kindling and crept
back into the temple.

She followed the smell of smoke until she found the daeva. As usual, Dara had lit a small fire, letting it burn beside him
as he slept. Though she'd never asked why--it obviously wasn't for warmth during the hot desert days--the presence of the flames
seemed to comfort him.

He was fast asleep under the shadow of a crumbling arch. For the first time since they'd met, he'd taken off his robe and
was using it as a pillow. Underneath he wore a sleeveless tunic the color of unripe olives and loose, bone-colored pants.

His dagger was tucked into a wide black belt tied tight around his waist, and his bow, quiver of arrows, and scimitar were
between his body and the wall. His right hand rested on the weapons. Nahri's gaze lingered on the sight of his chest rising
and falling in sleep. Something stirred low in her belly.

She ignored it and lit her kindling. His fire flared, and in the improved light, she noticed the black tattoos covering his
arms, bizarre, geometrical shapes, as if a calligrapher had gone mad on his skin. The largest mark was a slender, ladderlike
structure with what looked like hundreds of meticulously drawn, unsupported rungs snaking out from his left palm and twisting
up his arm to disappear under his tunic.

And I thought the tattoo on his face was strange . . .

As she followed the lines, the light illuminated something else as well.

His ring.

Nahri stilled; the emerald winked in the firelight as if greeting her. Tempting her. His left hand rested lightly on his stomach.

Nahri stared at the ring, transfixed. It had to be worth a fortune and yet didn't even look snug on his finger.

I could take it

, she realized.

I've taken jewelry off people while they were

awake

.

The kindling grew warm in her hand, the fire burning uncomfortably close. No. It wasn't worth the risk. She gave the daeva

one last glance as she left. She could not help but feel a pang of regret; she knew Dara represented the best chance to learn

about her origins, about her family and her abilities. About, well . . . everything. But it wasn't worth her freedom.

Nahri returned to the theater. She dropped the kindling on the carpet. Years in a tomb and a week in the desert air had sucked

out every drop of moisture from the old wool. It burst into flames like it had been doused in oil. She coughed, waving smoke

away from her face. By the time Dara woke, it would be nothing but ash. He'd have to go after her on foot, and she'd have a half day's start.

"Just make it to the river," she whispered to herself. She picked up her bag and started climbing the stairs that led out of the theater.

The bag was pathetically light, a physical reminder of how dire her circumstances were.

I'm going to be nothing. People will laugh when I say I can heal.

Yaqub's willingness to partner with her was rare, and that was after she'd already established a reputation as a healer, a reputation that had taken years of careful cultivation.

But she wouldn't have to worry if she had that ring

.

She could sell it, rent a place so she wouldn't have to sleep on the street. Buy medicines to use in her work, materials

with which to make amulets. She slowed, not even halfway up the steps.

I'm a good thief. I've stolen far more challenging things.

And Dara slept like the dead; he hadn't even awakened when Khayzur nearly landed on him.

"I'm a fool," she whispered, but she was already turning around, running lightly down the steps and past the blazing carpet.

She crept back into the temple, winding her way around the collapsed columns and smashed statues.

Dara was still fast asleep. Nahri carefully put down her bag and freed the waterskin. She sprinkled a few drops on his finger,

her heart racing as she watched for any reaction. Nothing. Moving cautiously, she

gently pinched the ring between her thumb
and index finger. She pulled.

The ring pulsed and grew hot. A sudden pain blossomed in her head. She panicked and tried to let go, but her fingers wouldn't

budge. It was as if someone had seized control of her mind. The temple vanished, and her vision blurred, replaced by a series

of smoky shapes that quickly solidified into something entirely new. A parched plain under a blinding white sun . . .

I study the dead land with a practiced eye. This place had once been grassy and green, rich with irrigated fields and orchards,

but my master's army trampled all signs of fertility, leaving nothing but mud and dust. The orchards are stripped and burned,

the river poisoned a week ago, in hopes that it would drive the city to surrender.

Unseen by the humans around me, I rise in the air like smoke to better survey our forces. My master has a formidable army:

thousands of men in chain and leather, dozens of elephants, and hundreds of horses. His archers are the best in the human

world, honed by my careful instruction. But the walled city remains insurmountable.

I stare at the ancient blocks, wondering at how thick they are, how many other armies they have repulsed. No battering ram

will bring them down. I sniff carefully; the stench of famine scents the wind.

I turn to my master. He is one of the largest humans I've ever encountered; the top of my head barely comes to his shoulders.

Unable to deal with the heat of the plains, he is constantly pink and wet and utterly disagreeable. Even his ruddy beard is

damp with sweat, and his ornately filigreed tunic stinks. I wrinkle my nose; such a garment is frivolous in a time of war.

I settle to the ground next to his horse and look up at him. "Another two to three days," I say, tripping over the sounds.

Although I've belonged to him for a year, his language is still strange to me, full of harsh consonants and snarls. "They

cannot hold out much longer."

He scowls and caresses the hilt of his sword. "That is too long. You said they'd be ready to surrender last week."

I pause, the impatience in his voice causing a small knot of dread to grow in my stomach. I do not want to sack this city.

Not because I care about the thousands who will die--centuries of slavery have

cultivated a deep hatred for humans in my soul--but
because I do not wish to see the sack of any city. I do not want to see the
violence, to imagine how my beloved Daevabad suffered
a similar fate at the hands of the Qahtanis.

"It is taking longer because they are courageous, my lord. Such a thing should be admired."
My master doesn't seem to hear
me, so I continue, "You'll earn a more lasting peace by negotiating."

My master takes a deep breath. "Was I not clear?" he snaps, leaning down in his saddle to
glare at me. His face is scarred
from the pox. "I didn't buy you for advice, slave. I

wish

for you to give me victory. I wish for this city. I wish to see my cousin on his knees before
me."

Admonished, I lower my head. His wishes settle heavily on my shoulders, wrapping around
my limbs. Energy surges through my
fingers.

There is no fighting it; I learned this long ago. "Yes, master." I raise my hands and focus my
attention on the wall.

The ground begins to tremble. His horse shies away, and a few men cry out in alarm. In the
distance, the wall groans, the
ancient stones protesting my magic. Tiny figures race along the top, fleeing their
posts.

I close my hands into fists, and the wall collapses as though made of sand. A roar runs
through my master's army. Humans,
their very blood dances at the prospect of brutalizing their own kind . . .

No!

Nahri gasped, a tiny voice crying out in her mind.

This isn't me! This isn't real!

But the voice was drowned out by the screams of the next vision.

We are inside the city. I fly alongside my master's horse through bloody streets thick with
corpses. His soldiers torch the
shops and narrow homes, cutting through any inhabitants foolish enough to cross
them. A burning man crashes to the ground
beside me, thrown from a balcony, and a young girl shrieks as two soldiers pull
her from an overturned cart.

Bonded by the wish, I can't leave my master's side. I wade through gore with a sword in each hand, killing any who approach.

As we grow closer to the castle, the attackers are too numerous for my blades. I toss the weapons away, and the slave curse

sweeps through me as I burn an entire group with a single glance. Their screams rise through the air, horrendous, animal-like groans.

Before I know it, we are in the castle and then in a bedchamber. The room is opulent and smells strongly of cedarwood, the

scent bringing tears to my eyes. It was what my Daeva tribe burned to honor the Creator and His blessed Nahids . . . but I

cannot honor anyone in my defiled condition. Instead, I tear through the guards. Their blood spatters the silk wall coverings.

A balding man cowers in one corner; I can smell his released bowels. A fierce-eyed woman throws herself in front of him, a

knife in her hand. I break her neck as I toss her aside and then grab the sobbing man, forcing him to his knees before my master.

"Your cousin, my lord."

My master smiles, and the weight of the wish lifts from my shoulders. Exhausted by magic and nauseated by the smell of so

much human blood, I fall to my own knees. My ring blazes, illuminating the black slave record branded into my skin. I fix

my gaze on my master, surrounded by the carnage he ordered, watching as he mocks his cousin's hysterics. Hate surges in my heart.

I will see you dead, human

, I swear.

I will see your life reduced to a mere mark on my arm . . .

The bedchamber dissolved before Nahri's eyes as her fingers were pried off the ring, her hand wrenched away so hard that she

fell back against the stone floor. Her mind spun as she desperately tried to make sense of what had just happened.

The answer loomed over her, still clutching her wrist.

If anything, Dara looked more shocked to find himself awakened in such a manner. He glanced at his hand, his fingers still

gripping her wrist. His ring blazed with light, mirroring the emerald brightness of his

eyes. He let out a startled cry.

"

No!

" His eyes went wide with panic, and he dropped her wrist, backing away. His entire body was shaking. "What did you do?" he

shrieked, holding his hand out like he expected the ring to explode.

Dara. The man in her vision had been

Dara

. And what she had seen . . . were those his

memories

? They seemed too real to have been his dreams.

Nahri forced herself to meet his gaze. "Dara . . ." She tried to keep her voice gentle. The daeva was pale with fright, his

eyes wild. "Please, just calm down." He'd backed away without any of his weapons.

She resisted the urge to look at them, fearing

he would notice. "I didn't--"

The daeva seemed to read her mind, lunging for his weapons at the same time she did. He was faster, but Nahri was closer.

She grabbed his sword and jumped back as he lunged at her with the dagger.

"Don't!" She raised the sword, her hands trembling as she gripped it tight. Dara drew back with a hiss that bared his teeth.

Nahri panicked. There was no way she could outrun him, no way she could outfight him. The daeva looked like he'd gone mad;

she half-expected him to start frothing at the mouth. The visions flashed through her mind again: bodies ripped apart, men

burned to death. And Dara had done it all.

No

. There had to be some explanation. And then she remembered. Master, he had called that man his master.

He's a slave.

All the stories Nahri had heard about the djinn raced through her mind, and her mouth fell open in shock.

A wish-granting djinn slave

.

The realization didn't improve her situation. "Dara, please . . . I don't know what happened, but I didn't mean to hurt you.

I swear!"

His left hand was pressed to his chest, the ring next to his heart--if daevas had hearts. He held the dagger out with his right,

circling her like a cat. He closed his eyes for a moment and when he opened them, some of the wildness had dissipated. "No . . .

I--" He swallowed, looking close to tears. "I'm still here." He took a shaky breath, relief flooding into his face. "I'm still

free." He leaned heavily against one of the marble columns. "But that city . . .," he choked out. "Those people . . ." He

slid to the floor, dropping his head into his hands.

Nahri didn't lower the sword. She had no idea what to say, torn between guilt and fear. "I . . . I'm sorry," she finally said.

"I just wanted the ring. I had no idea . . ."

"You wanted the ring?" He glanced up sharply, a hint of suspicion stealing back into his voice. "Why?"

Telling the truth seemed safer than his assuming some type of magical malice on her part. "I was trying to steal it," she

confessed. "I am--I

was

," she corrected, realizing there was no way she was getting free now, "trying to escape."

"Escape?" He narrowed his eyes. "And you needed my ring for that?"

"Have you seen the size of it?" She let out a nervous laugh. "That emerald could get me back to Cairo with money to spare."

He gave her an incredulous look and then shook his head. "And the glory of the Nahids continues." He climbed to his feet,

seemingly unaware of how quickly she backed away. "Why would you even want to escape? Your human life sounds dreadful."

"What?" she asked, offended enough to momentarily forget her fear. "Why would you say that?"

"

Why?

" He picked up his robe and whirled it around his shoulders. "Where do I even start? If simply being human isn't wretched

enough, you had to lie and steal constantly to survive. You lived alone, with no

family and no friends, in unceasing fear
you'd be arrested and executed for sorcery." He blanched. "And you'd return to
that

? Over Daevabad?"

"It wasn't that bad," she insisted, taken aback by his answer. All those questions he'd asked
about her life in Cairo--he really

had been listening to her answers. "My abilities gave me a lot of independence. And
I had a friend," she added, though she

wasn't certain Yaqub would agree with that definition of their relationship. "Besides,
you act as if I'm facing something

better. Aren't you turning me over to some djinn king who murdered my family?"

"No," Dara said, adding somewhat more hesitantly, "it was not . . .

technically

him. Your ancestors were enemies, but Khayzur spoke correctly." He sighed. "It was a long
time ago," he added lamely, as

if that explained everything.

Nahri stared. "So being delivered to

my ancestral enemy

is supposed to make me feel better?"

Dara looked even more annoyed. "

No

. It's not like that." He made an impatient noise. "You're a healer, Nahri. The last of them.
Daevabad needs you as much as

you need it, maybe even more." He scowled. "And when the djinn learn I was the
one who found you? The Scourge of Qui-zi forced

to play nursemaid to a mixed-blood?" He shook his head. "The Qahtanis are going
to love it. They'll probably set you up in

your own wing of the palace."

My own wing of the

what

?

"The Scourge of Qui-zi?" she asked instead.

"An endearment I've earned from them." His green gaze settled on the sword still clasped in
her hands. "You don't need that.

I'm not going to hurt you."

"No?" Nahri arched an eyebrow. "Because I just saw you hurt a whole lot of people."

"You saw that?" When she nodded, his face crumpled. "I wish you hadn't." He crossed the floor to retrieve her bag, dusting

it off before handing it back. "What you saw . . . I didn't do those things by choice."

His voice was low as he turned back

and picked up his turban cloth.

Nahri hesitated. "In my country, we have stories of djinn . . . djinn who are trapped as slaves and forced to grant wishes

to humans."

Dara flinched, his fingers fumbling as he rewound his turban. "I'm not a djinn."

"But are you a slave?"

He said nothing, and her temper flashed. "Forget it," she snapped. "I don't know why I bothered to ask. You never answer my

questions. You let me panic over this Qahtani king for an entire week just because you couldn't bother to--"

"Not anymore." His reply was a whisper, a fragile thing that hung in the air--the first real truth he'd offered her. He turned

around; old grief was etched in his face. "I'm not a slave anymore."

Before Nahri could respond, the ground trembled beneath her feet.

A nearby pillar cracked as a second rumble--far stronger--rocked the temple. Dara swore, snatched up his weapons, and grabbed

her hand. "Come on!"

They raced through the temple and out onto the open stage, narrowly avoiding a falling column. The ground shook harder, and

Nahri gave the theater a nervous glance, looking for signs of the recently risen dead.

"Maybe this one's an earthquake?"

"So soon after you used your powers on me?" He searched the stage. "Where's the carpet?"

She hesitated. "I may have burned it."

Dara whirled on her. "You

burned

it?"

"I didn't want you to follow me!"

"Where did you burn it?" he asked, not even waiting for an answer before sniffing the air and racing toward the edge of the stage.

By the time she caught him, he was crouching in the glowing embers, his hands pressed against the carpet's ashy remains. "Burned it . . .," he muttered. "By the Creator, you really don't know anything about us."

Little worms of white-bright flame crawled out from under his fingers, reigniting the ash and twisting together into long ropes that grew and stretched under his feet. As she watched, they quickly multiplied, forming a fiery mat roughly the same size and shape as the carpet.

The fire flashed and died, revealing the tired colors of their old rug. "How did you do that?" she whispered.

Dara grimaced as he ran his hand over the surface. "It won't last long, but it should get us across the river."

The ground rumbled again, and a groan came from inside the temple, the sound all too familiar. Dara reached for her hand. She backed away.

His eyes flashed with alarm. "Are you mad?"

Probably

. Nahri knew what she was about to do was risky, but she also knew the best time to negotiate was when your mark was desperate.

"No. I'm not getting on that rug unless you give me some answers."

There was another loud, vaguely human shriek from inside the temple. The ground shook harder, and a crack raced across the high ceiling.

"You want answers

now

? Why? So you'll be better informed when the ghouls devour you?" Dara snatched for her ankle, but she danced back. "Nahri, please! You can ask me whatever you want once we're gone, I swear!"

But she wasn't convinced. What was to stop him from changing his mind as soon as they were safe?

Then it came to her.

"Tell me your name, and I'll go with you," she offered. "Your real name." He had told her there was power in names. It wasn't much, but it was something.

"My name doesn't--" Nahri took a deliberate step toward the temple, and panic lit his face. "No, stop!"

"Then tell me your name!" Nahri shouted, her own fear getting the better of her. She was used to bluffing, but not with the threat of being eaten by the risen dead looming. "And be quick about it!"

"Darayavahoush!" The daeva pulled himself onto the stage. "Darayavahoush e-Afshin is my name. Now get

over

here!"

Nahri was certain she couldn't have repeated that correctly even if she'd been paid, but as the ghouls screamed again, and the smell of rot swept past her face, she decided it didn't matter.

He was ready for her, grabbing her elbow and pulling her down on the rug as he landed lightly beside her. Without another word, the carpet rose in the air, sweeping over the temple's roof as three ghouls stumbled out onto the stage.

Dara was thoroughly riled by the time they'd risen above the clouds. "Do you have any

idea how dangerous that was?" He threw up his hands. "Not only did you try to destroy our only method of escaping the ifrit, you were ready to risk your life just to--"

"Oh, get over it," she said, dismissing him. "You're the one who drove me to such straits, Afshin Daryevu--"

"Dara' will continue to do just fine," he interrupted. "You needn't mangle my proper name." A goblet appeared in his hand, filled with the familiar dark of date wine. He took a long sip. "You can call me a damn djinn again if you promise not to go running after ghouls."

"Such affection for the shafit thief?" She raised an eyebrow. "You weren't so fond of me a week ago."

He grumbled. "I can change my mind, can't I?" A blush stole into his cheeks. "Your

company is not . . .

entirely

displeasing." He sounded deeply disappointed in himself.

Nahri rolled her eyes. "Well, it's time

your

company became a lot more informative. You promised to answer my questions."

He glanced around, gesturing to the clouds. "Right now?"

"Are you busy with something else?"

Dara exhaled. "

Fine

. Go on, then."

"What's a daeva?"

He sighed. "I already told you this: we're djinn. We just have the decency to call ourselves by our true name."

"That explains nothing."

He scowled. "We're souled beings like humans, but we were created from fire, not earth." A delicate tendril of orange flame

snaked around his right hand and twisted through his fingers. "All the elements--earth, fire, water, air--have their own creatures."

Nahri thought of Khayzur. "The peris are creatures of air?"

"An astonishing deduction."

She shot him a dirty look. "He had a better attitude than you."

"Yes, he's extraordinarily gentle for a being who could rearrange the landscape below us and kill every life-form for miles

with a single sweep of his wings."

Nahri felt the blood drain from her face. "Truly?" When Dara nodded, she continued.

"Are--are there a lot of creatures like that?"

He gave her a somewhat wicked smile. "Oh, yes. Dozens. Rukh birds, karkadann, shedu . . . things with sharp teeth and nasty

temperaments. A zahhak nearly ripped me in two once."

She gaped at him. The flame playing around his finger stretched into an elongated lizard

that belched a fiery plume. "Imagine

a fire-breathing serpent with limbs. They're rare, thank the Creator, but don't give much warning when they attack."

"And humans don't notice any of this?" Nahri's eyes widened as the smoky beast left Dara's arm and flew around his head.

He shook his head. "No. Those created from dirt, like humans, usually can't see the rest of us. Besides, most magical beings

prefer wild places, places already empty of your kind. If a human had the misfortune to come across one, they might sense

something, see a blur on the horizon or a shadow out of the corner of their eye. But they'd likely be dead before they gave

it a second thought."

"And if they came across a daeva?"

He opened his palm, and his fiery pet flew into it, dissolving into smoke. "Oh, we'd eat them." At the alarm in her face,

he laughed and took another sip of wine. "A jest, little thief."

But Nahri wasn't in the mood for his jokes. "What about the ifrit?" she persisted. "What are they?"

The amusement vanished from his face. "Daevas. At least . . . they were once."

"Daevas?" she repeated in surprise. "Like you?"

"No." He looked offended. "Not like me. Not at all."

"Then like what?" She prodded his knee when he stayed silent. "You promised to--"

"I know, I know." He removed his cap to rub his brow, running his fingers through his black hair.

It was an entirely distracting motion. Nahri's eyes followed his hand, but she shut her wayward thoughts down, ignoring the

flutter in her stomach.

"You do know that if you have Nahid blood, you're likely going to live a few centuries." Dara lay back on the carpet to recline

on a propped wrist. "You should work on your patience."

"At this rate, it will take us a few centuries just to finish this conversation."

That brought a wry smile to his face. "You have their wit, I'll admit to that." He snapped his fingers, and another goblet

appeared in his hand. "Drink with me."

Nahri gave the goblet a suspicious sniff. It smelled sweet, but she hesitated. She hadn't had

a drop of wine in her life;

such a forbidden luxury was well beyond her means, and she wasn't sure how she'd react to alcohol. Drunks had always been easy pickings for a thief.

"Rejecting hospitality is a grave offense among my people," Dara warned.

Mostly to appease him, Nahri took a small sip. The wine was cloyingly sweet, more like a syrup than a liquid. "Is it truly?"

"Not at all. But I'm tired of drinking alone."

She opened her mouth to protest, irritated that she'd been so easily tricked, but the wine was already working, rolling down

her throat and spreading a warm drowsiness throughout her body. She swayed, grabbing for the rug.

Dara steadied her, his fingers hot on her wrist. "Careful."

Nahri blinked, her vision swimming for another moment. "By the Most High, your people must get nothing done if you drink things like this."

He shrugged. "A fair assessment of our race. But you wish to know of the ifrit."

"And why you think they want to kill me," she clarified. "Mostly that."

"We'll get to that bit of bad luck later," he said lightly. "First, you must understand that the earliest daevas were true

creatures of fire, formed and formless all at once. And very, very powerful."

"More powerful than you are now?"

"Far more. We could possess and imitate any creature, any object we desired, and our lives spanned eras. We were greater than

peris, maybe even greater than marid."

"Marid?"

"Water elementals," he replied. "No one's seen one in millennia--they'd be like gods to your kind. But the daevas were at peace

with all creatures. We stayed in our deserts while the peri and marids kept to their realms of sky and water. But then, humans were created."

Dara twirled his goblet in his hand. "My kind can be irrational," he confessed.

"Tempestuous. To see such weak creatures marching

across our lands, building their filthy cities of dirt and blood over our sacred sands . . . it was maddening. They became

a target . . . a plaything."

Goose bumps erupted across her skin. "And how exactly did the daevas

play

?"

A flash of embarrassment swept his bright eyes. "In all sorts of ways," he muttered, conjuring up a small pillar of white

smoke that thickened as she watched. "Kidnapping newlyweds, stirring up sandstorms to confuse a caravan, encouraging . . ."

He cleared his throat. "You know . . . worship."

Her mouth fell open. So the darker stories about djinn really did have their roots in truth. "No, I can't say that I do know.

I've never murdered merchants for my own amusement!"

"Ah, yes, my thief. Forgive me for forgetting that you are a paragon of honesty and goodness."

Nahri scowled. "So what happened next?"

"Supposedly the peri ordered us to stop." Dara's smoky pillar undulated in the wind at his side. "Khayzur's people fly to

the edge of Paradise; they hear things--at least they think they do. They warned that humans were to be left alone. Each elemental

race was to stick to its own affairs. Meddling with each other--especially with a lesser creature--was absolutely forbidden."

"And the daevas didn't listen?"

"Not in the slightest. And so we were cursed." He scowled. "Or 'blessed,' as the djinn see it now."

"How?"

"A man was called from among the humans to punish us." A hint of fear crossed Dara's face. "Suleiman," he whispered. "May

he be merciful."

"Suleiman?" Nahri repeated in disbelief. "As in the

Prophet

Suleiman?" When Dara nodded, she gasped. Her only education might have consisted of running from the law, but even she knew

who Suleiman was. "But he died thousands of years ago!"

"Three thousand," Dara corrected. "Give or take a few centuries."

A

horrifying thought took root in her mind. "You . . . you're not three thousand years--"

"No," he cut in, his voice terse. "This was before my time."

Nahri exhaled. "Of course." She could barely wrap her mind around how long three thousand years was. "But Suleiman was human.

What could he possibly do to a daeva?"

A dark expression flickered across Dara's face. "Anything he liked, apparently. Suleiman was given a seal ring--some say by

the Creator himself--that granted him the ability to control us. A thing he went about doing with a vengeance after we . . .

well,

supposedly

there was some sort of human war the daevas

might

have had a part in instigating--"

Nahri held up a hand. "Yes, yes, I'm sure it was a most unfair punishment. What did he do?"

Dara beckoned the smoky pillar forward. "Suleiman stripped us of our abilities with a single word and commanded that all daevas

come before him to be judged." The smoke spread before them; one corner condensed to become a misty throne while the rest

dissipated into hundreds of fiery figures the size of her thumb. They drifted past the carpet, their smoky heads bowed before the throne.

"Most obeyed; they were nothing without their powers. They went to his kingdom and toiled for a hundred years." The throne

vanished, and the fiery creatures swirled into workers heating bricks and stacking enormous stones several times their size.

A vast temple began to grow in the sky. "Those who made penance were forgiven, but there was a catch."

Nahri watched the temple rise, entranced. "What was it?"

The temple vanished, and the daevas were bowing again to the distant throne. "Suleiman didn't trust us," Dara replied. "He

said our very nature as shapeshifters made us manipulative and deceitful. So we were forgiven but changed forever."

In an instant, the fire was extinguished from the bowing daevas' smoky skin. They shrank in

size, and some grew hunched, their
spines bent in old age.

"He trapped us in humanlike bodies," Dara explained. "Bodies with limited abilities that only lasted a few centuries. It meant
that those daevas who originally tormented humanity would die and be replaced by their descendants, descendants Suleiman believed
would be less destructive."

"God forbid," Nahri cut in. "Only living for a few centuries with magical abilities . . . what an awful fate."

He ignored her sarcasm. "It was. Too awful for some. Not all daevas were willing to subject themselves to Suleiman's judgment
in the first place."

The familiar hate returned to his face. "The ifrit," she guessed.

He nodded. "The very same."

"The

very

same?" she repeated. "You mean they're still alive?"

"Unfortunately. Suleiman bound them to their original daeva bodies, but those bodies were meant to survive millennia." He

gave her a dark look. "I'm sure you can imagine what three thousand years of seething resentment does to the mind."

"But Suleiman took their powers away, didn't he? How much of a threat can they be?"

Dara raised his brows. "Did the thing that possessed your friend and ordered the dead to eat us seem powerless?" He shook

his head. "The ifrit have had millennia to test the boundaries of Suleiman's punishment and have risen to the task spectacularly.

Many of my people believe they descended to hell itself, selling their souls to learn new magic." He twisted his ring again.

"And they're obsessed with revenge. They believe humanity a parasite and consider my kind to be the worst of traitors for
submitting to Suleiman."

Nahri shivered. "So where do I fit in all this? If I'm just some lowly, mixed-blood shafit, why are they bothering with me?"

"I suspect it's whose blood--however little--you have in you that provoked their interest."

"These Nahids? The family of healers you mentioned?"

He nodded. "Anahid was Suleiman's vizier and the only daeva he ever trusted. When the daevas' penance was complete, Suleiman

not only gave Anahid healing abilities, he gave her his seal ring, and with it the ability to undo any magic--whether a harmless

spell gone wrong or an ifrit curse. Those abilities passed to her descendants, and the Nahids became the sworn enemies of

the ifrit. Even Nahid blood was poisonous to an ifrit, more fatal than any blade."

Nahri was suddenly very aware of how Dara was speaking of the Nahids. "

Was

poisonous?"

"The Nahid family is no more," Dara said. "The ifrit spent centuries hunting them down and killed the last, a pair of siblings,

about twenty years ago."

Her heart skipped a beat. "So what you're saying--" she started, her voice hoarse, "is that you think I'm the last living descendant

of a family that a group of crazed, revenge-obsessed former daevas have been trying to exterminate for the last three thousand

years?"

"You wanted to know."

She was sorely tempted to push him off the carpet. "I didn't think . . ." She trailed off as she noticed ash drifting up around

her. She looked down.

The carpet was dissolving.

Dara followed her gaze and let out a surprised cry. He backed away to a more solid patch in the blink of an eye and snapped

his fingers. Its edges smoking, the rug sped up as it descended toward the glistening Euphrates.

Nahri tried to appraise the water as they skimmed through the air above it. The current was rough but not as turbulent as

it had been in other spots; she could probably make it to shore.

She glanced up at Dara. His green eyes were so bright with alarm that it was difficult to look at his face. "Can you swim?"

"Can I

swim

?" he snapped, as if the very idea offended him. "Can you burn?"

But their luck held. They were already at the shallows when the carpet finally burst into burning crimson embers. Nahri tumbled

into a knee-high patch of river while Dara leaped for the rocky shore. He sniffed disdainfully as she staggered toward the riverbank covered in muck.

Nahri adjusted the makeshift strap of her bag. And then she stopped. She didn't have Dara's ring, but she had her supplies.

She was in the river, safely separated from the daeva by a band of water she knew he wouldn't cross.

Dara must have noticed her hesitation. "Still tempted to try your luck alone with the ifrit?"

"There's a lot you haven't told me," she pointed out. "About the djinn, about what happens when we get to Daevabad."

"I will. I promise." He gestured at the river, his ring sparkling in the light of the setting sun. "But I've no desire to

spend the coming days being looked at like some villainous abductor. If you want to return to the human world, if you wish

to risk the ifrit to return to bartering your talents for stolen coins, stay in the water."

Nahri glanced back at the Euphrates. Somewhere across the river, across deserts vaster than seas, was Cairo, the only home

she'd ever known. A hard place but familiar and predictable--completely unlike the future Dara offered.

"Or follow me," he continued, his voice smooth. Too smooth. "Find out what you really are, what really exists in this world.

Come to Daevabad where even a drop of Nahid blood will bring you honor and wealth beyond your imagining. Your own infirmery,

the knowledge of a thousand previous healers at your fingertips.

Respect

."

Dara offered his hand.

Nahri knew she should be suspicious, but, God, his words struck her heart. For how many years had she dreamed of Istanbul?

Of studying proper medicine with respected scholars? Learning to read books instead of pretending to read palms? How often

had she counted her savings in disappointment and put aside her hopes for a greater future?

She took his hand.

He pulled her free of the mud, his fingers scalding her own. "I'll cut your throat in your sleep if you're lying," she warned,

and Dara grinned, looking delighted at the threat. "Besides, how are we supposed to get to Daevabad? We've lost the rug."

The daeva nodded eastward. Set against the dark river and distant cliffs, Nahri could make out the bare brick lines of a large village.

"You're the thief," he challenged. "You're going to steal us some horses."

6: Ali

6

Ali

Wajed came for him at dawn.

"Prince Alizayd?"

Ali startled and looked up from his notes. The sight of the city's Qaid--the commander of the Royal Guard--would have made most

djinn startle, even if they weren't expecting to be arrested for treason at any minute.

He was a massively built warrior covered

in two centuries' worth of scars and welts.

But Wajed only smiled as he entered the Citadel's library, the closest thing Ali had to his own quarters. "Already hard at

work, I see," he said, motioning to the books and scrolls scattered on the rug.

Ali nodded. "I have a lesson to prepare."

Wajed snorted. "You and your lessons. Were you not so dangerous with that zulfiqar, one would think I'd raised an economist

instead of a warrior." His smile faded. "But I fear your students--however few they are--will have to wait. Your father's had

it with Bhatt. They can't get any more information out of him, and the Daevas are clamoring for his blood."

Though Ali had been expecting this moment since he'd first heard Anas had been captured alive, his stomach twisted, and he

struggled to keep his voice even. "Was he--?"

"Not yet. The grand wazir wants a spectacle, says it's the only thing that will satisfy his tribe." Wajed rolled his eyes;

he and Kaveh had never gotten along. "So we'll both need to be there."

A spectacle. Ali's mouth went dry, but he rose to his feet. Anas had sacrificed himself so that Ali might escape; he deserved

to have one friendly face at his execution. "Let me dress."

Wajed ducked out, and Ali quickly changed into his uniform, a tunic the color of obsidian, a white waist-wrap, and a gray

tasseled turban. He secured his zulfiqar to his waist and tucked his khanjar--the hooked dagger worn by all Geziri men--into

his belt. At least he'd look the part of a loyal soldier.

He joined Wajed at the stairs, and they descended the tower into the Citadel's heart. A large complex of sand-colored stone,

the Citadel was home to the Royal Guard, housing the barracks, offices, and training ground of the djinn army. His ancestors

had built it shortly after conquering Daevabad, its crenellated courtyard and stark stone tower an homage to Am Gezira, their distant homeland.

Even at this early hour, the Citadel was a hive of activity. Cadets drilled with zulfiqars in the courtyard and spearmen practiced

on an elevated platform. A half-dozen young men crowded around a free-standing door, attempting to break past its locking

enchantment. As Ali watched, one flew back from the door, the wood sizzling as his fellows burst into laughter. In the opposite

corner, a Tukharistani warrior-scholar dressed in a long felt coat, fur hat, and heavy gloves presented an iron shield to

a group of students gathered around him. He shouted an incantation, and a sheath of ice enveloped the shield. The scholar

tapped it with the butt of a dagger, and the entire thing shattered.

"When's the last time you saw your family?" Wajed asked as they reached the waiting horses at the end of the courtyard.

"A few months ago . . . well, more than a few, I suppose. Not since Eid," Ali admitted. He swung into his saddle.

Wajed tsked as they passed through the gate. "You should make a greater effort, Ali. You're blessed to have them so close."

Ali made a face. "I'd visit more often if it didn't involve going to that Nahid-haunted palace they call home."

The palace came into view just then, as they rounded a bend in the road. Its golden domes gleamed bright against the rising

sun, its white marble facade and walls shining pink in the rosy dawn light. The main building, an enormous ziggurat, sat heavy

on the stark cliffs overlooking Daevabad's lake. Surrounded by gardens still in shadow, it looked as if the massive step pyramid

was being swallowed by the spiky tops of blackened trees.

"It's not haunted," Wajed countered. "It simply . . . misses its founding family."

"The stairs vanished under me the last time I was there, uncle," Ali pointed out. "The water in the fountains turns to blood

so often that people don't drink it."

"So it misses them a lot."

Ali shook his head but stayed quiet as they crossed the waking city. They ascended the hilly road leading to the palace and

then entered the royal arena through the back. It was a place best suited for sunny days of competition, for boastful men

juggling incendiaries and women racing scaled simurgh firebirds. For entertainment.

That's exactly what this is for these people

. Ali gazed at the crowd with scorn. Though it was early, many of the stone seats were already taken, filled with an assortment

of nobles vying for his father's attention, curious pureblood commoners, angry Daevas, and what looked to be the entire ulema--Ali

suspected the clerics had been ordered to witness what happened when they failed to control the faithful.

He climbed up to the royal viewing platform, a tall stone terrace shaded by potted palm trees and striped linen curtains.

Ali didn't see his father but spotted Muntadhir near the front. His older half brother didn't look any happier than Ali to

be there. His curly black hair was mussed, and he seemed to be wearing the same clothes he'd probably gone out in last night,

an embroidered Agnivanshi jacket heavy with pearls and a lapis-colored silk waist-wrap, both wrinkled.

Ali could smell the wine on Muntadhir's breath from three paces away and suspected his brother had probably just been dragged

from a bed not his own. "Peace be upon you, Emir."

Muntadhir jumped. "By the Most High, akhi," he said, his hand over his heart. "Do you have to creep up on me like some sort

of assassin?"

"You should work on your reflexes. Where's Abba?"

Muntadhir nodded rudely toward a thin man in Daeva clothing at the terrace edge. "That one insisted on a public reading of

all the charges." He yawned. "Abba wasn't wasting his time on that--not when he has me to do it for him. He'll be here soon

enough."

Ali glanced at the Daeva man: Kaveh e-Pramukh, his father's grand wazir. Focused on the ground below, Kaveh didn't appear

to notice Ali's arrival. A satisfied smile played on his mouth.

Ali suspected he knew why. He took a deep breath and then stepped to the edge of the terrace.

Anas knelt on the sand below.

His sheikh had been stripped to the waist, burned and whipped, his beard hacked off in disrespect. His head was bowed, his

hands bound behind him. Though it had only been two weeks since his arrest, he'd clearly been starved, his ribs visible and

his bloody limbs thin. And those were only the wounds Ali could see. There would be others, he knew. Potions that made you

feel as if you were being stabbed by a thousand knives, illusionists who could make you hallucinate the deaths of your loved

ones, singers who could reach a pitch high enough to drive you to your knees while your ears bled. Men didn't survive the

dungeons of Daevabad. Not with their minds intact.

Oh, Sheikh, I'm so sorry . . .

The sight before him--a single shafit man with no magical abilities surrounded by hundreds of vengeful purebloods--seemed a

cruel joke.

"As for the crime of religious incitement . . ."

The sheikh swayed, and one of his guards jerked him upright. Ali went cold. The entire right side of Anas's face was smashed,

his eye swollen shut, his nose broken. A line of saliva dripped from his mouth, escaping past shattered teeth and swollen lips.

Ali pressed his zulfikar's scabbard. Anas met his stare. His eye flashed, the briefest of warnings before he dropped his gaze

again.

Earn this

. Ali remembered his sheikh's last command. He dropped his hand away from the weapon, aware of the eyes of the audience upon

him. He stepped back to join Muntadhir.

The judge droned on. "The illegal possession of weapons . . ."

There was an impatient snort from the other side of the arena, his father's karkadann, caged and hidden by a fiery gate. The

ground trembled as the beast stomped its feet. A horrid cross between a horse and an elephant, the karkadann was twice the

size of both, its scaly gray skin stained and matted with gore. The dust in the arena was heavy with its smell, the musk of

old blood. No one bathed a karkadann; none even got near save the pair of tiny

sparrows caged next to the creature. As Ali

listened, they began to sing. The karkadann settled down, placated for the moment.

"And as for the charge of--"

"By the Most High . . ." A voice boomed from behind Ali as the entire crowd shot to their feet. "Is this

still

going on?"

His father had arrived.

King Ghassan ibn Khader al Qahtani, ruler of the realm, Defender of the Faith. His name alone made his subjects tremble and

glance over their shoulders for spies. He was an imposing man, massive really, a combination of thick muscles and hearty appetite.

He was built like a barrel, and at the age of two hundred, his hair had just started to go gray, silver spotting his black

beard. It only made him more intimidating.

Ghassan strode to the edge of the terrace. The judge looked ready to wet himself, and Ali couldn't blame him. His father sounded

annoyed, and Ali knew the very thought of facing the king's legendary wrath had made more than one man's bowels give way.

Ghassan gave the bloodied sheikh a dismissive glance before turning to the grand wazir.

"The Tanzeem have terrorized Daevabad

long enough. We know their crimes. It's their patron I want, along with the men who helped him murder two of my citizens."

Kaveh shook his head. "He won't give them up, my king. We've tried everything."

"Banu Manizheh's old serums?"

Kaveh's pale face fell. "It killed the scholar who attempted it. The Nahids did not mean for their potions to be used by others."

Ghassan pursed his lips. "Then he's useless to me." He nodded to the guards standing over Anas. "Return to your posts."

There was a gasp from the direction of the ulema, a whispered prayer.

No

. Ali stepped forward, unthinking. There was punishment, and then there was

that

. He opened his mouth.

"Burn in hell, you wine-soaked ass."

It was Anas. There were several shocked murmurs from the crowd, but Anas pressed on, his fierce gaze locked on the king. "Apostate,"

he spat through broken teeth. "You betrayed us, the very people your family was meant to protect. You think it matters how

you kill me? A hundred more will rise in my place. You will suffer . . . in this world and the next." A savage edge entered

his voice. "And God will rip away from you those you hold most dear."

His father's eyes flashed, but he kept calm. "Unbind his hands before you return to your posts," he told the guards. "Let's

see him run."

Perhaps sensing its master's intentions, the karkadann roared, and the arena shook. Ali knew the rumbles would echo through

Daevabad, a warning to any who would disobey the king.

Ghassan raised his right hand. A striking mark high on his left cheek--an eight-pointed ebony star--began to glow.

Every torch in the arena went out. The stark black banners signifying his family's rule stopped fluttering, and Wajed's zulfiqar

lost its fiery gleam. Beside him, Muntadhir sucked in his breath, and a wave of dull weakness swept over Ali. Such was the

power of Suleiman's seal. When used, all magic, every trick and illusion of the djinn--of the peri, of the marid, of God only

knew how many magical races--failed.

Including the fiery gate that kept the karkadann enclosed.

The beast stepped forward, pawing at the ground with one of its three-toed yellow feet. Despite its massive bulk, it was its

horn--the length of a man and harder than steel--that was most feared. It jutted straight from its bony forehead, covered in

the dried blood of hundreds of previous victims.

Anas faced the beast. He squared his shoulders.

There ended up being little amusement for the king. Anas did not run, did not try to escape or beg for mercy. And it seemed

the beast was in no mood to torture its prey. It rushed out with a bellow and impaled the sheikh at his waist before raising

its head and tossing the doomed man to the dust.

It was done, it was quick. Ali let out a breath he didn't realize he was holding.

But then Anas stirred. The karkadann noticed. The beast approached more slowly this time,

sniffing and snorting at the ground.

It prodded Anas with its nose.

The karkadann had just lifted one foot over Anas's prone body when Muntadhir flinched and averted his gaze. Ali didn't look

away, didn't budge even when Anas's short scream was abruptly ended by a sickening crunch. From some distance away, one of the soldiers retched.

His father stared at the mangled corpse that had been the leader of the Tanzeem and then shot a long, intent look at the ulema

before turning to his sons. "Come," he said curtly.

The crowd dispersed while the karkadann pawed its bloodied prize. Ali didn't move. His eyes were locked on Anas's body, his

sheikh's scream ringing in his ears.

"Yalla, Zaydi." Muntadhir, still looking sick, nudged his shoulder. "Let's go."

Earn this

. Ali nodded. He had no tears to fight. He was too shocked to cry, too numb to do anything other than mutely follow his brother

into the palace.

The king swept down the long hallway, his ebony robe kissing the ground. Two servants abruptly about-faced to hurry down an

opposite corridor, and a low-ranking secretary threw himself on the floor in prostration.

"I want those fanatics gone," Ghassan demanded, his loud voice directed at no one in particular. "For good this time. I don't

want another shafit fool declaring himself a sheikh and popping up to wreak havoc in the streets next month." He shoved open

the door to his office, sending the servant meant to do so scrambling.

Ali followed Muntadhir inside, Kaveh and Wajed close at their heels. Tucked between the gardens and the royal court, the spacious

room was a deliberate blend of Daeva and Geziri design. Artists from the surrounding province of Daevastana were responsible

for the delicate tapestries of languorous figures and painted floral mosaics, while the simple geometric carpets and rough-hewn

musical instruments were from the Qahtanis' far more austere homeland of Am Gezira.

"There will be displeasure in the streets, my king," Wajed warned. "Bhatt was a well-liked man, and the shafit provoke easily."

"Good. I hope they riot," Ghassan retorted. "It will make it easier to root out the troublemakers."

"Unless they kill more of my tribesmen first," Kaveh cut in, his voice shrill. "Where were your soldiers, Qaid, when two Daevas

were hacked to death in their own quarter? How did the Tanzeem even pass the gate when it's supposed to be guarded?"

Wajed grimaced. "We're pressed thin, Grand Wazir. You know this."

"Then let us have our own guards!" Kaveh threw up his hands. "You've got djinn preachers declaring Daevas to be infidels,

the shafit calling for us to be burned to death in the Grand Temple--by the Creator, at least give us a chance to protect ourselves!"

"Calm

down

, Kaveh," Ghassan cut in. He collapsed into a low chair behind his desk and knocked aside an unopened scroll. It went rolling

away, but Ali doubted his father cared. Like many high-born djinn, the king was illiterate, believing reading was useless

if you had scribes who could do it for you. "Let's see if the Daevas themselves can go a half century without rebelling. I

know how easily your people get misty eyed about the past."

Kaveh shut his mouth, and Ghassan continued. "But I agree: it's time the mixed-bloods were reminded of their place." He pointed

at Wajed. "I want you to start enforcing the ban on more than ten shafit gathering in a private residence. I know it's fallen

into disuse."

Wajed looked reluctant. "It seemed cruel, my lord. The mixed-bloods are poor . . . they live as many to a room as possible."

"Then they shouldn't rebel. I want anyone with even the slightest of sympathies to Bhatt gone. Let it be known that if they

have children, I'll sell them. If they have women, I'll give them over to my soldiers."

Horried, Ali opened his mouth to protest, but Muntadhir beat him to it. "Abba, you can't really--"

Ghassan turned his fierce gaze on his eldest son. "Should I let these fanatics run free then? Wait until they've stirred the

whole city into flames?" The king shook his head. "These are the same men who claim we could free up jobs and homes for the

shafit by burning the Daevas to death in the Grand Temple."

Ali's head snapped up. He had dismissed the charge when Kaveh said it, but his father was not prone to exaggeration. Ali knew

Anas, like most shafit, had a lot of grievances when it came to the Daevas--it was their faith that called for the shafit to

be segregated, their Nahids who'd once routinely ordered the deaths of mixed-bloods with the same emotion one would rid a

home of rats. But Anas wouldn't really have called for the annihilation of the Daevas . . . would he?

His father's next comment pulled Ali from his thoughts. "We need to cut off their funding. Take that away, and the Tanzeem

are little more than puritanical beggars." He fixed his gray eyes on Kaveh. "Have you made any further progress in uncovering their sources?"

The grand wazir raised his hands. "Still no proof. All I have are suspicions."

Ghassan scoffed. "Weapons, Kaveh. A clinic on Maadi. Breadlines. That's the work of the rich. High-caste, pureblooded wealth.

How are you not able to find their patrons?"

Ali tensed, but it was clear from Kaveh's frustration that he held no further answers. "Their finances are sophisticated,

my king; their collection system may have even been designed by someone in the Treasury. They rotate the different tribal

currencies, trade supplies with some ridiculous paper money used among the humans . . ."

Ali felt the blood drain from his face as Kaveh listed just a few of the many loopholes in Daevabad's economy that Ali had

complained about--with thorough explanations--to Anas throughout the years.

Wajed's face perked up. "Human money?" He jerked a thumb at Ali. "You're always harping about that currency nonsense. Have

you taken a look at Kaveh's evidence?"

Ali's heart raced. Not for the first time, he thanked the Most High that the Nahids were dead. Even one of their half-trained

children would be able to tell he was lying. "I . . . no. The grand wazir did not consult with me." He thought fast, knowing

that Kaveh believed him a zealous idiot. He looked down at the Daeva man. "I suppose if you're having

trouble

. . ."

Kaveh bristled. "I've had the sharpest minds in the scholar's guild assisting me; I doubt the prince could offer more." He

gave Ali a withering look. "I

am

hearing a number of Ayaanle names among their rumored patrons," he added coolly before turning back to the king. "Including

one that might concern you. Ta Musta Ras."

Wajed blinked in surprise. "Ta Musta Ras? Isn't he one of the queen's cousins?"

Ali cringed at the mention of his mother, and his father scowled. "He is, and one I could easily see supporting a bunch of

dirt-blooded terrorists. The Ayaanle have always been fond of treating Daevabad's politics as a chessboard set for their amusement . . .

especially when they're safely ensconced in Ta Ntry." He fixed his gaze on Kaveh. "But no proof, you say?"

The grand wazir shook his head. "None, my king. But plenty of rumors."

"I can't arrest my wife's cousin over rumors. Especially not with Ayaanle gold and salt making up a third of my treasury."

"Queen Hatset is in Ta Ntry now," Wajed pointed out. "Do you think he would listen to her?"

"Oh, I don't doubt it," Ghassan said darkly. "He might already be."

Ali stared at his feet, his cheeks growing warm as they discussed his mother. He and Hatset weren't close. Ali had been taken

from the harem when he was five and given to Wajed to be groomed as Muntadhir's future Qaid.

His father sighed. "You'll have to go there yourself, Wajed. I trust no one else to speak to her. Let her and her entire damned

family know she doesn't return to Daevabad until the money stops. Should she wish to see her children again, the choice is hers."

Ali could feel Wajed's eyes upon him. "Yes, my king," Wajed said softly.

Kaveh looked alarmed. "Who will serve as Qaid while he's gone?"

"Alizayd. It's only for a few months and will be good practice for when I'm dead and this one"--Ghassan jerked his head in

Muntadhir's direction--"is too occupied with dancing girls to rule the realm."

Ali's mouth dropped open, and Muntadhir burst into laughter.

"Well, that should cut down on theft." His brother made a chopping motion across his wrist.

"Quite literally."

Kaveh went pale. "My king, Prince Alizayd is a child

. He's not even close to his first quarter century. You cannot possibly entrust the city's security to a sixteen--"

"

Eighteen

," Muntadhir corrected with a wicked grin. "Come now, Grand Wazir, there's an enormous difference."

Kaveh clearly didn't share the emir's amusement. His voice grew more pitched. "Eighteen-year-old boy. A boy who--might I remind you--once had a Daeva nobleman whipped in the street like a common shafit thief!"

"He

was

a thief," Ali defended. He remembered the incident, but was surprised Kaveh did; it was years ago, the first--and last--time

Ali had been allowed to patrol the Daeva Quarter. "God's law applies equally to all."

The grand wazir took a breath. "Trust me, Prince Alizayd, it is to my deep disappointment that you are not in Paradise where

we all follow God's law . . ." He didn't pause long enough for the double meaning of his words to land, but Ali picked it

up well enough. "But under Daevabad's law, the shafit are not equal to purebloods." He looked imploringly to the king. "Did you not just have someone executed for saying much the same thing?"

"I did," Ghassan agreed. "A lesson you would do well to remember, Alizayd. The Qaid enforces

my

law, not his own beliefs."

"Of course, Abba," Ali said quickly, knowing he'd been foolish to speak so plainly in front of them. "I will do as you command."

"See, Kaveh? Nothing to fear." Ghassan nodded in the direction of the door. "You may leave. Court will be held after the noon

prayer. Let word get out about this morning; perhaps that will cut down on the number of petitioners harassing me."

The Daeva minister looked like he had more to say, but he merely nodded, throwing Ali a vicious look as he left.

Wajed slammed the door shut behind him. "That snake has a twisted tongue, Abu Muntadhir," he said to the king, switching to

Geziriyya. "I'd like to make him wriggle like one." He caressed his zulfiqar. "Just once."

"Don't give your protege any ideas." Ghassan unwound his turban, leaving the brilliant silk in a heap on the desk. "Kaveh

is not wrong to be upset, and he doesn't even know the half of things." He nodded to a large crate sitting next to the balcony.

Ali hadn't noticed it earlier. "Show them."

The Qaid sighed but crossed to the crate. "An imam who runs a mosque near the Grand Bazaar contacted the Royal Guard a few

weeks ago and said he suspected Bhatt of recruiting one of his congregants." Wajed pulled free his khanjar and pried open

the crate's wooden slats. "My soldiers followed that man to one of his hideouts." He beckoned for Ali and Muntadhir. "We found this there."

Ali took a step closer, already sick. In his heart, he knew what was in that crate.

The weapons Anas swore he didn't have were packed in tight. Crude iron cudgels and battered steel daggers, studded maces and

a couple of crossbows. A half-dozen swords and a few of the long incendiary devices--rifles?--humans had invented, along with

a box of ammunition. Ali's disbelieving eyes scanned the crate and then his heart skipped a beat.

Zulfiqar training blades.

The words were out of Ali's mouth before he could stop himself. "Someone in the Royal Guard stole these."

Wajed gave him a grim nod. "It had to be. A Geziri man; we only let our own near those blades." He crossed his arms over his

massive chest. "They must have been stolen from the Citadel, but I suspect the rest were bought from smugglers." He met Ali's

horrified gaze. "There were three other crates like this one."

Beside him, Muntadhir exhaled. "What in God's name were they planning to do with all this?"

"I'm not sure," Wajed admitted. "They could have armed a few dozen shafit men at most. No real match for the Royal Guard,

but--"

"They could have murdered a score of people shopping in the Grand Bazaar," the king cut in. "They could have lain in wait

outside the Daevas' temple on one of their feast days and massacred a hundred pilgrims before help arrived. They could have started a war."

Ali gripped the crate, though he had no memory of reaching for it. In his mind, he saw the warriors he'd grown up with--the

cadets who'd fallen asleep on one another's shoulders after long days of training, the young men who teased and insulted one

another as they headed out on their first patrols. The ones Ali would soon swear to lead and protect as Qaid. They were the ones who would have likely faced these weapons.

Anger, swift and fierce, coursed through him, but Ali had no one to blame but himself.

You should have known. When the first rumors of weapons reached you, you should have stopped.

But Ali hadn't stopped. Instead, he'd accompanied Anas to that tavern. He'd stood by while two men were killed.

He took a deep breath. From the corner of his eye, he saw Wajed give him a curious look. He straightened up.

"But why?" Muntadhir pressed. "What would the Tanzeem have to gain?"

"I don't know," Ghassan replied. "And I don't care. It took years to bring peace to Daevabad after the deaths of the last

Nahids. I don't intend to let some dirt-blood fanatics eager for martyrdom tear us apart." He pointed at Wajed. "The Citadel

will find the men responsible and execute them. If they are Geziri, do it quietly. I don't need the Daevas thinking our tribe

supports the Tanzeem. And you will put in place the new restrictions on the shafit. Ban their gatherings. Throw them in prison

if they so much as step on a pureblood's foot. For now, at least." He shook his head.

"God willing, we'll get through the next few months without any surprises, and we'll be able to ease them again."

"Yes, my king."

Ghassan waved at the crate. "Get rid of that thing before Kaveh sniffs it out. I've had enough of his ranting for one day."

He rubbed his brow and sank back into his chair, his jeweled rings gleaming. He glanced up, fixing his sharp gaze on Muntadhir.

"Also . . . should I need to execute another shafit traitor, my emir will watch without flinching else he'll find himself
carrying out the next sentence."

Muntadhir crossed his arms, leaning against the desk in a familiar manner Ali never would have dared. "Ya, Abba, if I knew

you were going to have his head crushed like an overripe melon, I would have skipped breakfast."

Ghassan's eyes flashed. "Your younger brother managed to control himself."

Muntadhir laughed. "Yes, but Ali is Citadel trained. He'd dance in front of the karkadann if you told him to."

Their father didn't seem to appreciate the jest, his face growing stormy. "Or perhaps spending all your time drinking with

courtesans and poets has weakened your constitution." He glared. "You should be glad of your future Qaid's training--God knows

you're likely to need it." He rose from his desk. "And on that note, I would speak to your brother alone."

What? Why?

Ali was barely holding his emotions in check; he didn't want to be alone with his father.

Wajed squeezed his shoulder and briefly leaned in toward Ali's ear. "Breathe, boy," he whispered as Ghassan stood and strolled

toward the balcony. "He doesn't bite." He flashed Ali a reassuring smile and followed Muntadhir out of the office.

There was a long moment of silence. His father studied the garden, his hands clasped behind him.

His back was still to Ali when he asked, "Do you believe that?"

Ali's voice came out in a squeak. "Believe what?"

"What you said before." His father turned around, his dark gray eyes intent. "About God's law applying equally-- By the Most

High, Alizayd, stop

shaking

. I need to be able to talk to my Qaid without him turning into a trembling mess."

Ali's embarrassment was tempered with relief--far better for Ghassan to blame his anxiety on nerves from being made Qaid. "I'm

sorry."

"It's fine." Ghassan leveled his gaze on him again. "Answer the question."

Ali thought fast, but there was no way he could lie. His family knew he was devout--he had been since childhood--and their religion

was clear on the issue of the shafit. "Yes," he replied. "I believe the shafit should be treated equally. That's why our ancestors

came to Daevabad. That's why Zaydi al Qahtani went to war with the Nahids."

"A war that nearly destroyed our entire race. A war that ended in the sacking of Daevabad and earned us the enmity of the

Daeva tribe until this day."

Ali startled at his father's words. "Do you not think it was worth it?"

Ghassan looked irritated. "Of course I think it was worth it. I'm simply capable of seeing both sides of an issue. It's a

skill you should try to develop." Ali's cheeks grew hot, and his father continued.

"Besides, there weren't this many shafit

in Zaydi's time."

Ali frowned. "Are they that numerous now?"

"Nearly a third of the population. Yes," he said, noticing the surprise in Ali's face. "Their numbers have burgeoned immensely

in recent decades--information you'd do best to keep to yourself." He gestured to the weapons. "There are now almost as many

shafit in Daevabad as there are Daevas, and truthfully, my son, if they went to war in the streets, I'm not sure the Royal

Guard could stop them. The Daevas would win in the end, of course, but it would be bloody, and it would destroy the city's

peace for generations."

"But that's not going to happen, Abba," Ali argued. "The shafit aren't fools. They just want a better life for themselves.

They want to be able to work and live in buildings that aren't coming down around them. To take care of their families without

fearing their children will be snatched away by some pure--"

Ghassan interrupted. "When you come up with a way to provide jobs and housing for thousands of people, let me know. And if

their lives were made easier here, they would only reproduce faster."

"Then let them

leave

. Let them try to make better lives in the human world."

"Let them cause chaos in the human world, you mean." His father shook his head.

"Absolutely not. They may look human, but

many still have magic. We'd be inviting another Suleiman to curse us." He sighed.
"There's no easy answer, Alizayd. All we
can do is strike a balance."

"But we're not striking a balance," Ali argued. "We're choosing the fire worshippers over the
shafit our ancestors came here
to protect."

Ghassan whirled on him. "The
fire worshippers
?"

Too late Ali remembered the Daevas hated that term for their tribe. "I didn't mean--"

"Then don't ever repeat such a thing in my presence." His father glared at him. "The Daevas
are under my protection, same
as our own tribe. I don't care what faith they practice." He threw up his hands. "Hell,
maybe they're right to obsess over
blood purity. In all my years, I've never encountered a Daeva shafit."

They probably smother them in their cradles

. But Ali didn't say that. He'd been a fool to pick this fight today.

Ghassan ran a hand along the wet windowsill and then shook off the water droplets that had
gathered upon his fingertips. "It's
always wet here. Always cold. I haven't been back to Am Gezira in a century and yet
every morning, I wake up missing its hot
sands." He glanced back at Ali. "This is not our home. It never will be. It will always
belong to the Daevas first."

It's my home

. Ali was accustomed to Daevabad's damp chill and liked the diverse mix of peoples that
filled its streets. He'd felt out
of place during his rare trips to Am Gezira, always conscious of his half-Ayaanle
appearance.

"It's their home," Ghassan continued. "And I am their king. I will not allow the shafit--a
problem the Daevas had no part in
creating--to threaten them in their own home." He turned to face Ali. "If you are to be
Qaid, you must respect this."

Ali lowered his gaze. He didn't respect it; he entirely disagreed. "Forgive my impertinence."

He suspected that wasn't the answer Ghassan wanted--his father's eyes stayed sharp
another moment before he abruptly crossed

the room toward the wooden shelves lining the opposite wall. "Come here."

Ali followed. Ghassan picked up a long, lacquered black case from one of the upper shelves. "I hear nothing but compliments

from the Citadel about your progress, Alizayd. You've a keen mind for military science and you're one of the best zulfiqari

in your generation. None would dispute that. But you're very young."

Ghassan blew the dust off the case and then opened it, pulling a silver arrow from a bed of fragile tissue. "Do you know what

this is?"

Ali certainly did. "It's the last arrow shot by an Afshin."

"Bend it."

A little confused, Ali nonetheless took the arrow from his father. Though it was incredibly light, he couldn't bend it in

the slightest. The silver still gleamed after all these years, only the scythe-ended tip dulled by blood. The same blood that

ran in Ali's veins.

"The Afshins were good soldiers too," Ghassan said softly. "Probably the best warriors of our race. But now they're dead,

their Nahid leaders are dead, and our people have ruled Daevabad for fourteen centuries. And do you know why?"

Because they were infidels, and God willed us to victory?

Ali held his tongue; he suspected if he said that, the arrow would be getting a new coat of Qahtani blood.

Ghassan took the arrow back. "Because they were like this arrow. Like you. Unwilling to bend, unwilling to see that not everything

fit into their perfectly ordered world." He put the weapon back in the case and snapped it shut. "There is more to being Qaid

than being a good soldier. God willing, Wajed and I have another century of wine and ridiculous petitioners ahead of us, but

one day Muntadhir will be king. And when he needs guidance, when he needs to discuss things only his blood can hear, he'll

need you."

"Yes, Abba." Ali was willing to say anything at this point to leave, anything that would let him escape his father's measured

gaze.

"There's one more thing." His father stepped away from the shelf. "You're moving back to the palace. Immediately."

Ali's mouth dropped open. "But the Citadel is my home."

"No . . .

my

home is your home," Ghassan said, looking irritated. "Your place is here. It's time you start attending court to see how

the world works outside your books. And I'll be able to keep a better eye on you--I don't like the way you're talking about the Daevas."

Dread welled up in Ali, but his father didn't press the issue. "You can go now. I'll expect you at court when you're settled in."

Ali nodded and bowed; it was all he could do not to run for the door. "Peace be upon you."

He'd no sooner stumbled into the corridor than he ran into his grinning brother.

Muntadhir pulled him into a hug. "Congratulations, akhi. I'm sure you're going to make a terrifying Qaid."

"Thanks," Ali mumbled. He'd just witnessed the brutal death of his closest friend. That he was soon to be in charge of maintaining security for a city of bickering djinn was something he'd yet to dwell on.

Muntadhir didn't seem to pick up on his distress. "Did Abba tell you the other good news?" When Ali made a noncommittal sound, he continued. "You're moving back to the palace!"

"Oh." Ali frowned. "That."

His brother's face fell. "You don't sound very excited."

A fresh wave of guilt swept over Ali at the hurt in Muntadhir's voice. "It's not that, Dhiru. It's . . . it's been a long morning. Taking over for Wajed, the news about the weapons . . ." He exhaled. "Besides, I've never been very . . ." He searched for a way to avoid insulting his brother's entire social circle. ". . .

comfortable

around people here."

"Ah, you'll be fine." Muntadhir threw his arm around Ali's shoulder, half-dragging him down the corridor. "Stick by me, and

I'll make sure you get embroiled in only the most delightful of scandals." He laughed when Ali gave him a startled look. "Come.

Zaynab and I picked you out apartments near the waterfall." They turned the corner.

"With the most boring furnishings and
least comfortable amenities. You'll be right at ho--whoa."

The brothers drew to an immediate stop. They had to. A wall stood in their way, a jewel-colored mural splashed across the
stone.

"Well . . ." Muntadhir's voice was shaky. "That's new."

Ali edged closer. "No . . . it's not," he said softly, recognizing the scene and remembering his long-ago history lessons.

"It's one of the old Nahid murals. They used to cover the palace walls before the war."

"It wasn't here yesterday." Muntadhir touched the mural's bright sun. It flashed beneath his fingertips, and they both jumped.

Ali gave the mural an uneasy look. "And you wonder why I'm not excited about moving back to this Nahid-haunted place?"

Muntadhir made a face. "It's not usually this bad." He nodded to one of the figures on the cracked plaster facade. "Do you
know who that's supposed to be?"

Ali studied the image. The figure looked human, a man with a flowing white beard and a silver halo above his crowned head.

He stood before a crimson sun, one hand resting on the back of a roaring shedu, and the other holding a staff with an eight-pointed
seal. The same seal that was on Ghassan's right temple.

"It's Suleiman," Ali realized. "Peace be upon him." He gazed at the rest of the painting. "I think it depicts the ascension

of Anahid when she received her abilities and Suleiman's seal." His eyes fell on the bent figure at Suleiman's feet. Only

her back was visible, the long taper of her ears giving away that she was a djinn. Or daeva, rather. Anahid, first of her
line.

Blue paint flooded Suleiman's robes.

"Odd," Muntadhir remarked. "I wonder why it picked today of all days to start trying to repair fourteen centuries of damage."

A shiver went down Ali's spine. "I don't know."

7: Nahri

7

Nahri

"Raise your arm higher."

Nahri lifted her elbow, tightening her grip on the dagger. "Like this?"

Dara made a face. "No." He stepped up to her, the scent of his smoky skin tickling her nose, and adjusted her arm. "Loosen

up; you need to be relaxed. You're throwing a knife, not beating someone with a stick."

His hand lingered a moment longer than necessary on her elbow, his breath warm against her neck. Nahri shivered; relaxing

was a thing easier said than done when the handsome daeva was so close. He finally stepped away, and she fixed her eyes on

the scrubby tree. She threw the dagger, and it sailed past the tree to land in a patch of bushes.

Dara burst into laughter as she swore. "I'm not sure we're going to be able to make much of a warrior out of you." He opened

his palm, and the dagger flew back to him.

Nahri gave him an envious look. "Can't you teach me how to do that?"

He handed the knife back. "No. I've told you enough times . . ."

". . . magic is unpredictable," she finished. She threw the dagger again. She could have sworn it landed slightly closer to

the tree, but that might have been her own wishful thinking. "So what if it is? Are you truly afraid of what I might do?"

"Yes," he said bluntly. "For all I know, you'll send fifty such knives flying back at us."

Ah, well, perhaps he had a point. She waved the knife away when he tried to hand it back.

"No. I've had enough for today.

Can't we just rest? We've been traveling as if--"

"As if a pack of ifrit are after us?" His raised his eyebrows.

"We'll travel faster if we're not exhausted," she replied, taking his arm and pulling him in the direction of their small

camp. "Come on."

"We'd travel faster if we weren't carting around a caravan of stolen goods," Dara retorted,

snapping off a twig from a dying
tree and letting it burn to cinders in his hands. "How many clothes do you truly
need? And you're not even eating the oranges . . .
to say nothing of that entirely useless flute."

"That flute is ivory, Dara. It's worth a fortune. Besides . . ." Nahri held out her arms, briefly
admiring the embroidered
tunic and brown leather boots she'd snatched off a stall they passed in one of the
river towns. "I'm just trying to keep our
supplies well stocked."

They reached their camp, though "camp" might have been too kind a word for the little
clearing where Nahri had stomped down
the grass before dropping her bags. The horses were grazing in a distant field,
eating any bit of greenery down to the roots.

Dara knelt and rekindled their fire with a snap of his fingers. The flames jumped,
illuminating the dark tattoo on his frowning
face.

"Your ancestors would be horrified to see how easily you take to stealing."

"According to you, my ancestors would be horrified to learn of my very existence." She
pulled out a well-wrapped heel of stale
bread. "And it's the way the world works. By now, people have certainly broken into
my home in Cairo and stolen my things."

He tossed a broken branch on the fire, sending up sparks. "How does that make it better?"

"Someone steals from me, I steal from others, and I'm sure the people I stole from will
eventually take something that doesn't
belong to them. It's a circle," she added wisely, as she gnawed on the chewy bread.

Dara stared at her for a good few heartbeats before speaking. "There is something very
wrong with you."

"Probably comes from my daeva blood."

He scowled. "It's your turn to fetch the horses."

Nahri groaned; she had little desire to leave the fire. "And what are you going to do?"

But Dara was already retrieving a battered pot from one of their bags. She'd stolen it along
the way, hoping to find something
to cook that wasn't manna. And after listening to her complain about their food
situation for days, Dara had taken it upon
himself to try and figure out how to conjure up something different. But Nahri wasn't
hopeful. All he'd managed thus far was
a vaguely warm gray soup that tasted like the ghouls smelled.

Night had fallen by the time Nahri returned with the horses. The darkness in this land fell quick and was thick enough to

feel, a heavy, impenetrable blackness that would have made her nervous if she didn't have their campfire to guide her. Even

the thick canopy of stars above did little to alleviate it, their light captured by the white mountains surrounding them.

They were covered in snow, Dara explained, a concept she could scarcely imagine. This country was completely foreign to her,

and though it was novel and in some ways even beautiful, she found herself longing for Cairo's busy streets, for the crowded

bazaars and squabbling merchants. She missed the golden desert that embraced her city and the wide, brown Nile that twisted through it.

Nahri tied the horses to a skinny tree. The temperature had dropped dramatically with the sun, and her cold fingers fumbled

the knot. She wrapped one of the blankets around her shoulders and then took a seat as close to the fire as she dared.

Dara wasn't even wearing his robe. She stared jealously at his bare arms.

Must be nice to be made of fire

. Whatever daeva blood she had clearly wasn't enough to keep the chill away.

The pot steamed at his feet; he pushed it over with a triumphant smile. "Eat."

She took a suspicious sniff. It smelled good, like buttery lentils and onions. Nahri ripped off a strip of bread from her

bag and dipped it into the pot. She took a guarded bite and then another. It tasted as good as it smelled, like cream and

lentils and some type of leafy green. She quickly reached for more bread.

"Do you like it?" he asked, his voice rising in hope.

After all the manna, anything edible would have been appetizing, but this was legitimately delicious. "I love it!" She scooped

more into her mouth, savoring the warm stew. "How did you finally do it, then?"

Dara looked tremendously pleased with himself. "I tried to concentrate on the dish I knew best. I think the focus helped--a

lot of magic has to do with your intentions." He paused, and his smile faded. "It was something my mother used to make."

Nahri almost choked; Dara had revealed nothing about his past and even now she could see a guarded look slip across his face.

Hoping he wouldn't change the subject, she quickly replied, "She must be a very

good cook."

"She was." He drank back the rest of his wine, and the goblet immediately refilled.

"Was?" Nahri ventured.

Dara stared into the fire; his fingers twitched like he longed to touch it. "She's dead."

Nahri dropped her bread. "Oh. Dara, I'm sorry, I didn't realize--"

"It is fine," he interrupted, though the tone of his voice implied it was anything but. "It was a long time ago."

Nahri hesitated but couldn't contain her curiosity. "And the rest of your family?"

"Dead as well." He gave her a sharp look, his emerald eyes bright. "There's no one but me."

"I can relate," she said softly.

"Indeed. I suppose you can." A goblet suddenly materialized in her hand. "Drink with me, then," he commanded, raising his

goblet in her direction. "You'll choke if you don't wash down that food. I don't think I've ever seen anyone eat so quickly."

He was changing the subject, and they both knew it. Nahri shrugged, taking a sip of the wine. "You'd do the same if you grew

up like me. Sometimes I didn't know when I'd eat next."

"I could tell." He snorted. "You didn't look much thicker than the ghouls when I first found you. Curse the manna all you

like, at least it filled you out some."

Nahri lifted an eyebrow. "'Filled me out some'?" she repeated.

Dara was immediately flustered. "I-I didn't mean in a bad way. Just that, you know . . ." He made a vague sweeping motion

toward her body and then blushed, perhaps realizing such a gesture didn't help.

"Never mind," he muttered, dropping his embarrassed gaze.

Oh, I know, believe me

. For all Dara supposedly abhorred the shafit, Nahri had caught him staring at her more than once, and their dagger-throwing

lesson hadn't been the first time his hand had lingered upon her a bit too long.

She kept her gaze on him, studying the broad line of his shoulders and watching as he played nervously with his goblet, still

avoiding her eyes. His fingers trembled on the stem, and for a moment Nahri could not help but wonder if they would do the

same upon her skin.

Because things are not tumultuous enough between us without adding
that
to the mix.

Before her mind could go any further, Nahri changed the subject again to one she knew would thoroughly ruin the mood. "So
tell me about these Qahtanis."

Dara startled. "What?"

"These djinn you keep insulting, the ones who supposedly fought my ancestors." She took a sip of her wine. "Tell me about
them."

Dara made a face as if he'd eaten something sour. One objective achieved. "Must we really do this now? It's late--"

She shook a finger at him. "Don't make me go looking for another ghoul to threaten you into talking."

He didn't smile at the joke, instead looking more troubled. "It's not a pleasant tale, Nahri."

"All the more reason to get it over with."

He took a sip of wine, a long sip, as if he needed a dose of courage. "I told you before that Suleiman was a clever man. Before

his curse, all daevas were the same. We looked similar, spoke a single language, practiced identical rites." Dara beckoned

at their fire, and its tendrils of smoke rushed toward his hands like an eager lover. "When Suleiman freed us, he scattered
us across the world he knew, changing our tongues and appearances to mirror the humans in our new lands."

Dara spread his hands. The smoke flattened and condensed to form a thick map in the sky before her, Suleiman's temple at the

center. As she watched, blazing pinpricks of light spun out from the temple across the world, falling to the ground like meteorites
and bouncing back as fully formed people.

"He divided us into six tribes." Dara pointed at a pale woman weighing jade coins at the eastern edge of the map, China perhaps.

"The Tukharistanis." He gestured south at a bejeweled dancer twirling in the Indian subcontinent. "The Agnivanshi." A tiny

rider burst out of the smoke, galloping across southern Arabia and brandishing a fiery sword. Dara pursed his lips and with

a snap of his fingers lopped off its head. "The Geziri." To the south of Egypt, a golden-eyed scholar tossed a brilliant teal scarf over his shoulder as he scanned a scroll. Dara nodded at him. "The Ayaanle," he said and then pointed to a fire-haired man mending a boat on the Moroccan coast. "The Sahrayn."

"What about your people?"

"

Our

people," he corrected and gestured toward the flat plains of what looked like Persia to her, or perhaps Afghanistan. "Daevastana," he said warmly. "The land of the Daevas."

She frowned. "Your tribe took the original name of the entire daeva race as your own?"

Dara shrugged. "We were in charge."

He studied the map. The smoky figures silently shouted and gesticulated at each other. "It was said to be a violent, terrifying

time. Most people embraced their new tribes, clinging together for survival and forming within the tribes caste groups determined

by their new abilities. Some were shapeshifters, others could manipulate metals, some could conjure up rare goods, and so

forth. None could do it all, and the tribes were too busy fighting each other to even consider revenge against Suleiman."

Nahri smiled, impressed. "Surely even you must admit that was rather a brilliant move on Suleiman's part."

"Perhaps," Dara replied. "But brilliant as he might have been, Suleiman failed to consider the consequences of giving my people solid, mortal bodies."

The tiny figures continued to multiply, building small villages and crisscrossing the vast world in spindly caravans. Occasionally a miniature flying carpet dashed across the smoky clouds.

"What consequences?" Nahri asked, confused.

He gave her a playful smile that didn't quite reach his eyes. "That we could mate with humans."

"And make shafit," she realized. "People like me."

Dara nodded. "Completely forbidden, mind you." He sighed. "You may have realized by now that we're not particularly good at

following rules."

"I'm guessing those shafit multiplied pretty quickly?"

"Very." He gestured to the smoky map. "Like I say, magic is unpredictable." A tiny city in the Maghreb burst into flames.

"Made even more so in the hands of mix-blooded, untrained practitioners." Enormous ships, in a variety of bizarre shapes crossed the Red Sea, and winged cats with human faces soared over the Hind. "Although most shafit don't have any abilities, the few that do have the capacity to inflict terrible damage on their human societies."

Damage like leading a pack of ghouls through Cairo and tricking bashas out of their wealth? Nahri had little argument there. "But why did the daevas--or djinn, or whatever you were calling yourselves at the time--even care?" she asked. "I thought your race didn't think much of humans anyway."

"They wouldn't have," Dara admitted. "But Suleiman made it quite clear that another would follow in his place to punish us again should we ignore his law. The Nahid Council struggled for years to contain the shafit problem, ordering that any humans suspected of having magical blood be brought to Daevabad to live out their lives."

Nahri went still. "The

Nahid

Council? But I thought the Qahtanis were the ones--"

"I'll get to that part," Dara cut in, his voice a little colder--and slightly more slurred--than usual. He took another long sip of wine. The goblet never seemed to empty, so Nahri could only imagine how much he'd consumed by now. Far more than her, and her head was starting to swim.

A city rose from the smoky map in Daevastana, in the center of a dark lake. Its walls gleamed like brass, beautiful against the dark sky. "Is that Daevabad?" she asked.

"Daevabad," Dara confirmed. His eyes dimmed as he stared at the tiny city, longing in his face. "Our grandest city. Where Anahid built her palace and from where her descendants ruled the realm until they were overthrown."

"Let me guess . . . by all the kidnapped shafit they kept locked up?"

Dara shook his head. "No. No shafit could have ever done such a thing; they're too weak."

"Then who did?"

Dara's face darkened. "Who didn't?" When she frowned in confusion, he continued. "The other tribes never paid much heed to

Suleiman's decree. Oh, they

claimed

to agree that humans and daevas should be segregated, but they were the source of the shafit."

He nodded at the map. "The Geziri were the worst. They were fascinated by the humans in their land, praising their prophets

and adopting their culture--with some inevitably getting too close. They're the poorest tribe, a pack of religious fanatics

who believe what Suleiman did to us was a blessing not a curse. They often refused to surrender shafit kin, and when the Nahid

Council grew more severe in their enforcement of the law, the Geziri didn't react well."

A black swarm rose in the Rub al Khali, the forbidding desert north of the Yemen. "They started calling themselves 'djinn,'"

Dara said. "The word the humans in their land used for our race. And when their leader, a man named Zaydi al Qahtani, called

for an invasion, the other tribes joined him." The black cloud grew enormous as it descended upon Daevabad and stained the

lake. "He overthrew the Nahid Council and stole Suleiman's seal." Dara's next words came out in a hiss. "His descendants rule

Daevabad to this day."

Nahri watched as the city slowly turned black. "How long ago was all this?"

"About fourteen hundred years ago." Dara's mouth was a thin line. Within the smoky map, the tiny version of Daevabad, now

black as coal, collapsed.

"Fourteen hundred years ago?" She studied the daeva, noticing the tense way he held his body and the scowl on his handsome

face. Something stirred in her memory. "This . . . this is the war you were discussing with Khayzur, isn't it?" Her mouth

fell open. "Didn't you say you

witnessed

it?"

He drank back the rest of his wine. "You don't miss much, do you?"

Nahri's head spun from the admission. "But how? You said the djinn only lived for a few centuries!"

"It doesn't matter." He dismissed her with a wave of his hand, but the movement wasn't as graceful as usual. "My history is just that: mine."

She was incredulous. "And you don't think this king is going to want an explanation when we show up in Daevabad?"

"I'm not going to Daevabad."

"

What?

But I thought . . . where are we going then?"

Dara looked away. "I'll take you as far as the city gates. You can make your way to the palace from there. You'll be received better alone, trust me."

Nahri drew back, shocked and far more hurt than she should have been. "You're just going to abandon me?"

"I'm not

abandoning

you." Dara exhaled and threw up his hands, gesturing rudely to the pile of weapons behind him. "Nahri, what kind of history do you think I have with these people? I can't go back."

Her temper flashed, and she rose to her feet. "You coward," she accused him. "You misled me back at the river and you know

it. I never would have agreed to go to Daevabad with you if I'd known you were so afraid of the djinn that you were planning to--"

"I am

not

afraid of the djinn." Dara also rose to his feet, his eyes flaring. "I sold my soul for the Nahids! I'm not going to spend eternity languishing in a dungeon while I listen to the djinn mock them for being hypocrites."

"But they

were

hypocrites--look at me! I'm living proof!"

His face darkened. "I am all too aware of that."

That stung, she couldn't deny it. "Is that what this is about then? You're ashamed of me?"

"I . . ." Dara shook his head. Something like regret seemed to briefly flicker in his face before he turned away. "Nahri,
you didn't grow up in my world. You can't understand."

"Thank God I didn't! I probably would have been killed before my first birthday!"

Dara said nothing, his silence more revealing than any denial. Her stomach twisted. She'd been imagining her ancestors as

noble healers, but what Dara suggested painted a far darker picture. "Then I'm glad the djinn invaded," she said, her voice
hoarse. "I hope they got vengeance for all the shafit my ancestors murdered!"

"Vengeance?" Dara's eyes flashed, smoke curling out from under his collar. "Zaydi al Qahtani slaughtered every last Daeva
man, woman, and child when he took the city. My

family

was in that city. My sister wasn't even half your age!"

Nahri immediately backed down, seeing the grief in his face. "I'm sorry. I didn't . . ."

But he'd already turned away. He crossed toward their supplies, moving so fast the grass scorched beneath his feet. "I don't

need to listen to this." He snatched his bag from the ground, slinging his bow and quiver over his shoulder before shooting
her a hostile look. "You think your ancestors--

my

leaders--such monsters, the Qahtanis so righteous . . ." He jerked his head toward the encompassing darkness. "Why don't you
try singing for a djinn to save you next?"

And then before Nahri could say anything, before she could really comprehend what was happening, he stalked off, vanishing
into the night.

8: Ali

8

Ali

Where is he?

Ali paced outside his father's office. Muntadhir was supposed to meet him here before court, but it was getting late and there
was still no sign of his perpetually tardy brother.

He gave the closed office door an anxious look. People had been passing through all morning, but Ali could not yet bring himself
to go in. He felt terribly unprepared for his first day at court and had barely slept the night before, the spacious bed in
his extravagant new quarters too soft and covered in an alarming number of beaded pillows. He'd finally settled for sleeping
on the floor, only to be assailed by nightmares of being thrown to the karkadann.

Ali sighed. He took one last look down the corridor, but there was no sign of Muntadhir.

A flurry of activity greeted him when he entered the office, scribes and secretaries loaded with scrolls dashing past assorted
ministers arguing in a dozen different languages. His father was at his desk, listening intently to Kaveh while one servant
waved an incense burner of smoldering frankincense over his head and another adjusted the stiff collar of the white dishdasha
he wore under his immaculate black robes.

No one seemed to notice Ali, and he was happy to keep it that way. Dodging a wine bearer, he pressed against the wall.

As if on some prearranged signal, the room began to disperse, the servants slinking away and the ministers and secretaries
making their way toward the doors leading to the king's massive audience hall. Ali watched as Kaveh made a notation on the
paper in his hand and nodded.

"I'll be sure to tell the High Priests that . . . ," he trailed off and then abruptly straightened up as he noticed Ali. His
face turned stormy. "Is this some sort of joke?"

Ali had no idea what he'd already done wrong. "I . . . I was supposed to come here, right?"

Kaveh gestured rudely at his clothes. "You're

supposed

to be in ceremonial dress, Prince Alizayd. Robes of state. I had tailors sent to you last night."

Ali mentally cursed himself. Two anxious Daeva men

had

presented themselves to him last night, stammering something about measurements, but Ali had dismissed them, not thinking

much of it at the time. He neither desired nor needed new clothes.

He glanced down. His sleeveless gray tunic had only a couple of gashes where he'd been slashed during practice, and his indigo

waist-wrap was dark enough to hide its zulfiqar burns. It looked fine to him.

"These are clean," he argued. "I only wore them yesterday." He gestured to his turban; the crimson cloth indicated his new

position as Qaid. "This is all that matters, no?"

"No!" Kaveh looked incredulous. "You're a Qahtani prince--you can't go to court looking like someone just dragged you in from

a sparring match!" He threw up his hands and turned to the king. Ghassan had said nothing, simply watching them fight with

a strange twinkle in his eyes. "Do you see this?" he demanded. "Now we'll have to start late so your son can be properly--"

Ghassan laughed.

It was a full-throated, hearty laugh, one Ali hadn't heard from his father in years. "Aye, Kaveh, let him be." The king came

from behind the desk and clapped Ali on the back. "He has Am Gezira in his blood," he said proudly. "Back home, we never bothered

with all this ceremonial nonsense." He chuckled as he led Ali toward the door. "If he looks like he just finished thrashing someone with a zulfiqar, so be it."

His father's praise was not a thing doled out often, and Ali could not help but feel his spirits lift. He glanced around as

a servant reached for the door leading to the audience chamber. "Abba, where's Muntadhir?"

"With the trade minister from Tukharistan. He's . . .

negotiating

a deal to reduce the debt we owe for the Royal Guard's new uniforms."

"Muntadhir's negotiating our debts?" Ali asked skeptically. His brother and numbers did not go well together. "I didn't think
economics his strong suit."

"It's not that type of negotiation." When Ali's confused frown only deepened, Ghassan shook his head. "Come along, boy."

It had been years since Ali had last been in his father's throne room, and he paused to fully appreciate it as they entered.

The chamber was enormous, taking up the entire first level of the palatial ziggurat, and held up by marble columns so tall

they disappeared into the distant ceiling. Although it was covered in fading paint and broken mosaics, one could still make

out the flowery vines and ancient Daevastani creatures that had once decorated its surface--as well as the pockmarks where

his ancestors had pried out gems; the Geziri were not ones to waste resources on ornamentation.

The western side of the room opened onto manicured formal gardens. Enormous windows--nearly the height of the ceiling--broke

up the remaining walls, shielded by intricately carved wooden screens that kept the cavernous space cool while letting in

light and fresh air. Flower-filled fountains set against the wall did the same, the water enchanted to continuously flow over

channels of cut ice. Bright mirrored braziers of burning cedarwood hung from silver chains over a floor of green marble swirled

with white veins. The floor rose as it reached the eastern wall and separated into five tiers, each level assigned to a different
branch of the government.

Ali and his father walked out onto the top level, and as they approached the throne, Ali could not help but admire it. Twice

his height and carved from sky blue marble, the throne originally belonged to the Nahids and looked it, a monument to the

extravagance that had gotten them overthrown. It was designed to turn its occupant into a living shedu, the legendary winged

lion that had been their family symbol. Rubies, carnelians, and pink and orange topaz were inlaid above the head to represent

the rising sun, while the arms of the throne were similarly jeweled to imitate wings, the legs carved into heavy clawed paws.

The jewels sparkled in the sunlight--as did the thousands of eyes he suddenly realized were upon him. Ali promptly dropped

his gaze. There was nothing that united the tribes more than gossiping about their leaders, and he suspected the sight of

Ghassan's second son eying the throne on his first day in court would set every tongue wagging.

His father nodded to the jeweled cushion below the throne. "Your brother isn't here. You might as well take his seat."

More gossip

. "I'll stand," Ali said quickly, edging away from Muntadhir's cushion.

The king shrugged. "Your choice." He settled into his throne, Ali and Kaveh flanking him. Ali forced himself to look at the

crowd again. Though the throne room could fit ten thousand, Ali guessed about half that number were here now. Nobles from

all the tribes--their regular presence required to prove loyalty--shared space with clerics in white turbans, while court scribes,

lesser wazirs, and Treasury officials swarmed in a dizzying array of ceremonial dress.

But the majority of the crowd looked to be commoners. No shafit, of course, save servants, but plenty of mixed tribal heritage

like Ali. All were dressed well--none would present themselves in court otherwise--but some were clearly from Daevabad's lower

classes, their robes clean but patched, their ornaments little more than metal bangles.

An Ayaanle woman in mustard-colored robes with a scribe's black sash around her collar stood up.

"In the name of King Ghassan ibn Khader al Qahtani, Defender of the Faith, and on the ninety-fourth Rabi' al Thani of the

twenty-seventh generation after Suleiman's Blessing, I call this session to order!" She lit a cylindrical glass oil lamp and

placed it on the dais before her. Ali knew his father would hear petitions until the oil ran out, but as he watched court

officials herd the crowd below into some semblance of order, he gaped at the sheer number. His father didn't mean to hear

all these people, did he?

The first petitioners were brought forward and introduced: a silk merchant from Tukharistan and his aggrieved Agnivanshi customer.

They prostrated themselves before his father and stood when Ghassan beckoned them to rise.

The Agnivanshi man spoke first. "Peace be upon you, my king. I am humbled and honored to be in your presence." He jerked a

thumb at the silk merchant, the pearls around his neck jangling. "I only beg your

forgiveness for having dragged before you
an unabashed liar and unrepentant thief!"

His father sighed as the silk merchant rolled his eyes. "Why don't you just explain the problem?"

"He agreed to sell me a half-dozen bales of silk for two barrels each of cinnamon and pepper--I even threw in three crates
of mangos as a gesture of good faith." He whirled on the other merchant. "I delivered on my end, but by the time I returned
home, half your silk had turned to smoke!"

The Tukharistani man shrugged. "I am merely an intermediary. I warned you that if you had problems with the product, you'd
have to take it up with the supplier." He sniffed, unimpressed. "And your mangos of good faith were sour."

The Agnivanshi man bristled as if the merchant had insulted his mother. "

Liar!

"

Ghassan raised a hand. "Calm down." He turned his hawklike gaze on the silk merchant. "Is what he says true?"

The merchant fidgeted. "It might be."

"Then pay him for the silk that disappeared. It's your responsibility to recover the loss from the suppliers. The Treasury
will set the price. We'll leave the question of the mangos' acidity to God." He waved them away. "Next!"

The bickering merchants were replaced by a Sahrayn widow left destitute by her spendthrift husband. Ghassan immediately granted
her a small pension, along with a spot for her young son in the Citadel. She was followed by a scholar requesting funds to
research the incendiary properties of zahhak bladders (firmly denied), an appeal for help against a rukh savaging villages
in western Daevastana, and several more accusations of fraud--one including knock-off Nahid potions with some rather embarrassing
results.

Hours later, the complaints were a blur, a stream of demands--some so utterly nonsensical Ali wanted to shake the petitioner.

The sun had risen past the wooden window screens, the audience chamber growing warm, and Ali swayed on his feet, staring longingly
at the cushion he'd refused.

None of it seemed to bother his father. Ghassan was as calmly impassive now as he'd been when they walked in--helped, perhaps,

by the goblet a wine bearer had been keeping studiously full. Ali had never known his father to be a patient man and yet he

showed no irritation toward his subjects, listening as intently to destitute widows as to wealthy nobles arguing over vast

tracts of land. Truthfully . . . Ali was impressed.

But by God, did he want it to end.

When the light in the oil lamp finally snuffed out, it was all Ali could do not to drop to the floor in prostration. His father

rose from his throne and was promptly swallowed by a crowd of scribes and ministers. Ali didn't mind; he was eager to escape

for a cup of tea so strong it could hold a spoon upright. He headed for the exit.

"Qaid?"

Ali paid no mind to the voice until the man called again, and then he realized with some embarrassment that he was now Qaid.

He turned to see a short Geziri man behind him. He wore the uniform of the Royal Guard, a black-hemmed turban indicating he

was a military secretary. He had a well-trimmed beard and kind gray eyes. Ali didn't recognize him, but that wasn't surprising.

There was an entire section of the Royal Guard dedicated to the palace, and if the man was a secretary, it might have been

decades since he trained in the Citadel.

The man promptly touched his heart and brow in the Geziri salute. "Peace be upon you, Qaid. I'm sorry to bother you."

After hours of civilian complaints, a fellow Geziri warrior was a welcome sight. Ali smiled.

"No bother at all. How can I

help you?"

The secretary held out a thick roll of scrolls. "These are records of those suspected in manufacturing the faulty carpets

that crashed in Babili."

Ali stared at him in utter incomprehension. "What?"

The secretary narrowed his eyes. "The Babili incident . . . the one whose survivors your father just granted compensation.

He ordered us to arrest their manufacturers and seize the remaining stock of carpets before they're sold."

Ali dimly remembered something like that being mentioned. "Oh . . . of course." He reached

for the scroll.

The other man held back. "Maybe I should give it to your secretary," he said delicately. "Forgive me, my prince, but you look
a little . . . overwhelmed."

Ali cringed. He hadn't realized it was that obvious. "I don't have a secretary."

"Then who took notes for you during today's session?" Alarm rose in the other man's voice. "There were at least a dozen matters
that pertained to the Royal Guard."

I was supposed to have someone take notes?

Ali wracked his brain. Wajed had thoroughly explained Ali's new responsibilities before he left for Ta Ntry, but shocked
by Anas's execution and the revelation about the weapons, Ali had struggled to pay attention.

"No one," he confessed. Ali glanced at the sea of scribes--surely one of them would have a transcript of today's session.

The other man cleared his throat. "If I may be so bold, Qaid . . . I typically take notes for myself regarding Citadel matters.

I would gladly share them with you. And though I'm sure you would rather appoint a relative or member of the nobility as your
secretary, if you need someone in the mean--"

"Yes," Ali cut in, relieved. "Please . . .," he trailed off with some embarrassment. "I'm sorry. I don't think I asked your
name."

The secretary touched his heart again. "Rashid ben Salkh, my prince." His eyes sparkled. "I look forward to working with you."

Ali felt better as he headed back to his quarters. His attire and failure to take notes aside, he didn't think he'd done terribly
at court.

But, by God, those eyes . . . It was bad enough to stand and listen to inane petitions for hours; being examined by thousands
of strangers while doing so was torture. He could hardly blame his father for drinking.

A palace guard bowed as Ali approached. "Peace be upon you, Prince Alizayd." He opened the door for Ali, then stepped aside.

His siblings might have tried to find Ali simple accommodations, but it was still a palace apartment, twice the size of the

barracks he'd once shared with two dozen junior cadets. The bedroom was plain but large, containing the overly soft bed and the single chest of belongings he'd brought from the Citadel pushed against the wall. Attached to the bedroom was an office ringed in bookshelves already half filled--improved access to the Royal Library was the one benefit of palace living Ali intended to make use of.

He entered the room and slipped off his sandals. His apartment faced the wildest corner of the harem gardens, a verdant jungle complete with hooting monkeys and shrieking mynah birds. A covered marble pavilion lined with swings overlooked the cool waters of the rushing canal.

Ali unwound his turban. The late-afternoon light filtered in through the sheer linen curtains, and it was mercifully quiet.

He crossed the carpet to his desk and rifled through the stacks of paperwork: crime reports, appropriation requests, invitations to a countless number of social events he had no intention of attending, oddly personal notes requesting favors, pardons . . .

Ali quickly sorted it, discarding anything that sounded unnecessary or ridiculous and putting the more important papers in order.

The sparkle of the canal caught his eye, tempting him. Though his mother had taught him to swim as a child, it had been years since Ali had last done so, embarrassed to take part in a hobby so strongly associated with the Ayaanle--and one that was viewed with revulsion and horror by many in his father's tribe.

But there was no one around to see him now. He loosened his collar, reaching for the bottom of his shirt as he headed for the pavilion.

Ali stopped. He backed up to glance again through the open archway leading to the next room, but his eyes hadn't deceived him.

There were two women waiting in his bed.

They burst into laughter. "I think he's finally spotted us," said one of the women with a grin. She lay on her stomach, delicate ankles crossed overhead. Ali's eyes took in her layers of sheer skirts, soft curves, and dark hair before he quickly fixed his eyes on her face.

Not that it helped; she was beautiful. Shafit; that was clear from her rounded ears and dull brown skin. Her eyes were lined

with kohl and bright with amusement. She rose from the bed, her ankle bells tinkling as she approached. She bit a painted lip, and Ali's heart started to race.

"We were wondering how long it would take you to look past all your papers," she teased. She was suddenly before him, her fingers trailing the inside of his wrist.

Ali swallowed. "I think there's been some sort of mistake."

She smiled again. "No mistake, my prince. We were sent to welcome you properly to the palace." She reached for the knot of his waist-wrap.

Ali stepped back so fast he nearly tripped. "Please . . . that's not necessary."

"Oh, Leena, do stop scaring the boy." The second woman stood, moving into the sunlight. Ali went cold, the ardor he'd been struggling to check instantly gone.

It was one of the Daeva courtesans from Turan's tavern.

She walked forward with far more grace than the shafit girl, her liquid black eyes locked on his face. There didn't seem to be any recognition there, but the night came flooding back to Ali: the smoky tavern, the blade bursting through the guard's throat, Anas's hand on his shoulder.

The way his scream had abruptly ended in the arena.

The courtesan's gaze swept over him. "I like him," she said to the other woman. "He looks sweeter than they say." She gave him a gentle smile. Gone was the laughing woman enjoying a night out with friends; she was all business now.

"There's no need to be so nervous, my prince," she added softly. "Our master desires only your satisfaction."

Her words cut through the fog of fear and desire clouding Ali's mind, but before he could question her, there was another feminine laugh from the direction of the pavilion--this one all too familiar.

"Well . . . it certainly didn't take you much time to settle in."

Ali jerked away from the courtesan as his sister entered the room. The other women instantly fell to their knees.

Zaynab's gray-gold eyes sparkled with the malicious delight only a sibling's could hold. She was less than a decade older

than Ali, and as teenagers they could have passed for twins though their mother's sharp cheeks and elongated features suited

Zaynab far better. His sister was dressed in Ayaanle fashion today, a dark purple and gold gown with a matching head wrap

embroidered in pearls. Gold ringed her wrists and neck, and jewels glittered in her ears; even in the privacy of the harem,

Ghassan's only daughter looked the part of a princess.

"Forgive the interruption." She sauntered farther into the room. "We came to make sure court hadn't swallowed you alive, but

clearly you need no help." She dropped onto his bed and kicked at the blanket that was neatly folded on the floor with a roll

of her eyes. "Don't tell me you slept on the ground, Alizayd."

"I--"

The second part of "we" entered the room before Ali could finish his protest. Muntadhir looked more rakish than usual, his

dishdasha unbuttoned at the collar and his curly hair uncovered. He grinned at the sight before him. "

Two?

Don't you think you ought to pace yourself, Zaydi?"

Ali was happy his siblings were enjoying themselves at his expense. "That's not what this is," he snapped. "I didn't tell

them to come here!"

"No?" The amusement left Muntadhir's face, and he glanced at the courtesans kneeling on the floor. "Rise, please. There's

no need for that."

"Peace be upon you, Emir," the Daeva courtesan murmured as she stood.

"And upon you peace." Muntadhir smiled, but the expression didn't meet his eyes. "I know I resisted the urge, so tell me . . .

who requested that my little brother receive such a delightful welcome home?"

The two women exchanged a look, their playful attitude gone. The Daeva courtesan finally spoke again, her voice hesitant.

"The grand wazir."

Instantly outraged, Ali opened his mouth, but Muntadhir raised his hand, cutting him off.

"Please thank Kaveh for the gesture, but I fear I'll have to interrupt." Muntadhir nodded at

the door. "You can go."

Both women offered muted salaams and then hurried out.

Muntadhir glanced at their sister. "Zaynab, would you mind? I think Ali and I need to talk."

"He grew up in a Citadel full of men, Dhiru . . . I think he's had 'the talk.'" Zaynab laughed at her joke but rose from the

bed, ignoring the annoyed look Ali shot in her direction. She touched his shoulder as she passed. "Do

try

and stay out of trouble, Ali. Wait at least a week before launching any holy wars. And don't be a stranger," she shot back

over her shoulder as she headed toward the garden. "I expect you to come listen to me gossip at least once a week."

Ali ignored that, immediately turning for the doors leading to the palace. "You'll excuse me, akhi. Clearly, I need to have

words with the grand wazir."

Muntadhir stepped in front of him. "And what are you going to tell him?"

"To keep his fire-worshipping whores to himself!"

Muntadhir raised a dark eyebrow. "And how do you think that will play?" he asked. "The teenage son of the king--already rumored

to be some sort of religious fanatic--berating one of the most-respected Daeva men in the city, a man who's loyally served

his father for decades? And over what--a gift most young men would be delighted to receive?"

"I'm not like that, and Kaveh knows--"

"Yes, he does," Muntadhir finished. "He knows very well, and I'm sure he's made certain to situate himself someplace where

there will be a great number of witnesses to the scene you're ready to cause."

Ali was taken aback. "What are you saying?"

His brother gave him a dark look. "That he's trying to upset you, Ali. He wants you away from Abba, ideally away from Daevabad

and back in Am Gezira, where you can't do anything to hurt his people."

Ali threw up his hands. "I haven't done anything to his people!"

"Not yet." Muntadhir crossed his arms over his chest. "But you religious types hardly make a secret of your feelings toward

the Daevas. Kaveh is afraid of you; he probably thinks your presence here is a

threat. That you'll turn the Royal Guard into
some sort of morality police and have them beating up all men wearing ash marks."
Muntadhir shrugged. "Honestly, I can't blame
him; the Daevas tend to suffer when people like you come near power."

Ali leaned against his desk, taken aback by his brother's words. He was already trying to fill
in for Wajed while hiding his
involvement with the Tanzeem. He didn't feel capable of matching political wits with
a paranoid Kaveh right now.

He rubbed his temples. "What do I do?"

Muntadhir took a seat in the window. "You could try sleeping with the next courtesan he
sends you," he said with a grin. "Oh,
Zaydi, don't give me that look. It would throw Kaveh for a loop." Muntadhir
absentmindedly twirled a bit of flame around his
fingers. "Until he turned around and denounced you as a hypocrite, of course."

"You're not leaving me with a lot of options."

"You could try not stomping around like the royal version of the Tanzeem," Muntadhir
offered. "Actually, I don't know . . .

attempt to befriend a Daeva? Jamshid's been wanting to learn how to use a zulfiqar.
Why don't you give him lessons?"

Ali was incredulous. "You want me to teach

Kaveh's son

how to use a Geziri weapon?"

"He's not just Kaveh's son," Muntadhir argued, sounding a little irritated. "He's my best
friend, and you're the one who asked
me for advice."

Ali sighed. "Sorry. You're right. It's just been a long day." He shifted against the desk,
promptly knocking over one of his
carefully arranged stacks of paperwork. "A day with no sign of ending anytime
soon."

"Maybe I should have left you with the women. They might have improved your attitude."
Muntadhir rose from the window. "I

just wanted to make sure you survived your first day at court, but you look like you
have a lot of work. At least think on
what I've said about the Daevas. You know I'm only trying to help."

"I know." Ali exhaled. "Were your negotiations successful?"

"My what?"

"Your negotiations with the Tukharistani minister," Ali reminded. "Abba said you were trying to reduce a debt."

Muntadhir's eyes brightened with amusement. He pressed his lips together as if fighting a grin. "Yes. She proved to be very . . .
accommodating."

"That's good." Ali retrieved his papers, straightening the stacks on his desk. "Let me know if you'd like me to check the
numbers you agreed on. I know mathematics isn't your--" He stopped, surprised by the kiss Muntadhir suddenly planted on his
forehead. "What?"

Muntadhir only shook his head, exasperated affection in his face. "Oh, akhi . . . you're going to get eaten alive here."

9: Nahri

9

Nahri

Cold

. That was her first thought upon waking. Nahri shivered violently and curled into a ball, pulling her blanket over her head

and tucking her frozen hands under her chin. Could it be morning already? Her face felt damp, and the tip of her nose was completely numb.

What she saw when she opened her eyes was so strange, she immediately sat up.

Snow.

It had to be; it matched Dara's description perfectly. The ground was covered by a thin blanket of white with only a few dark

patches of soil visible. The very air seemed more still than usual, frozen into silence by the snow's arrival.

Dara was still gone, as were the horses. Nahri wrapped her blanket around her shoulders and fed the dying fire the driest

branch she could find, trying not to let her nerves get the better of her. Maybe he'd just taken the horses to graze.

Or maybe he really did leave

. She forced down a few bites of cold stew and then started packing up her meager supplies. There was something about the

silence and lonely beauty of the fresh snowfall that made the solitude more intense.

The stale bread and spicy stew left her mouth dry. Nahri searched their small campsite, but the waterskin was nowhere to be

seen. Now she did start to panic. Would Dara really leave her with no water?

That bastard. That smug, self-righteous bastard

. She tried to melt some snow in her hands but only got a mouthful of mud. She spat, growing annoyed, and then pulled on her

boots. Dara be damned. She'd noticed a stream in the sparse woods behind their camp. If he wasn't back by the time she returned,

well . . . she'd have to start making other plans.

She stomped toward the forest.

If I die out here, I hope I come back as a ghoul. I will haunt that arrogant, wine-soaked daeva until the Day of Judgment.

As she walked deeper into the forest, the sounds of warbling birds faded. It was dark; the tall, ancient trees blocked what

little light penetrated the cloudy morning sky. Unbending pine needles held up tiny cups of crisp snow in the air all around her.

A thin layer of ice covered the rushing stream. She broke it easily with a rock and knelt to drink. The water was so cold

it made her teeth ache, but she forced a few mouthfuls down and splashed some on her face, her entire body trembling. She longed for Cairo, its heat and crowds the perfect remedy to this cold, lonely place.

A flash drew her attention back to the stream, and she glanced down to see a bright fish dash behind a submerged rock. It

briefly reappeared to fight the swift current, its scales sparkling in the dim light.

Nahri pressed her palms against the muddy bank and leaned closer. The fish was a striking silver color with brilliant blue

and green bands crossing its body. While it was only about the length of her hand, it looked plump, and she suddenly wondered how it would taste seared over her weak campfire.

The fish must have guessed her intent. Just as she was considering the best way to catch it, it vanished behind the rocks

again, and a breeze blew straight through her thin headscarf. She shivered and stood; the fish wasn't worth staying here any longer.

She returned to the forest's edge and then stopped.

Dara was back.

She doubted he saw her. He stood between the horses with his back to the trees, and as Nahri watched, he pressed his brow

against one's fuzzy cheek, giving its nose an affectionate scratch.

She wasn't moved by the gesture. Dara probably thought even animals were superior to shafit like her.

But there was visible relief in his face when she entered their campsite. "Where were you?" he demanded. "I was worried that something ate you."

Nahri pushed past him toward her horse. "Sorry to disappoint." She grabbed the edge of her saddle and shoved one foot into

the stirrup.

"Let me help--"

"Don't touch me." Dara jerked away, and Nahri heaved herself awkwardly into the saddle.

"Listen . . . ," he started again, sounding admonished. "About last night. I was drunk. It's been a long time since I've had company." He chewed his lip. "I suppose I forgot my manners."

She whirled on him. "Your

manners

? You go into a wild rant about the djinn--you know, the ones who stopped the indiscriminate butchery of shafit like me, insult

me when I show some relief at the news of their victory, and then announce you're planning to leave me at the gates of that

damn city anyway? And you're blaming it all on wine and your lack of

manners

?" Nahri scoffed. "By the Most High, you're so arrogant you can't even apologize properly."

"Fine.

I'm sorry

," he said, exaggerating the words. "Is that what you wish to hear? You are the first shafit I've ever spent time with. I

didn't realize . . ." He cleared his throat, playing nervously with the reins. "Nahri, you have to understand that when I

was growing up, we were taught that the Creator himself would punish us if our race continued breaking Suleiman's laws. That

another human would rise to strip away our powers and upend our lives if we didn't bring the other tribes into line. Our leaders

said the shafit were soulless, anything out of their mouths a deception." He shook his head. "I never questioned it. No one

did." He hesitated, his eyes bright with regret. "When I think of some of the things I've done . . . "

"I think I've heard enough." She jerked the reins out of his hands. "Let's just go. The sooner we get to Daevabad, the sooner

we're done with each other."

She kicked her horse a bit harder than usual, and it gave an annoyed snort before rushing into a trot. Nahri clutched the

reins and squeezed her legs, praying her rash move wouldn't land her on the ground. She was a terrible rider, while Dara seemed

to have been born in the saddle.

She tried to relax, knowing from experience that the most comfortable way to ride was to let her body follow the animal's

motions, leaving her hips loose to sway instead of bouncing all over the place.

Behind her, she heard Dara's horse pounding
the frozen ground.

He quickly caught up. "Oh, don't run off like that. I said I was sorry. Besides . . ." She heard his voice catch, and when

he spoke again, she could barely hear him. "I will take you to Daevabad."

"Yes, I know. To the gates. We've been over this."

Dara shook his head. "No. I will take you

into

Daevabad. I will escort you to the king myself."

Nahri immediately pulled on her reins to slow her horse. "Is this a trick?"

"No. I swear on my parents' ashes. I will take you to the king."

Macabre oath aside, she found it hard to trust his rather abrupt change of heart. "Will I not embarrass the legacy of your
precious Nahids?"

He dropped his gaze to study his reins, looking ashamed. "It matters not. In truth, I cannot predict how the djinn will react

and . . ." A blush stole into his cheeks. "I could not bear it if something happened to you. I would never forgive myself."

She opened her mouth to mock his reluctant affection for the "dirt-blood thief" and then stopped, struck by the soft edge

to his voice and the way he was anxiously twisting his ring. Dara looked as nervous as a prospective bridegroom. He was telling
the truth.

Nahri stared at him, catching sight of the sword at his waist. His silver bow gleamed in the morning light. No matter the

disturbing things that occasionally came out of his mouth, he was a good ally to have.

She'd be lying if she said her gaze didn't linger a moment longer than necessary. Her heart skipped a beat.

Ally

, she reminded herself.

Nothing more.

"And how do

you

expect to be greeted in Daevabad?" she asked. Dara looked up, a wry smile on his face.

"You mentioned being locked up in
a dungeon," she reminded him.

"Then how fortunate I travel with Cairo's premier picker of locks." He gave her a wicked grin before spurring his horse. "Try
to keep up. It seems I cannot afford to lose you now."

They traveled throughout the morning, racing along the frost-encrusted plains, their horses' hooves loud against the frozen

ground. The snow cleared, but the wind kicked up, sweeping rolling gray clouds over the southern horizon and whipping through

Nahri's garments. With the snow gone, she could see the blue mountains surrounding them, capped by ice and belted by dark

forests, the trees growing sparser as the rocky cliffs rose. At one point, they startled a group of wild goats grown fat on

grass, with thick, matted coats and sharply curved horns.

She eyed them hungrily. "Do you think you could get one?" she asked Dara. "All you do with that bow of yours is polish it."

He glanced at the goats with a frown. "Get one? Why?" His confusion turned to revulsion. "You mean to

eat

?" He made a disgusted sound. "Absolutely not. We don't eat meat."

"What? Why not?" Meat had been a rare luxury on her limited income in Cairo. "It's delicious!"

"It's unclean." Dara shuddered. "Blood pollutes. No Daeva would consume such a thing. And especially not a Banu Nahida."

"A Banu Nahida?"

"The title we give to female Nahid leaders. A position of honor," he added, a little chiding in his voice. "Of responsibility."

"So you're telling me I should hide my kebabs?"

Dara sighed.

They kept riding, but Nahri's legs were aching by the afternoon. She twisted in her saddle to

stretch her cramping muscles

and pulled the blanket tighter, wishing for a cup of Khayzur's hot spiced tea. They'd been traveling for hours; certainly

it was time for a break. She kicked her heels against the horse's side, trying to close the distance between her and Dara

so she could suggest they stop.

Annoyed by his inexperienced rider, her horse snorted and skidded to the left before galloping forward and passing Dara.

He laughed. "Having some problems?"

Nahri cursed and yanked back on the reins, pulling her horse into a walk. "I think it hates--" She stopped speaking, her eyes

drawn toward a dark crimson smudge in the sky. "Ya, Dara . . . have I gone mad or is there a bird the size of a camel flying toward us?"

The daeva whirled around, then pulled to a stop with a curse, snatching the reins from her hands. "Suleiman's eye. I don't

think it's seen us yet, but . . ." He looked worried. "There's no place to hide."

"Hide?" she asked, lowering her voice when Dara hushed her. "Why? It's just a bird."

"No, it's a rukh. Bloodthirsty creatures; they'll eat anything they find."

"Anything? You mean like us?" She groaned when he nodded. "Why does everything in your world want to

eat

us?"

Dara carefully pulled his bow free as he watched the rukh circle the forest. "I think it's found our camp."

"Is that bad?"

"They have an excellent sense of smell. It will be able to track us." Dara inclined his head to the north, toward the thickly

forested mountains. "We need to reach those trees. Rukh are too large to hunt in the forest."

Nahri glanced back at the bird, which had drifted closer to the ground, and then at the edge of the forest. It was impossibly

far. "We'll never make it."

Dara pulled off his turban, cap, and robe and tossed them to her. Puzzled, Nahri watched as he secured his sword to his waist.

"Don't be such a pessimist. I have an idea. Something I heard about in a story." He knocked one of his gleaming silver arrows.

"Just stay low and hold on to your horse. Don't look back, and don't stop. No matter what you see." He pulled on her reins,
jerked her horse in the right direction, and urged both animals into a trot.

She swallowed, her heart in her throat. "What about you?"

"Don't worry about me."

Before she could protest, Dara smacked her horse's rump hard. She could feel the heat of his hand from her saddle; the animal
whinnied in protest and bolted toward the forest.

Nahri threw herself forward, one hand clutching the saddle and the other wrapped in the horse's damp mane. It took every bit
of self-control not to scream. Her body bounced wildly, and she tightened her legs, desperately hoping that she wouldn't be
thrown off. She caught a brief glimpse of the racing ground before squeezing her eyes shut.

A long cry pierced the air, so high-pitched it seemed to tear right through her. Unable to cover her ears, Nahri could only
pray.

Oh, Merciful One

, she begged,

please don't let this thing eat me

. She'd survived a body-possessing ifrit, ravenous ghouls, and a deranged daeva. This couldn't end with her being gobbled
up by an overgrown pigeon.

Nahri peeked up from the horse's mane, but the forest didn't look much closer. Her horse's hooves beat against the ground,
and she could hear it panting. And where was Dara?

The rukh screeched again, sounding furious. Worried about the daeva, she ignored his warning and glanced back.

"God preserve me." The whispered prayer came unbidden to her lips at the sight of the rukh. She suddenly knew why she'd never
heard of them.

No one survived to tell the tale.

Camel size was a terrible understatement; larger than Yaqub's shop and with a wingspan

that would have covered the length

of her street in Cairo, the monstrous bird probably snacked on camels. It had ebony eyes the size of platters and glittering

feathers the color of wet blood. Its long black beak ended in a sharply curved tip. It looked big enough to swallow her whole,

and it was closing in. There was no way she'd make it to the forest.

Dara suddenly veered into view behind her. His boots jammed against the stirrups, he was damn near standing on the horse,

turned around to face the rukh. He drew back his bow, unleashing an arrow that hit the beast just below its eye. The rukh

jerked its head back and shrieked again. At least a dozen silver arrows pierced its body, but they didn't slow it in the slightest.

Dara shot it twice more in the face, and the rukh dove for him, its massive talons outstretched.

"Dara!" she screamed as the daeva made a sharp eastward turn. The rukh followed, apparently preferring a reckless daeva to

a fleeing human.

There was little chance he could hear her over the rukh's enraged shrieks, but she couldn't help but shout, "You're going

the wrong way!" There was nothing east but flat plains--was he trying to get himself killed?

Dara shot the creature once more and then threw his bow and quiver away. He pulled himself into a squatting position on the

horse's saddle and cradled his sword to his chest with one arm.

The rukh cried out in triumph as it closed in on the daeva. It opened its talons wide.

"No!" Nahri screamed as the rukh snatched up the horse and Dara, as easily as a hawk might seize a mouse. It rose in the air

while the horse screamed and kicked, and then veered back south.

She yanked hard on the reins to pull her racing horse around. It reared, trying to throw her off, but she held on, and it

turned. "Yalla, go! Go!" she shouted, reverting to Arabic in panic. She kicked hard, and it bolted after the rukh.

The bird soared away with Dara clutched in its talons. It cried out again and then tossed both Dara and his horse high in

the air. It opened its mouth wide.

It was only seconds, but the moment between seeing Dara thrown in the air and seeing him vanish seemed to last an eternity,

twisting something deep in her chest. The rukh caught the horse again with one foot,

but the daeva was nowhere to be seen.

She searched the sky, expecting him to reappear, to flit into existence like the wine he conjured up. This was Dara, the magical

being who traveled by sandstorms and saved her from a pack of ghouls. He had to have a plan; he couldn't just vanish down
the gullet of some bloodthirsty bird.

But he didn't reappear.

Tears pricked her eyes, her mind knowing what her heart denied. Her horse slowed, balking at her kicks. It clearly had more

sense than she did; the only thing they could offer the rukh was dessert.

She could see the crimson bird silhouetted against the mountains; it hadn't gotten very far but suddenly shot up in the sky,

frantically flapping its wings. As she watched, it started to fall and then momentarily righted itself, letting out a screech

that sounded more frightened than triumphant. Then it fell again, tumbling through the air and crashing to the frozen ground.

The force of the distant impact shuddered through her horse. Nahri wanted to scream. Nothing could survive a fall like that.

She didn't let her horse slow until they reached the shallow crater the rukh's body had smashed into the ground. She tried

to steel herself but had to look away from Dara's dead horse. Her own animal startled and fussed. Nahri fought for control

as she approached the rukh's massive body. It towered over them, one enormous wing crumpled under its dead weight. Its glittering
feathers were twice her height.

She began to circle the bird, but the daeva was nowhere to be seen. Nahri choked back a sob. Had it really eaten him? That

might have been faster than crashing to the ground, but--

A cold, sharp feeling cut through her and she reeled, overcome with emotion. She caught sight of the creature's bent head,

black blood pouring from its mouth. The sight of it filled her with rage, displacing her grief and despair. She grabbed her

dagger, overcome by the irrational need to tear at its eyes and rip out its throat.

Its neck twitched.

Nahri jumped, and her horse backed up. She tightened her grip on the reins, ready to flee, and then the neck twitched again . . .

no, it

bulged

, like something was inside.

She'd already slipped off her horse when a dark blade finally emerged from inside the rukh's neck, laboriously cutting a long

vertical gash before being dropped to the ground. The daeva followed, washed out in a wave of black blood. He collapsed to his knees.

"Dara!" Nahri ran and kneeled at his side, throwing her arms around him before her mind caught up with her actions. The rukh's

hot blood soaked through her clothes.

"I . . ." He spat a gob of black blood onto the ground before shaking free of her grasp and climbing laboriously to his feet.

He wiped the blood from his eyes, his hands trembling. "Fire," he rasped. "I need a fire."

Nahri looked around, but the ground was covered in wet snow, and there were no branches in sight. "What can I do?" she cried

as the daeva gasped for air. He collapsed to the ground again. "Dara!"

She reached for him. "No," he protested. "Don't touch me . . ." He dug his fingers into the ground, sending up sparks that

were quickly extinguished by the icy dirt. A terrible sucking sound came from his mouth.

She crept closer despite his warning, aching to do something as a deep shudder ran through his body. "Let me heal you."

He slapped her hand away. "No. The ifrit--"

"There are no damned ifrit here!"

Beads of ash rolled down his face. Before she could reach for him again, he suddenly cried out.

It was as if his very body momentarily turned to smoke. His eyes grew dim, and as they both watched, his hands briefly translucent.

And though Nahri knew nothing about how daeva bodies worked, she could tell from the panic in his face that this was not normal.

"Creator, no," he whispered, staring in horror at his hands. "Not now . . ." He glanced up at Nahri, a mixture of fear and

sadness in his expression. "Oh, little thief, I'm so sorry."

He had no sooner apologized than his entire body shimmered like steam, and he fell against the ground.

"Dara!" Nahri knelt at his side and checked him over, her instincts kicking in. She could see nothing but slick black blood,

whether the daeva's or the rukh's, she had no idea. "Dara, talk to me!" she begged. "Tell me what to do!" She tried to pull open his robe, hoping to see some type of wound she could heal.

The hem crumbled into ash. Nahri gasped, trying not to panic as the daeva's skin took on the same hue. Was he going to turn to dust in her arms?

His skin briefly firmed up even as his body grew light. His eyes fluttered shut, and Nahri went cold. "No," she said, brushing the ash from his closed eyes.

Not like this, not after everything we've been through

. She wracked her memory, trying to think of anything useful he'd told her about how the Nahids healed.

He had said they could undo poisons and curses, she remembered that. But he hadn't told her how. Did they have their own medicines, their own spells? Or did they do it by touch alone?

Well, touch was all she had. She pulled his shirt open and pressed her trembling hands against his chest. His skin was so cold it numbed her fingers.

Intent

, he had mentioned more than once. Intent was critical in magic.

She closed her eyes, focusing entirely on Dara.

Nothing. There was no heartbeat, no breath. She frowned, trying to sense anything wrong, trying to imagine him healthy and alert. Her fingers grew frosty, and she pressed them harder against his chest, his body twitching in response.

Something wet tickled her wrists, growing faster and thicker, like steam off a boiling pot. Nahri didn't move, keeping the image of a healthy Dara, his smile sly as always, firmly in her mind. His skin warmed a bit.

Please, let it be working

, she begged.

Please, Dara. Don't leave me

.

A sharp ache crept up from the base of her skull. She ignored the pain. Warm blood dripped from her nose, and she fought a

wave of dizziness. The steam was coming more quickly. She felt his skin grow firm beneath her fingertips.

And then the first memory flashed before her eyes. A green plain, lush and entirely unfamiliar, sliced in half by a brilliant

blue river. A young girl with eyes as black as obsidian. She held out a badly constructed wooden bow.

"Look, Daru!"

"A masterpiece!" I exclaim, and she beams. My little sister, ever the warrior. The Creator help the man she marries . . .

Nahri shook her head, dispelling the memory. She needed to remain focused. Dara's skin was finally growing hot again, the

muscles solidifying under her hands.

A dazzling court, the palace walls covered in precious metals and jewels. I breathe in the scent of sandalwood and bow. "Does

this please you, my master?" I ask, my smile ingratiating as always. I snap my fingers, and a silver chalice appears in my

hand. "The finest drink of the ancients as requested." I hand the beaming human fool the chalice and wait for him to die,

the drink little more than concentrated hemlock. Perhaps my next master will be more careful in the wording of his wishes.

Nahri shook free of the horrifying image. She bent down to concentrate. She just needed a little more time . . .

But it was too late. The darkness behind her closed eyes swept away again, replaced by a ruined city surrounded by rocky hills.

A sliver of moon splashed dim light on broken masonry.

I thrash against the ifrit, dragging my feet on the ground as they pull me toward the sinkhole, the remains of an ancient

well. Its dark water glimmers, hinting at hidden depths.

"No!" I scream, for once not caring about my honor. "Please! Don't do this!"

The two ifrit laugh. "Come now, General Afshin!" The female offers a mock salute. "Don't you want to live forever?"

I try to struggle, but the curse has already weakened me. They bind my wrists with rope, not bothering with iron, and then

wrap the rope around one of the heavy stones lining the well.

"No!" I beg, as they haul me over the edge. "Not now! You don't under--" The brick hits me in the stomach. Their black smiles

are the last thing I see before the dark water closes over my face.

The brick plummets to the bottom of the well, dragging me along headfirst. I frantically twist my wrists, clawing and ripping

at my skin. No, I can't die like this. Not with the curse still on me!

The stone thuds against the bottom, my body bouncing against the rope. My lungs burn, the press of dark water against my skin

terrifying. I follow the rope, trying desperately to find the knot tying it to the stone.

My own magic is lost to me, the

ifrit's curse coursing through my blood, preparing to seize me as soon as I breathe my last.

I'm going to be a slave.

The thought rings through my mind as I fumble for the knot. When I next open my eyes, it will be to look upon the human master

to whose whims I'll be entirely beholden. Horror surges through me. No, Creator, no. Please.

The knot won't budge. My chest is collapsing, my head spinning. One breath, what I would do for just one breath . . .

There was a scream from another world, a faraway world on a snowy plain, shouting a strange name that meant nothing.

The water finally pries past my clenched jaws, pouring down my throat. A bright light blossoms before me, as lush and green

as the valleys of my homeland. It beckons, warm and welcoming.

And then Nahri was gone.

"Nahri, wake up! Nahri!"

Dara's terrified cries tugged at her mind, but Nahri ignored them, warm and comfortable in the thick blackness that surrounded

her. She pushed away the hand shaking her shoulder, settling deeper into the hot coals and savoring the tickle of fire licking

up her arms.

Fire?

Nahri had no sooner opened her eyes and seen a set of dancing flames than she shrieked and jumped up. She batted her arms

and the fiery tendrils shimmied away, dropping to the ground like snakes and melting into the snow.

"It's okay! It's okay!"

Dara's voice barely registered as she frantically swept her body. But instead of scorched flesh and burned clothes, she found

only normal skin. Her tunic barely felt warm to the touch. What in the name of all . . .
She glanced up, giving the daeva
a wild look. "Did you light me on

fire

?"

"You wouldn't wake!" he protested. "I thought it might help." His face was paler than usual, the crossed wing and arrow tattoo

on his face standing out like charcoal. And his eyes were brighter, closer to how they'd looked in Cairo. But he was standing
up, healthy and whole, and mercifully not translucent.

The rukh . . . she remembered, her head feeling like she'd had too much wine. She rubbed her temples, unsteady on her feet.

I healed him and then . . .

She gagged, the memory of water pouring down her throat strong enough to make her sick. But it hadn't been her throat, hadn't
been her memory. She swallowed, taking in the sight of the anxious daeva again.

"God be merciful," she whispered. "You're dead. I saw you die . . . I felt you
drown

."

The devastated shadow that overtook his face was confirmation enough. Nahri gasped and instinctively stepped back, bumping
into the still warm body of the rukh.

No breath, no heartbeat. Nahri closed her eyes, everything coming together too fast. "I-I don't understand," she stammered.

"Are you . . . are you some sort of ghost?" The word sounded ridiculous to her ears even as its implication broke her heart.

Her eyes were suddenly wet. "Are you even
alive

?"

"Yes!" The words tumbled out in a rush. "I mean, I-I think so. It's . . . it's complicated."

Nahri threw up her hands. "Whether or not you're alive shouldn't be

complicated

!" She turned away, linking her fingers behind her head and feeling wearier than she had at any point during their exhausting

journey. She paced down the length of the rukh's belly. "I don't understand why every . . ." And then she stopped, distracted

by the sight of something lashed to one of the rukh's massive talons.

She was at the rukh's foot in an instant, tearing the bundle from its ties. The black scrap of fabric was filthy and torn

but the cheap coins were recognizable. As was the heavy gold ring tied to one end. The basha's ring. She untied both, holding

the ring up in the sunlight.

Dara hurried toward her. "Don't touch that. Suleiman's eye, Nahri, not even you could want those. They're probably from its

last victim."

"They're mine," she said softly, quiet horror taking grip of her heart. She rubbed the ring, remembering how it had cut her

palm so many weeks ago. "They're from my home back in Cairo."

"What?" Dara stepped closer and snatched the headdress from her hands. "You must be mistaken." He turned the filthy fabric

over and pressed it to his face, taking a deep breath.

"I'm not mistaken!" She dropped the ring, suddenly wanting nothing to do with it. "How is that possible?"

Dara lowered the headdress; there was panic in his bright eyes. "It was hunting us."

"You mean it belonged to the ifrit? They broke into my home?" Nahri asked, her voice rising. Her skin crawled at the thought

of those creatures in her tiny stall, rifling through the few precious things she owned. And what if that hadn't been enough?

What if they'd gone after her neighbors? After Yaqub? Her chest tightened.

"It wasn't an ifrit. The ifrit can't control rukhs."

"Then what can?" Nahri didn't like the cold stillness that had overtaken him.

"Peris." He threw the headdress to the ground, the movement sudden and violent. "The only creatures who can control ruhks

are peris."

"Khayzur." She took a shaky breath. "But why?" she stammered. "I thought he liked me."

He shook his head. "Not Khayzur."

She couldn't believe his naivete. "What other peris even know about me?" she pointed out. "And he rushed off after finding
out about my Nahid heritage--probably to go tell his friends." She started walking toward the rukh's other leg. "I bet my teacup
is tied over. . . ."

"No." Dara reached for her hand. Nahri flinched, and he immediately pulled back, a flash of hurt in his face. "I . . . Forgive
me." He swallowed and turned toward the horse. "I'll try not to touch you again. But we need to leave. Now."

The sadness in his voice cut her deeply. "Dara, I'm sorry. I didn't mean--"

"There's no time." He gestured for her to climb into the saddle, and she did so reluctantly, taking the bloody sword when
he handed it to her.

"I will need to ride with you," he explained, pulling himself up and settling in behind her. "At least until we find another
horse."

He kicked the horse into a trot and despite his promise, she fell back against his chest, momentarily taken aback by the smoky
heat and warm press of his body.

He's not dead

, she tried to assure herself.

He can't be

.

He pulled the horse to an abrupt stop where he'd thrown his bow and quiver. He raised his hands, and they flew to him like
loyal sparrow hawks.

Nahri ducked as he swung the weapons over her head, looping both over his left shoulder. "So what do we do now?" She thought
back to Khayzur's easy banter and Dara's quip about how the peri could rearrange the landscape with a single sweep of his
wings.

"The only thing we can," he said, his breath soft against her ear. He snatched up the reins again, holding her tight. There
was nothing affectionate or remotely romantic about the gesture; it was desperation, like a man clinging to a ledge.

"We run."

10: Ali

10

Ali

Ali squinted and tapped the delicate stem of the scales on the desk in front of him, aware of the expectant eyes of the other

three men in the room. "They look even to me."

Rashid bent down to join him, the silver scale platters reflected in the military secretary's gray eyes. "It could be hexed,"

he offered in Geziriyya. He jerked his head in the direction of Soroush, the Daeva Quarter's muhtasib. "He might have come

up with some type of curse that would weigh the coins in his favor."

Ali hesitated, glancing at Soroush. The muhtasib, the market official in charge of exchanging Daeva currency with the myriad

others used in Daevabad, was trembling, his black gaze locked on the floor. Ali could see ash staining his fingertips; he'd

been nervously touching the charcoal mark on his brow since they entered. Most religious Daevas wore such a mark. It was a

sign of their devotion to the Nahids' ancient fire cult.

The man looked terrified, but Ali couldn't blame him--he had just been visited by the Qaid and two armed members of the Royal

Guard for a surprise inspection.

Ali turned back to Rashid. "We have no evidence," he whispered back in Geziriyya. "I can't arrest a man with no evidence."

Before Rashid could respond, the door to the office swung open. The fourth man in the room, Abu Nuwas--Ali's very gruff and

very large personal guard--was between the door and the prince in a moment, his zulfiqar drawn.

But it was only Kaveh, not looking particularly impressed by the enormous Geziri warrior. He peered under one of Abu Nuwas's

large raised arms, his face turning sour when he met Ali's eyes. "Qaid," he greeted him flatly. "Do you mind telling your

dog to back down?"

"It's fine, Abu Nuwas," Ali said before his guard could do something rash. "Let him in."

Kaveh stepped over the threshold. As he glanced between the glittering scales and the frightened muhtasib, a hint of anger

crept into his voice. "What are you doing in my quarter?"

"There've been several reports of fraud coming out of here," Ali explained. "I was just examining the scales--"

"Examining the scales? Are you a wazir now?" Kaveh raised a hand to cut off Ali before he could reply. "Never mind . . . I've

wasted enough time this morning looking for you." He beckoned to the door. "Come in, Mir e-Parvez, and give your report to the Qaid."

There was some inaudible muttering from the doorway.

Kaveh rolled his eyes. "I don't

care

what you heard. He doesn't have crocodile teeth, and he isn't going to eat you." Ali flinched, and Kaveh continued. "Forgive

him, he's had a terrible fright at the hands of the djinn."

We are all djinn

. Ali bit back the retort as the anxious merchant came forward. Mir e-Parvez was thickset and older, beardless like most Daeva.

He was dressed in a gray tunic and loose dark trousers, the typical garb of Daeva men.

The merchant pressed his palms together in greeting but kept his gaze on the floor. His hands were shaking. "Forgive me, my

prince. When I learned you were serving as Qaid, I-I did not want to trouble you."

"It's the Qaid's job to be troubled," Kaveh cut in, ignoring Ali's glare. "Just tell him what happened."

The other man nodded. "I run a shop outside the quarter selling fancy human goods," he started. His Djinnistani was broken,

colored by a thick Divasti accent.

Ali raised his eyebrows, already sensing where this was going. The only "fancy human goods" a Daeva merchant would sell outside

their quarter were human-made intoxicants. Most djinn had little tolerance for human spirits, and they were banned by the

Holy Book anyway, so it was illegal to sell them in the rest of the city. The Daevas had no such qualms and freely traded

in the stuff, peddling it to foreign tribesmen at greatly inflated prices.

The man continued. "I've had some trouble in the past with djinn. My windows smashed, they protest and spit when I pass by.

I say nothing. I don't want trouble." He shook his head. "But last night, these men break into my shop while my son is there and smash my bottles and set fire to everything. When my son tried to stop them, they hit him and cut his face. They accused him of being a 'fire worshipper' and said he's leading djinn to sin!"

Not exactly false charges

. Ali refrained from saying so, knowing Kaveh would go running to his father at the slightest whisper of injustice against his tribe. "Did you report this to the guard in your quarter?"

"Yes, Your Majesty," the merchant said, bungling his title, his Djinnistani growing worse as he got upset. "But they do nothing.

This happens all the time and always nothing. They laugh or 'make report,' but nothing changes."

"There are not enough guards in the Daeva neighborhoods," Kaveh interrupted. "And not enough . . . diversity among them. I've been telling Wajed this for years."

"So you requested more soldiers from Wajed--just not ones that look like him," Ali replied, though he knew Kaveh had a point.

The soldiers patrolling the markets were often the youngest, many straight from the sands of Am Gezira. They probably feared protecting a man like Mir e-Parvez was as much a sin as drinking his wares.

But there was no easy solution; the bulk of the military was Geziri, and they were already stretched thin. "Tell me, whose district do I take these soldiers from, Kaveh?" Ali pressed on. "Should the Tukharistanis go without so the Daevas feel safer selling liquor?"

"The allocation of the guard is not my realm of responsibility, Prince Alizayd. Maybe if you took a break from terrorizing my muhtasib . . ."

Ali straightened up and came around the table, cutting off Kaveh's sarcastic remark. Mir e-Parvez actually stepped back, giving Ali's coppery zulfiqar a nervous look.

By the Most High, were the rumors surrounding him really that bad? Judging from the look on the merchant's face, one would think Ali spent every other Friday slaughtering Daevas.

He sighed. "Your son is okay, I trust?"

The merchant blinked in surprise. "He . . . yes, my prince," he stammered. "He will recover."

"God be praised. Then I will speak to my men and see what we can do about improving security in your quarter. Go over the damages to your shop and submit the bill to my aide Rashid. The Treasury will cover--"

"The king will have to approve--" Kaveh started to say.

Ali raised a hand. "It will come from my accounts if necessary," he said firmly, knowing that would end any doubt. The fact

that his Ayaanle grandfather gave a lavish yearly endowment to his royal grandson was an open secret. Ali normally found it

embarrassing--he didn't need the money and knew his grandfather only did it to annoy his father. But in this instance, it worked to his advantage.

The Daeva merchant's eyes popped, and he dropped to the ground and pressed his ash-covered forehead against the carpet. "Oh,

thank you, Your Majesty. May the flames burn brightly for you."

Ali fought a smile, bemused at the traditional Daeva blessing being bestowed upon him of all people. He suspected the merchant

was going to present him with a rather hefty bill, but he was nonetheless pleased, sensing he'd handled the situation correctly.

Maybe he could manage the role of Qaid after all.

"I trust we are done?" he asked Kaveh as Rashid opened the door. Movement caught his eye up ahead: two small boys armed with

makeshift bows were playing along one of the fountains in the plaza. Each had an arrow in hand, and they were bashing them together like swords.

Kaveh followed his gaze. "Would you like to join them, Prince Alizayd? You're near enough in age, no?"

He remembered Muntadhir's warning.

Don't let him get under your skin

. "I dare not. They look far too fierce," he said calmly. He grinned to himself, ducking out from under the balustrade and

into the bright sunshine, as Kaveh's smirk turned to a scowl. The sky was a cheerful blue, with only a few lacy white clouds

dancing in from the east. It was another beautiful day in a string of beautiful days, warm and bright--a pattern most unlike

Daevabad and strange enough to start attracting attention.

And the weather wasn't all that was odd. Ali heard rumors that the Nahids' original fire altar,

extinguished after Manizheh

and Rustam--the siblings who'd been the last of their family--were murdered, had somehow relit itself in a locked room. An abandoned,

weed-choked grove in the garden where one of them had liked to paint was suddenly orderly and flourishing, and just last week

one of the shedu statues that framed the palace walls had turned up on top of the ziggurat's roof, its brass gaze focused

on the lake as if awaiting a boat.

Then there was that mural of Anahid. Against Muntadhir's wishes, Ali had it destroyed. Yet he walked past it every few days,

nagged by the sense that there was something alive beneath the ruined facade.

He glanced at Kaveh, wondering what the grand wazir made of the whispers coming from his superstitious tribe. Kaveh was an

ardent devotee of the fire cult, and the Pramukh family and the Nahids had been close. Many of the plants and herbs used in

traditional Nahid healing were grown on the Pramukhs' vast estates. Kaveh himself had originally come to Daevabad as a trade

envoy but had risen quickly in Ghassan's court, becoming a trusted advisor even as he aggressively pushed for Daeva rights.

Kaveh spoke again. "I apologize if my girls made you nervous the other week. It was meant as a gesture of kindness."

Ali bit back the first retort that came to mind. And the second. He was unused to this type of verbal sparring. "Such . . .

gestures are not to my taste, Grand Wazir," he finally said. "I would appreciate it if you remember that for the future."

Kaveh said nothing, but Ali could feel his cold stare upon him as they continued to walk. By the Most High, what had he done

to earn this man's enmity? Could he truly think Ali's beliefs represented that much of a threat to his people?

It was an otherwise pleasant stroll, the Daeva Quarter a far lovelier sight when he wasn't dashing through it pursued by archers.

The cobbled stones were perfectly even and swept. Cypress trees shadowed the main avenue, broken up by flower-filled fountains

and potted barberry bushes. The stone buildings were finely polished, their thatched wooden screens neat and fresh--one would

never guess that this neighborhood was among the oldest in the city. Ahead, a few elderly men were playing chatrang and sipping

from little glass vials, probably filled with some human intoxicant. Two veiled women glided from the direction of the Grand

Temple.

It was an idyllic scene, at odds with the filthy conditions in the rest of the city. Ali frowned. He'd have to see what was

going on with Daevabad's sanitation. He turned toward Rashid. "Make me an appointment with--"

Something whizzed past Ali's right ear leaving a sharp sting. He let out a startled cry, instinctively reaching for his zulfiqar

as he whirled around.

Standing on the edge of the fountain was one of the little boys he'd seen playing, the toy bow still in his grasp. Ali immediately

dropped his hand. The boy looked at Ali with innocent black eyes; Ali saw he had used charcoal to draw a crooked black arrow on his cheek.

An Afshin arrow. Ali scowled. It was just like the fire worshippers to let their children run around pretending to be war

criminals. He touched his ear, and came away with a smear of blood on his fingers.

Abu Nuwas pulled free his zulfiqar and stepped forward with a snarl, but Ali held him back. "Don't. He's just a boy."

Seeing that he wasn't going to be punished, the boy gave them a wicked grin and jumped off the fountain to flee down a twisting alley.

Kaveh's eyes were bright with mirth. Across the plaza, a veiled woman held a hand across her hidden mouth, though Ali could

hear her giggle. The old men playing chatrang had their eyes fixed on their game pieces, but their mouths twitched in amusement.

Ali's cheeks grew warm with embarrassment.

Rashid stepped up to him. "You

should

have the boy arrested, Qaid," he said quietly in Geziriyya. "He's young. Give him to the Citadel to be raised properly as

one of us. Your ancestors used to do so all the time."

Ali paused, nearly taken in by Rashid's reasonable tone. And then he stopped.

How is that any different from purebloods stealing shafit children?

And the fact that he could do it, that Ali could snap his fingers and have a boy kidnapped from the only home he'd ever know,

wrested from his parents and his people . . . ?

Well, it suddenly explained why someone like Kaveh might look upon him with such hostility.

Ali shook his head, uneasy. "No. Let's just go back to the Citadel."

"Oh, my love, my light, how you have stolen my happiness!"

Ali let out a grumpy sigh. It was a beautiful night. A thin moon hung over Daevabad's dark lake, and stars twinkled in the

cloudless sky. The air was fragrant with frankincense and jasmine. Before him played the city's finest musicians, at hand

was a platter of food from the king's favored chef, and the dark eyes of the singer would have driven a dozen human men to their knees.

Ali was miserable. He fidgeted in his seat, keeping his gaze on the floor and trying to ignore the jingle of ankle bells and

the girl's smooth voice singing of things that made his blood rise. He tugged at the stiff collar of the new silver dishdasha

Muntadhir had forced him to wear. Embroidered with a dozen rows of seed pearls, it was tight on his throat.

His behavior didn't go unnoticed. "Your little brother doesn't appear to be having a good time, my emir." An even silkier

female voice interrupted the singer, and Ali glanced up to meet Khanzada's coy smile. "Are my girls not to your liking, Prince Alizayd?"

"Don't take it personally, my light," Muntadhir interrupted, kissing the hennaed hand of the courtesan curled at his side.

"He got shot in the face this morning by a child."

Ali threw his brother an annoyed look. "Do you have to keep bringing it up?"

"It's very funny."

Ali scowled, and Muntadhir lightly smacked his shoulder. "Ya, akhi, can you at least try to look less murderous? I invited

you here so we could celebrate your promotion, not so you could terrify my friends." He gestured at the dozen or so men arrayed

around them, a handpicked group of the wealthiest and most influential nobles in the city.

"You didn't invite me." Ali sulked. "You ordered me."

Muntadhir rolled his eyes. "You're part of Abba's court now, Zaydi." He switched to Geziriyya and lowered his voice. "Socializing

with these people is part of it . . . hell, it's supposed to be a perk."

"You know how I feel about these"--Ali waved his hand at a nobleman giggling like a little girl, and the man abruptly shut up--"

debaucheries

."

Muntadhir sighed. "You need to stop talking like that, akhi." He nodded at the platter. "Why don't you eat something? Maybe the weight of some food in your stomach will drag you off your high horse."

Ali grumbled but obeyed, leaning forward to take a small glass of sour tamarind sherbet. He knew Muntadhir was just trying to be kind, to ease his awkward, Citadel-raised little brother into court life, but Khanzada's salon made Ali terribly uncomfortable.

A place like this was the epitome of the wickedness Anas had wanted to eradicate in Daevabad.

Ali stole a glance at the courtesan as she leaned in to whisper in Muntadhir's ear. Khanzada was said to be the most skilled

dancer in the city, hailing from a family of acclaimed Agnivanshi illusionists. She was stunning, Ali would admit that. Even

Muntadhir, his handsome older brother famous for leaving a string of broken hearts in his wake, had fallen for her.

I suppose her charms are enough to pay for all this

. Khanzada's salon was located in one of the city's most desirable neighborhoods, a leafy enclave nestled in the heart of

the Agnivanshi Quarter's entertainment district. Her home was large and beautiful, three floors of white marble and cedar-screened

windows that surrounded an airy courtyard with fruit trees and an intricately tiled fountain.

Ali would have seen the entire place razed to the ground. He despised these pleasure houses. It wasn't enough that they were

dens of every vice and sin imaginable, put on brazen public display, but he knew from Anas that most of these girls were shafit

slaves stolen from their families and sold to the highest bidder.

"My lords."

Ali looked up. The girl who had been dancing stopped before them and bowed low to the ground, pressing her hands on the tiled

floor. Though her hair had the same night-black sheen as Khanzada's and her skin shimmered like a pureblood, Ali could see

round ears beneath her sheer veil. Shafit.

"Rise, my dear," Muntadhir said. "Such a pretty face does not belong on the floor."

The girl stood and pressed her palms together, blinking long-lashed hazel eyes at his brother. Muntadhir smiled, and Ali wondered

if Khanzada would have some competition tonight. His brother beckoned her closer and hooked a finger into her bangles. She

giggled, and he removed one of the strands of pearls that looped his neck, playing at placing it over her veil. He whispered

something in her ear, and she laughed again. Ali sighed.

"Perhaps Prince Alizayd would like some of your attention, Rupa," Khanzada teased. "Do you like your men tall, dark, and hostile?"

Ali shot her a glare, but Muntadhir only laughed. "It might help your attitude, akhi," he said as he nuzzled the girl's neck.

"You're too young to have sworn off them completely."

Khanzada pressed closer to Muntadhir. She trailed her fingers down his waist-wrap. "And Geziri men make it so easy," she said,

tracing the pattern embroidered on the hem. "Even their garments are practical." She grinned and removed her hand from his brother's lap to run it down Rupa's smooth face.

She looks like she's evaluating a piece of fruit at the market

. Ali cracked his knuckles. He was a young man--he'd be lying if he said the pretty girl didn't stir him--but that only made him more uneasy.

Khanzada took his disdain the wrong way. "I have other girls if this one doesn't suit your interest. Boys, as well," she added

with a wicked grin. "Perhaps such an adventurous taste runs in the--"

"Enough, Khanzada," Muntadhir cut in, a note of warning in his voice.

The courtesan laughed and slid into Muntadhir's lap. She pressed a wineglass to his lips. "Forgive me, my love."

The humor returned to Muntadhir's face, and Ali looked away, his temper rising. He didn't like to see this side of his brother;

such profligacy would be a weakness when he was king. The shafit girl looked between them.

As if awaiting orders

. Something in Ali snapped. He dropped his spoon, folding his arms across his chest. "How old are you, sister?"

"I . . ." Rupa looked again to Khanzada. "I am sorry, my lord, but I do not know."

"She's old enough," Khanzada interrupted.

"Is she?" Ali asked. "Well, I'm sure you would know . . . you'd be certain to get all the details of her pedigree when you
bought her."

Muntadhir exhaled. "Simmer down, Zaydi."

But it was Khanzada who grew irate. "I do not
buy

anyone," she said, defending herself. "I have a list of girls wishing entrance to my school as long as my arm."

"I am certain you do," Ali said scornfully. "And how many of your customers must they sleep with to get off this list?"

Khanzada straightened up, fire in her tin-colored eyes. "Excuse me?"

Their argument was attracting curious glances; Ali switched to Geziriyya so only Muntadhir could understand him. "How can
you even sit here, akhi? Have you ever given thought to where--"

Khanzada jumped to her feet. "If you want to accuse me of something, at least have the courage to say it in a language I can
understand, you half-tribe brat!"

Muntadhir abruptly straightened up at her words. The nervous chatter of the other men died away, and the musicians stopped
playing.

"

What

did you just call him?" Muntadhir demanded. Ali had never heard such ice in his voice.

Khanzada seemed to realize she had made a mistake. The anger vanished from her face, replaced by fear. "I-I only meant--"

"I don't care what you meant," Muntadhir snapped. "How dare you say such a thing to your prince? Apologize."

Ali reached for his brother's wrist. "It's fine, Dhiru. I shouldn't have--"

Muntadhir cut him off with a raised palm. "Apologize, Khanzada," he repeated. "Now."

She quickly pressed her palms together and lowered her eyes. "Forgive me, Prince Alizayd. I did not mean to insult you."

"Good." Muntadhir shot a look at the musicians so reminiscent of their father it made Ali's skin crawl. "What are you all
staring at? Play on!"

Ali swallowed, too embarrassed to look at anyone in the room. "I should go."

"Yes, you probably should." But before Ali could rise, his brother grabbed him by the wrist. "And don't ever disagree with
me in front of these men again," he warned in Geziriyya. "Especially when
you're

the one being an ass." He let go of Ali's arm.

"Fine," Ali muttered. Muntadhir still had a strand of pearls looped around Rupa's neck like some extravagant leash. The girl
was smiling, but the expression didn't meet her eyes.

Ali pulled a heavy silver ring off his thumb as he stood up. He met the shafit girl's gaze and then dropped the ring on the
table. "My apologies."

He took the dark steps that led to the street two at a time, struck by his brother's swift response. Muntadhir clearly hadn't
agreed with Ali's behavior, but had still defended him, had humiliated his own lover to do so. He hadn't even hesitated.

We are Geziri. It's what we do

. Ali was just clear of the house when a voice spoke up behind him.

"Not quite to your taste?"

Ali glanced back. Jamshid e-Pramukh lounged outside Khanzada's door, smoking a long pipe.

Ali hesitated. He didn't know Jamshid well. Though Kaveh's son served in the Royal Guard, he did so in a Daeva contingent

whose training was segregated--and purposefully inferior. Muntadhir spoke highly of the Daeva captain--his bodyguard for over
a decade and his closest friend--but Jamshid was always quiet in Ali's presence.

Probably because his father thinks I want to burn down the Grand Temple with all the Daevas inside it.

Ali could only imagine the things said about him in the privacy of the Pramukh household.

"Something like that," Ali finally replied.

Jamshid laughed. "I told him to take you someplace quieter, but you know your brother

when he sets his mind on a thing." His
dark eyes sparkled, his voice warm with affection.

Ali made a face. "Fortunately, I think I've worn out my invitation."

"You're in good company then." Jamshid took another drag from the pipe. "Khanzada hates me."

"Really?" Ali couldn't imagine what the courtesan would have against the mild-mannered guard.

Jamshid nodded and held out the pipe, but Ali demurred. "I think I'll just head back to the palace."

"Of course." He motioned down the street. "Your secretary's waiting for you in the midan."

"Rashid?" Ali frowned. He didn't have any further business this evening that he could recall.

"He didn't get around to offering his name." A hint of annoyance flickered in Jamshid's eyes, gone in a moment. "Nor did he
want to wait here."

Odd

. "Thank you for letting me know." Ali started to turn away.

"Prince Alizayd?" When Ali turned back, Jamshid continued. "I'm sorry for what happened in our quarter today. We're not all
like that."

The apology took him aback. "I know," Ali replied, unsure of what else to say.

"Good." Jamshid winked. "Don't let my father get to you. It's a thing at which he excels."

That brought a smile to Ali's face. "Thank you," he said sincerely. He touched his heart and brow. "Peace be upon you, Captain
Pramukh."

"And upon you peace."

11: Nahri

11

Nahri

Nahri took a long swig of water from the skin, swirled it around in her mouth, and spat. She'd have given her last dirham

to drink without feeling grit in her teeth. She sighed and leaned heavily against Dara's back, letting her legs hang loose on the horse.

"I hate this place," she mumbled into his shoulder. Nahri was used to sand--she dealt with the storms that coated Cairo in

a hazy yellow dust every spring--but this was unbearable.

They'd left the last oasis days ago, stealing a new horse and making one last push across open, unprotected ground. Dara said

there was no choice; everything between the oasis and Daevabad was desert.

It had been a brutal crossing. They barely spoke, both too weary to do more than hold on to the saddle and continue in companionable

silence. Nahri was filthy; dirt and sand clung to her skin and matted her hair. It was in her clothes and her food, under

her nail beds and in between her toes.

"It's not much farther," Dara assured her.

"You always say that," she muttered. She shook out a cramped arm and then wrapped it around his waist again. A few weeks ago

she would have been too embarrassed to hold him so boldly, but now she no longer cared.

The landscape began to change, hills and scrubby, frail trees replacing the bare dirt. The wind picked up, blue clouds rolling

in from the east to darken the sky.

When they finally stopped, Dara slid off the saddle and pulled away the filthy cloth that covered his face. "Praise be to

the Creator."

She took his hand as he helped her down. No matter how many times she dismounted, it always took a few minutes for her knees

to remember how to work. "Are we there?"

"We've reached the Gozan River," he replied, sounding relieved. "Daevabad's threshold is just across the water, and none but

our kind can pass through it. Not ifrit, not ghouls, not even peris."

The land came to an abrupt end in a cliff that overlooked the river. In the gloomy light, the wide, muddy river was an unappealing

brownish-gray, and the other side didn't look promising. All Nahri could see was more flat dirt. "I think you may have overstated

Daevabad's charms."

"Do you really think we'd leave a vast magical city open to the eyes of any curious human onlooker? It's hidden."

"How are we going to cross?" Even from up here, she could see whitecaps cresting on the rushing water.

Dara peered over the edge of the limestone cliff. "I could try to enchant one of the blankets," he suggested, not sounding

optimistic. "But let's wait until tomorrow." He nodded at the sky. "It looks like it's about to storm, and I don't want to

risk crossing in bad weather. I remember these cliffs being pocked with caves. We'll shelter in one for the night." He started

to lead the horse down a twisting, narrow path.

Nahri followed. "Any chance I could make a trip to the riverbank?"

"Why?"

"I smell like something died in my clothes, and I have enough dirt caked on my skin to make a double of myself."

He nodded. "Just be careful. The way down is steep."

"I'll be fine."

Nahri trekked down the sharp hill, zigzagging past rocky boulders and stunted trees. Dara hadn't lied. She tripped twice and

cut her palms on the sharp rocks, but the chance to bathe was worth it. She stayed close to the riverbank as she quickly scrubbed

her skin, ready to jump back if the current grew too strong.

The sky grew darker by the minute; an unhealthy tinge of green lined the clouds. Nahri climbed out of the water, wrung out

her hair, and shivered. The air was humid and smelled of lightning. Dara was right about the storm.

She was shoving her wet feet into her boots when she felt it. The touch of the wind, so firm it was like a hand upon her shoulder.

She immediately straightened up and spun around, ready to hurl her boot at whatever it was.

There was no one. Nahri scanned the rocky shore, but it was empty and still save for the dead leaves blowing in the breeze.

She sniffed and caught the oddly strong scent of peppercorns and mace. Maybe Dara was attempting to conjure up a new dish.

She followed the small trail of smoke drifting in the sky behind her until she found Dara sitting at the mouth of a dark cave.

A pot of stew bubbled over the flames.

He glanced up and smiled. "Finally. I was starting to fear you drowned."

The wind whipped through her wet hair, and she trembled. "Never," she declared, cozying up to the fire. "I swim like a fish."

He shook his head. "All your swimming reminds me of the Ayaanle. I ought to check your neck for crocodile scales."

"Crocodile scales?" She snatched up his goblet in hopes the wine would warm her. "Truly?"

"Ay, it's just something we say about them." He pushed the pot in her direction. "Crocodiles are one of the preferred forms

of the marid. Supposedly the ancient Ayaanle used to worship them. Their descendants don't like talking about it, but I've

heard bizarre stories about their old rituals." He took the goblet back from her; the goblet refilled with wine the instant

his fingers touched the stem.

Nahri shook her head. "What is it tonight?" she asked, looking at the stew with a knowing smile. The question had turned into

a game: try as he might, Dara had never been able to conjure up anything other than his mother's lentil dish.

He grinned. "Pigeons stuffed with fried onions and saffron."

"How forbidden." She helped herself to the food. "The Ayaanle live near Egypt, yes?"

"Far to the south; your land is too fat with humans for the tastes of our people."

The rain began to fall. Thunder rumbled in the distance, and Dara made a face as he wiped water from his brow. "Tonight is

not a night for stories," he declared. "Come." He picked up the pot, indifferent to the hot metal. "We should get out of the

rain and get some sleep." He fixed his gaze on the hidden city beyond the river, and his expression turned unreadable. "We

have a long day ahead of us."

Nahri slept fitfully, her dreams bizarre and full of thunder. It was still dark when she woke, their fire reduced to glowing

embers. Rain battered the mouth of the cave, and she could hear the wind howling past the cliffs.

Dara was stretched out beside her on one of the blankets, but they'd grown familiar enough that she could tell from the cadence

of his breathing that he was also awake. She rolled over to face him, realizing that he'd spread his robe over her as she

slept. He lay flat on his back, his hands crossed over his stomach like a corpse.

"Trouble sleeping?" she asked.

He didn't move, his gaze fixed on the rocky ceiling. "Something like that."

A flash of lightning lit up the cave, followed shortly by a rumble of thunder. She studied his profile in the dim light. Her

gaze trailed his long-lashed eyes down his neck and across his bare arms. Her stomach fluttered; she was suddenly aware of how little space separated them.

Not that it mattered--Dara's mind was clearly worlds away. "I wish it were not raining," he said, his voice uncharacteristically

wistful. "I would have liked to look upon the stars in case . . ."

"In case?" she prompted when he trailed off.

He glanced at her, looking almost embarrassed. "In case it's my last night as a free man."

Nahri flinched. Too busy searching the sky for more rukh and trying to survive the last leg of their grueling journey, Nahri

had barely given further thought to their reception in Daevabad. "Do you really think you're going to be arrested?"

"It's likely."

There was a hint of fear in his voice, but having learned how prone to exaggeration Dara could be--especially when it came

to the djinn--Nahri tried to reassure him. "You're probably just ancient history to them, Dara. Not everyone is capable of

holding a grudge for fourteen centuries." He scowled and looked away, and she laughed. "Oh, come now, I'm just teasing you."

She pushed up on one elbow, and without thinking much of it, reached for his cheek to turn him back to face her.

Dara startled at her touch, his eyes bright with surprise. No, not at her touch, Nahri realized with some embarrassment, rather

at the position she'd inadvertently put them in, her body half-draped over his chest.

She flushed. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to--"

He touched her cheek.

Dara looked nearly as astonished as she did at the act, as if his fingers were lightly tracing her jaw of their own accord.

There was so much longing in his face--as well as a good bit of indecision--that Nahri's heart began to race, heat pooling in her stomach.

Don't

, she told herself.

He's the literal enemy of the people you're about to ask for sanctuary, and you want to add this

to the ties already binding you?

Only a fool would do such a thing.

She kissed him.

Dara made a halfhearted sound of protest against her mouth and then promptly tangled his hands in her hair. His lips were

warm and urgent, and every part of her seemed to cheer as he kissed her back, her body filled with a hunger her mind was screaming warnings against.

He broke away. "We can't," he gasped, his warm breath tickling her ear, sending a thrill down her spine. "This--this is completely inappropriate . . ."

He was right, of course. Not about being inappropriate--Nahri had never much cared about that. But it was

stupid

. This was how lovesick idiots ruined their lives, and Nahri had delivered enough bastards and nursed enough broken wives

through the last stages of syphilis to know. But she'd just spent a month with this arrogant, infuriating man, every night

and day at his side, a month of his smoldering eyes and his scalding hands that lingered both a little too long and yet never long enough.

She rolled on top of him, and the look of stunned disbelief on his face was worth it alone.

"Shut up, Dara." And then she kissed him again.

There was no sound of protest now. There was a gasp--half exasperation, half desire--then

he pulled her down against him, and
Nahri's thoughts stopped being coherent.

She was fumbling with the maddeningly complicated knot on his belt, his hands slipping under her tunic, when the cave shook
with the loudest boom of thunder Nahri had yet heard.

She stilled. She didn't want to--Dara's mouth had just found a delightful spot at the base of her throat and the press of his
hips against hers was doing things to her blood she'd never thought possible. But then a flash of lightning--brighter than
the rest--lit up the cave. Another breeze swept in, extinguishing the small fire and sending Dara's bow and quiver clattering
to the floor.

At the sound of his precious weapon hitting the ground, he looked up, and then froze, noticing the expression on her face.
"What's wrong?"

"I . . . I don't know." The thunder continued to rumble, but beneath it was something else, almost like a whisper on the wind,
an urging in a language she didn't understand. The breeze came again, rustling and tugging at her hair, smelling of those
same spices. Peppercorn and cardamom. Clove and mace.

Tea. Khayzur's tea.

Nahri immediately drew back, filled with a foreboding she didn't understand. "I think . . . I think there's something out
there."

He frowned. "I didn't hear anything." But he sat up anyway, untangling his limbs from hers to retrieve his bow and quiver.

She shivered, cold without the warm press of his body. Grabbing his robe, she slipped it over her head. "It wasn't a sound,"
she insisted, knowing she probably sounded crazy. "It was something else."

Another bolt of lightning cracked across the sky, its flash outlining the daeva against the dark. His brow furrowed. "No,
they would not dare . . .," he whispered, almost to himself. "Not this close to the border."

Still, he handed her his dagger and then notched one of his silver arrows. He crept toward the cave's entrance. "Stay back,"
he warned.

Nahri ignored him, shoving the dagger in her belt and joining him at the cave's mouth. Rain

lashed their faces, but it wasn't

as dark as it had been earlier; the light from the moon was reflected in the swollen clouds.

Dara raised his bow and gave her a pointed look as the fletched end of the arrow caught her stomach. "At least a

little

back."

He stepped out, and she stayed at his side, not liking the way he flinched when the rain hit his face. "Are you sure you should

be going out in this weather--"

A bolt of lightning struck just ahead, and Nahri jumped, shielding her eyes. The rain stopped, the effect so immediate it

was as if someone turned off a spigot.

The wind whipped through her damp hair. She blinked, trying to clear the spots from her vision. The darkness was lifting.

The lightning had struck a tree right near them, setting the dead branches aflame.

"Come on. Let's go back inside," Nahri urged. But Dara didn't move, his gaze locked on the tree. "What is it?" she asked,

trying to push past his arm.

He didn't answer--he didn't have to. Flames raced down the tree, the heat so intense it instantly dried her wet skin. Acrid

smoke poured off the wood, seeping past the roots and pooling into hazy black tendrils that slithered and twirled, solidifying

as they slowly rose from the ground.

Nahri backed up and reached for Dara's arm. "Is . . . is it another daeva?" she asked, trying to sound hopeful as the smoky

ropes twisted together, thicker, faster.

Dara's eyes were wide. "I fear not." He took her hand. "I think we should leave."

They had no sooner turned back toward the cave when more black smoke swept down from the cliffs above, surging past the rocky

entrance like a waterfall.

Every hair on her body stood on end; the tips of her fingers buzzed with energy. "Ifrit," she whispered.

Dara stepped back so fast that he stumbled, his usual grace gone. "The river," he stammered. "Run."

"But our supplies--"

"There's no time." Keeping one hand clenched on her wrist, he dragged her down the rocky ridge. "Can you swim as well as you claim?"

Nahri hesitated, thinking back to the Gozan's fast current. The river was likely swollen from the storm, its already turbulent waters whipped into a frenzy. "I . . . maybe. Probably," she corrected, seeing alarm flash across his face. "But you can't!"

"It matters not."

Before she could argue, he pulled her along, racing and scrambling down the limestone hill. The steep decline was treacherous in the dark, and Nahri slipped more than once on the loose, sandy pebbles.

They were running along a narrow ledge when a low sound broke across the air, something between a lion's roar and the snap of an uncontrolled fire. Nahri glanced up, getting the briefest glimpse of something large and bright before it slammed into Dara.

The force knocked her back, her balance gone without the daeva's firm grip on her wrist. She grabbed for a tree branch, for a rock, for anything as she stumbled, but her fingers raked uselessly through the air. Her feet met nothing, and then she was over the ridge.

Nahri tried to protect her head as she hit the ground hard and rolled down the incline, the jagged rocks gouging her arms. Her body bounced past another small ledge, and then she landed in a thick patch of mud. The back of her head smashed into a hidden tree root.

She lay still, stunned by the blinding pain, the wind knocked out of her. Every part of her hurt. She tried to take a small breath and cried out at the protest of an obviously broken rib.

Just breathe. Don't move

. She needed to let her body heal. She knew it would; already the sting of her torn flesh was fading. She gingerly touched the back of her head, praying that her skull was still intact. Her fingers met bloodied hair but nothing else. Thank the Most High for that small piece of luck.

Something in her abdomen twisted back into place, and she sat up, wiping her eyes free of

blood or mud or God only knew what.

She squinted. The Gozan was ahead of her, the rushing water glistening as it crested into rapids.

Dara

. She climbed to her feet and staggered forward, peering through the darkness at the ridge.

Another flash blinded her, and the air crackled, followed by a deafening boom that knocked her back. Nahri threw up her hands

to protect her eyes, but the light was already gone, vanished in a haze of quickly evaporating blue smoke.

Then the ifrit was there, towering over her with arms as thick as tree boughs. Its flesh was pressed light, its skin shimmering

between the ashy white of smoke and the crimson-tinged orange of fire. Its hands and feet were coal black, its hairless body

covered with a scrawl of ebony markings even wilder than Dara's.

And it was beautiful. Strange and deadly, but beautiful. She froze as a pair of golden feline eyes settled on her. It smiled,

its teeth blackened and sharp. A coal-colored hand reached for the iron scythe at its side.

Nahri jumped to her feet and dashed across the rocks to open water, landing in the shallows with a splash. But the ifrit was

too fast, snatching her ankle as she tried to swim away. She clawed at the muddy river bottom, hooking her fingers on a submerged tree root.

The ifrit was stronger. He yanked again, and Nahri screamed as he dragged her back. He'd grown brighter, his skin pulsing

with hot yellow light. A scar ran across his bald head like a smear of extinguished charcoal. The thief in her could not help

but note the gleaming bronze chest plate he wore over a simple linen waist cloth. A string of raw quartz stones looped his neck.

He raised her hand as if in shared victory. "I have her!" he screamed in a language that sounded like wildfire. He grinned

again and ran his tongue over his sharp teeth, a look of unmistakable hunger in his gold eyes. "The girl! I have--"

Recovering her senses, Nahri grabbed for the dagger Dara had given her in the cave. Nearly slicing off one of her fingers

in the process, she plunged it deep into the ifrit's fiery chest. He cried out and dropped her wrist, sounding more surprised

than hurt.

He lifted one painted eyebrow as he glanced down at the dagger, obviously unimpressed. Then he slapped her hard across the face.

The blow knocked Nahri off her feet. She reeled, black spots blinking before her eyes. The ifrit pulled the dagger free, barely glancing at it before he flung it past her.

She scrambled up, slipping and staggering as she tried to back away. She couldn't take her eyes off his scythe. The iron blade was stained black, the edge battered and dull. It would kill her, no doubt, and it would hurt. A lot. She wondered how many of her Nahid ancestors had met their end upon that scythe.

Dara

. She needed the Afshin.

The ifrit followed at a leisurely pace. "So you're the one getting all the races riled up . . .," he started. "The latest of Anahid's treacherous, blood-poisoning spawn."

The hate in his voice sent a new surge of fear through her body. She spotted the dagger on the ground and snatched it up.

It might not hurt the ifrit, but it was all she had. She held it out, trying to keep as much distance as possible between them.

The ifrit grinned again. "Are you afraid, little healer?" he drawled. "Are you trembling?" He caressed his blade. "What I would do to see that traitor's blood run out of you . . ." But then he dropped his hand, looking regretful. "Alas, we made a deal to return you unharmed."

"

Unharmed?

" She thought back to Cairo, the memory of the ghoul's teeth ripping open her throat vivid in her mind. "Your ghouls tried to eat me!"

The ifrit spread his hands, looking apologetic. "My brother acted rashly, I admit." He cleared his throat as if he was having trouble speaking, and then tilted his head to regard her. "Astonishing really, I give the marid their due. At first glance,

you're completely human, but look past that and . . ." He stepped closer to study her face. "There's the daeva."

"I'm not," she said quickly. "Whoever you're working for . . . whatever it is you want . . . I'm just a shafit. I can't do

anything," she added, hoping the lie might buy her some time. "You don't need to waste your time on me."

"Just a

shafit

?" He laughed. "Is that what that lunatic slave thinks?"

The sound of a crashing tree drew her attention before she could respond. A line of fire danced across the ridge, consuming

the scrub brush as if it was kindling.

The ifrit followed Nahri's glance. "Your Afshin's arrows might be sharper than his wits, little healer, but you are both outmatched."

"You said you meant us no harm."

"We mean

you

no harm," he corrected. "The wine-soaked slave was not part of our deal. But perhaps . . . if you come willingly . . ." He

trailed off with a cough and took in a sharp breath.

As she watched, he wheezed and reached for a nearby tree to brace himself. He coughed again, clutching his chest where she

had wounded him. He pulled the breastplate off, and Nahri gasped. The skin around the wound had turned black with what looked

like infection. And it was spreading, tiny coal-colored tendrils snaking out like delicate veins.

"Wha-what did you do to me?" he cried out as the blackening veins gave way to a blue-tinged ash before their eyes. He coughed

again, hacking up a dark viscous liquid that steamed when it hit the ground. He staggered closer and tried to grab her. "No . . .

you didn't. Say you didn't!" His golden eyes were wide with panic.

Still clutching the dagger, Nahri edged back, fearing the ifrit might be trying to trick her. But as he clutched his throat

and fell to his knees, sweating ash, she remembered something Dara had told her weeks ago over the Euphrates.

It was said the very blood of a Nahid was poisonous to the ifrit, more fatal than any blade.

As if in a trance, her gaze slowly fell on the dagger. Mixed in with the ifrit's black blood was her own dark crimson from

when she'd cut herself trying to stab him.

She looked back at the ifrit. He was lying on the rocks, blood leaking from his mouth. His eyes, beautiful and terrified,

met hers. "No . . . ," he panted. "We had a deal . . ."

He hit me. He threatened to kill Dara

. Acting on a rush of cold hate and instinct that likely would have frightened her if she had given it more thought, she kicked

him hard in the stomach. He cried out, and she dropped to her knees, pressing her dagger against his throat.

"Who did you make a deal with?" she demanded. "What did they want with me?"

He shook his head and took a rattling breath. "Filthy Nahid scum . . . you're all the same," he spat. ". . . knew it was a

mistake . . ."

"Who?" she demanded again. When he said nothing, she slashed her hand open and pressed her bloody palm against his wound.

The sound that came from the ifrit was unlike any she could imagine: a screech that tore at her soul. She wanted to turn away,

to flee into the river and submerge herself, escaping all this.

Nahri thought again of Dara. Over a thousand years as a slave, stolen from his people and murdered, given over to the whims

of countless cruel masters. She saw Baseema's gentle smile, the most innocent of innocents gone forever. She pushed harder.

With her other hand, she kept the dagger against his throat, though judging from his shrieks, it wasn't necessary. She waited

until his cries turned to a whimper. "Tell me, and I'll heal you."

He squirmed under her blade, his eyes briefly dilating black. The wound bubbled, steaming like an overfilled cauldron, and

a terrible liquid sound came from his throat.

"Nahri!" Dara's voice rose from somewhere in the dark, a distant distraction. "Nahri!"

The ifrit's fevered gaze fixed on her face. Something flickered in his eyes, something calculating and vile. He opened his

mouth. "Your mother," he wheezed. "We made a deal with Manizheh."

"What?" she asked, so startled that she nearly dropped the knife. "My

what

?"

The ifrit started to seize, a rattling moan coming from somewhere low in his throat. His eyes dilated again, and his mouth

fell open, a haze of steam rushing past his lips. Nahri grimaced. She doubted she'd get much more information from him.

His fingers scrabbled on her wrist. "Heal me . . . ," he begged. "You promised."

"I lied." With a sharp and vicious motion, she slashed her hand back and cut his throat. Dark vapor rose from his maimed neck

and stifled his cry. But his eyes, fixed and hateful, stayed on her blade, watching as she raised it over his chest.

The throat . . .

Dara had once instructed, the weaknesses of the ifrit one of the few things he would tell her.

. . . the lungs

. She brought the blade back down, plunging it into his chest. It didn't go in easily, and she fought the urge to vomit as

she leaned her weight into the dagger. Viscous black blood gushed over her hands. The ifrit convulsed once, twice, and then

fell still, his chest lowering like she'd emptied a sack of flour. Nahri watched another moment but knew he was dead, felt

the lack of life and vigor immediately. She had killed him.

She stood; her legs trembled.

I killed a man

. She stared at the dead ifrit, transfixed by the sight of his blood seeping and smoking over the pebbly ground.

I killed him

.

"Nahri!" Dara skidded to a stop in front of her. He took one of her arms as his alarmed eyes raked over her bloodied clothing.

He touched her cheek, his fingers grazed her wet hair. "By the Creator, I was so worried . . . Suleiman's eye!"

Spotting the ifrit, he leaped back, pulling her protectively behind him. "He . . . you . . . ," he stammered, sounding more

shocked than she had ever heard him. "You killed an ifrit." He whirled on her, his green eyes flashing. "

You

killed an ifrit?" he repeated as he took a closer look.

Your mother

. . . The ifrit's final claim taunted her. She couldn't forget that strange flicker in his eyes before he spoke. Was it a

lie? Words meant to haunt the enemy who would kill him?

A hot breeze swept past her cheeks, and Nahri lifted her eyes. The cliffs were on fire; the wet trees snapped and cracked

as they burned. The air smelled poisonous, hot and seeded with tiny burning embers that swept across the dead landscape and

twinkled above the dark river.

She pressed one of her bloody hands against her temple as a wave of nausea swept over her. She turned away from the dead ifrit,

the sight of its body triggering a strange sense of rightness that she didn't like. "I . . . he said something about . . ."

She stopped speaking. More black smoke was coming down the cliff, twisting and slithering through the trees and growing into

a thick roiling wave as it neared them.

"Get back!" Dara yanked her away, and the smoky tendrils flattened with a low hiss. Dara took the opportunity to shove her

toward the water. "Go, you can still get to the river."

The river. She shook her head; even as she watched, an enormous tree branch shot past like it had been fired from a cannon,

and the water roared as it crashed against the boulders littering its banks.

She couldn't even see the opposite shore--there was no way she could cross. And Dara would probably dissolve.

"No," she replied, her voice grim. "We'll never make it."

The smoke surged forward and began to separate, swirling and piling into three distinct shapes. The daeva snarled and drew

his bow. "Nahri, get in the water."

Before she could reply, Dara gave her a hard push, knocking her into the cold current. It wasn't deep enough for her to submerge,

but the river fought her as she climbed back to her feet.

Dara released one of his arrows, but it sailed uselessly through the nebulous forms. He

cursed and shot again as one of the

ifrit flashed with fiery light. A blackened hand grabbed the arrow. Still holding it, the ifrit burned back into its solid

form, followed immediately by the other two.

The ifrit with the arrow was even larger than the one Nahri had killed. The skin around his eyes smoldered in a rough band,

black and gold. The other two were smaller: another man and a woman wearing a diadem of braided metals.

The ifrit rolled Dara's arrow between his fingers. It began to melt, the silver winking as it dripped into the dirt. The ifrit

grinned, and then his hand smoked. The arrow was gone, replaced by an enormous iron mace. The spikes and ridges of its heavy

head were dull with blood. He hoisted the horrific weapon up on one shoulder and stepped forward.

"Salaam alaykum, Banu Nahida." He gave her a sharp smile. "I have

so

looked forward to this meeting."

The ifrit's Arabic was flawless, with just enough of Cairo's flavor to make her flinch. He inclined his head in a slight bow.

"You call yourself Nahri, yes?"

Dara drew back another arrow. "Don't answer that."

The ifrit lifted his hands. "There is no harm. I know it's not her real name." He turned his golden gaze back to Nahri. "I

am Aeshma, child. Why don't you come from the water?"

She opened her mouth to reply, but then the female sauntered over to Dara.

"My Scourge, it has been far too long." She licked her painted lips. "Look at that slave mark, Aeshma. A beauty. Have you

ever seen one as long?" She sighed, her eyes creasing in pleasure. "And oh, how he earned them."

Dara paled.

"Don't you remember, Darayavahoush?" When he said nothing, she gave him a sad smile.

"A pity. I've never seen a slave so ruthless.

Then again, you were always willing to do

anything

to stay in my good graces."

She leered at him, and Dara recoiled, looking sick. A surge of hatred swept through Nahri.

"Enough, Qandisha." Aeshma waved his companion off. "We are not here to make enemies."

Something brushed against Nahri's shins under the black water. She ignored it, focusing her attention on the ifrit. "What
do you want?"

"First: for you to get out of the water. There is no safety in there for you, little healer."

"And there's safety with you? One of your people in Cairo promised the same and then set a pack of ghouls on us. At least
there's nothing in here trying to eat me."

Aeshma raised his eyes. "A terribly ill choice of words, Banu Nahida. The denizens of air and water have already done you
both more harm than you know."

She frowned, trying to untwist his words. "What do you . . ." She stopped speaking. A shudder went through the river, like
something impossibly large heaving itself along the muddy bottom. She eyed the water around her. She could've sworn she saw
a flash of scales in the distance, a wet glistening that vanished as quickly as it had come.

The ifrit must have noticed her reaction. "Come now," he urged. "You are not safe."

"He's lying." Dara's voice was barely more than a growl. The daeva was still, his hate-filled gaze fixed on the ifrit.

The skinny one suddenly straightened up, sniffing the burning air like a dog before rushing into the brush where the murdered
ifrit lay.

"Sakhr!" The skinny ifrit cried, his luminous eyes wide in disbelief as he touched the throat Nahri had torn open. "No . . .
no, no,

no

!" He threw his head back and let out a screech of despair that seemed to rend the very air before bending back over the dead
ifrit and pressing his forehead to the corpse's.

His grief took her completely by surprise. Dara said the ifrit were demons. She wouldn't have thought they cared for each
other at all, let alone so deeply.

The wailing ifrit silenced his cry as he caught sight of her, and hate filled his golden eyes. "You murderous witch!" he accused
her, rising to his feet. "I should have killed you in Cairo!"

Cairo . . . Nahri backed up until the water surged around her waist.

Baseema

. He was the one who'd possessed Baseema, who doomed the little girl and sent the ghouls after them. Her fingers twitched
on her dagger.

He charged forward, but Aeshma grabbed him and threw him to the ground. "No! We made a deal."

The skinny ifrit jumped to his feet and immediately started after her again, snapping and hissing as he tried to wriggle free
of Aeshma's grasp. The dirt beneath his feet sparked. "The devil take your deal! She blood-poisoned him--I'm going to rip out
her lungs and grind her soul to dust!"

"

Enough!

" Aeshma threw him to the ground again and raised his mace. "The girl is under my protection." He glanced up and met Nahri's
eyes. There was a much colder look to his face now. "But the slave is not. If Manizheh wanted her bloody Scourge, she should
have told us." He lowered his weapon and gestured at Dara. "He's yours, Vizaresh."

"Wait!" Nahri cried as the skinny ifrit leaped on Dara. Dara smashed him across the face with his bow, but then Qandisha--bigger
than both men--simply grabbed Dara by the throat and lifted him off his feet.

"Drown him again," Aeshma suggested. "Maybe this time it will take." The river danced and boiled around his feet as he started
after Nahri.

Dara tried to kick Qandisha, his cry abruptly ending when she plunged him under the dark water. The ifrit laughed as Dara's
fingers clawed at her wrists.

"Stop!" Nahri screamed. "Let him go!" She hopped back, hoping to lose Aeshma in the deeper water and swim back to Dara.

But as Aeshma closed in, the river swept back, almost like a wave drawing up. It pulled from the bank, pulled from her ankles,
and in seconds, it was gone from her feet altogether, leaving her standing in a foot

of muck.

Absent the sound of the rushing current, the world went quiet. There was not even a hint of wind, the air saturated with the
scent of salt, smoke, and wet silt.

Taking advantage of Aeshma's distraction, Nahri darted toward Dara.

"Marid . . . ," the female ifrit whispered, her golden eyes wide with fright. She dropped Dara and grabbed the other ifrit
by his skinny arm, yanking him away. "Run!"

The ifrit were fleeing by the time Nahri reached Dara. He was holding his throat, sucking for air. As she tried to pull him
to his feet, his eyes locked on something past her shoulder, and the color left his face.

She glanced behind her. She immediately wished she hadn't.

The Gozan was gone.

A wide, muddy trench stood in the river's place, wet boulders and deep ridges marking its former path. The air was still smoky,
but the storm clouds had vanished, revealing a swollen moon and a rich spread of stars that lit up the sky. Or at least would
have lit up the sky had they not been steadily blinking out as something darker than night rose in front of them.

The river. Or what had been the river. It had drawn back and thickened, rapids and tiny waves still rippling across its surface,
swirling and churning, defying gravity to rise. It wriggled and undulated in the air, slowly towering over them.

Her throat tightened in fear. It was a serpent. A serpent the size of a small mountain and made entirely of rushing black
water.

The watery snake writhed, and Nahri got a glimpse of a head the size of a building, with whitecaps for teeth, as it opened
its mouth to roar again at the stars. The sound broke across the air, some horrifying combination of a crocodile's bellow
and the break of a tidal wave. Behind the serpent, she spied the sandy hills where Dara said Daevabad lay hidden.

He was frozen in terror now, and knowing how frightened he was of water, she didn't expect that to change. She tightened her
grip on his wrist. "Get up." She pulled him forward. "Get up!" When he moved too slowly for her liking, she slapped him hard

across the face and pointed toward the sandy dunes. "Daevabad, Dara! Let's go!
You can kill all the djinn you want once we
get there!"

Whether it was the slap or the promise of murder, the terror holding him seemed to break.
He grabbed her outstretched hand,
and they ran.

There was another roar, and a thick tongue of water lashed the spot where they'd been
standing, like a giant swatting a fly.

It crashed against the muddy bank, and water swept out to splash their feet as they
fled.

The serpent twisted and slammed to the ground just ahead of them. Nahri slid to a halt,
pulling Dara in another direction

to sprint across the emptied riverbed. It was littered with damp waterweeds and
drying boulders; Nahri stumbled more than

once, but Dara kept her on her feet as they dodged the crushing blows of the river
monster.

They had gotten a bit more than halfway across when the creature suddenly halted. Nahri
didn't turn around to see why, but

Dara did.

He gasped, his voice returning. "Run!" he screamed, as if they were not already doing so.
"Run!"

Nahri ran, her heart pounding, her muscles protesting. She ran so fast she didn't even
notice the ditch, a spot of what must

have been deep water, before she was sailing over it. She hit the uneven bottom
hard. Her ankle twisted as she landed, and

she heard the snap before she felt the pain of the broken bone.

Then from the ground, she saw what had made Dara scream.

Having risen once again to howl at the sky, the creature was letting its lower half dissolve
into a waterfall taller than

the Pyramids. The water rushed toward them, the wave at least three times her
height and spreading out in both directions.

They were caught.

Dara was at her side again. He clutched her close. "I'm sorry," he whispered. His fingers
snaked through her wet hair. She

could feel his warm breath as he kissed her brow. She held him tight, tucking her
head into his shoulder and taking a deep

breath of his smoky scent.

She expected it to be her last.

And then something slammed down between them and the wave.

The ground shook, and a high-pitched screech that would have frozen the blood of the bravest man alive broke the air. It sounded

like a whole flock of rukh descending upon their prey.

Nahri looked up from Dara's shoulder. Outlined against the rushing wave was an enormous sweep of wings, glittering with lime-colored

sparks where the starlight touched them.

Khayzur.

The peri shrieked again. He spread his wings, raised his hands, and then took a breath; as he inhaled, the air around Nahri

seemed to ebb--she could almost feel it being pulled from her lungs. Then he exhaled, sending a racing, funnel-shaped cloud toward the serpent.

The creature let out a watery bellow when the winds hit. A cloud of steam evaporated off its side, and it flinched, ducking

away toward the ground. Khayzur flapped his wings and sent another giant gust.

The serpent let out a defeated sound. It collapsed

in the distance with a crash, flattening back out across the land, gone in an instant.

Nahri let out a breath. Her ankle was already healing, but Dara had to help her to her feet and give her a shove to get out

of the ditch.

The river had lain down along different banks and was busily consuming the trees and ripping at the cliffs they had just escaped.

There was no sign of the ifrit.

They had crossed the Gozan.

They had made it.

She stood up, giving her ankle a delicate twist before she let out a triumphant shout. She could have thrown her head back

and howled at the stars herself, she was so thrilled to be alive. "By God, Khayzur has the

best

timing!" She grinned, glancing around for Dara.

But Dara wasn't behind her. Instead she spotted him rushing toward Khayzur. The peri landed on the ground and immediately

collapsed, his wings falling around him as he crumpled.

By the time she reached them, Khayzur lay cradled in Dara's arms. His lime-colored wings were marked with white boils and

gray scabs that grew larger before her eyes. He shuddered and several feathers fell to the ground.

". . . was following and tried to warn . . . ," he was saying to Dara. "You were so close . . . " The peri stopped to take

a deep, rattling breath. He looked shrunken, and there was a purplish cast to his skin. When he looked up at her, his colorless eyes were resigned. Doomed.

"Help him," Dara begged. "Heal him!"

Nahri bent to take his hand, but Khayzur waved her off. "There's nothing you can do," he whispered. "I broke our law." He

reached up and touched Dara's ring with one of his claws. "And not for the first time."

"Just let her try," Dara pleaded. "This can't be happening because you saved us!"

Khayzur gave him a bitter smile. "You still don't understand, Dara, about my people's role. Your race never did. Centuries

after being crippled by Suleiman for interfering with humans . . . and you still don't understand."

Taking advantage of Khayzur's distracted rambling, Nahri laid her palm over one of the boils. It hissed and grew icy at her

touch and then doubled in size. The peri yelped, and she pulled away. "I'm sorry," she rushed. "I've never healed anything like you."

"And you can't now," he said gently. He coughed to clear his throat and lifted his head, his long ears pricked up like a cat's.

"You need to go. My people are coming. The marid will be back, as well."

"I'm not leaving you," Dara said firmly. "Nahri can cross the threshold without me."

"It is not Nahri they want."

Dara's bright eyes widened, and he glanced around, as though he expected to see a new addition to their trio. "M-me?" he stammered.

"I don't understand. I'm nothing to either your race or the marids!"

Khayzur shook his head as the shrill cry of a large bird pierced the air. "Go. Please . . . ," he croaked.

"

No

." There was a tremor in Dara's voice. "Khayzur, I can't leave you. You saved my life, my soul."

"Then do the same for another." Khayzur rustled his wrecked wings and gestured at the sky. "What's coming is beyond you both.

Save your Nahid, Afshin. It's your duty."

It was as if he'd cast a spell on the daeva. She watched Dara swallow and then nod, all trace of emotion vanishing from his

face. He laid the peri carefully on the ground. "I am so sorry, old friend."

"What are you doing?" Nahri exclaimed. "Help him to his feet. We need to-- Dara!" she shouted as the daeva picked her up and

threw her over his shoulder. "Don't! We can't leave him here!" She kneed the daeva in the chest and tried to push off his

back, but his grip was too tight. "Khayzur!" she screamed, catching a glimpse of the injured peri.

He gave her a long, sad look before turning his gaze back to the sky. Four dark shapes soared over the cliffs. The wind kicked

up, seeding the air with sharp pebbles. She saw the peri wince and draw a withered wing across his face for protection.

"Khayzur!" She kicked at Dara again, but he only sped up, struggling to clamber over a sandy dune with her still on his shoulder.

"Dara, please! Dara, don't--"

And then she could not see Khayzur any longer, and they were gone.

12: Ali

12

Ali

Ali's spirits felt lighter as he headed for the midan, cheered by Jamshid's kind words. He passed under the Agnivanshi Gate,

its scattered oil lamps making it seem like traveling through a constellation. Ahead, the midan was still, the night songs

of insects replacing the sound of the music and drunken revelers he left behind. A cool breeze blew bits of rubbish and silvery

dead leaves across the ancient cobblestones.

A man stood at the fountain's edge. Rashid. Ali recognized him, though his secretary was out of uniform, dressed in a rather

bland dark robe and slate-colored turban.

"Peace be upon you, Qaid," Rashid greeted him as Ali came forward.

"And upon you peace," Ali replied. "Forgive me. I didn't think we had any further business this evening."

"Oh, no!" Rashid assured. "Nothing official, anyway." He smiled, his teeth a bright flash in the dark. "I hope you'll forgive

my impertinence. I didn't mean to pull you away from your evening amusements."

Ali made a face. "It's no bother, trust me."

Rashid smiled again. "Good." He gestured to the Tukharistani Gate. "I was on my way to see an old friend in the Tukharistani

Quarter, and thought you might like to come along. You've mentioned wanting to see more of the city."

It was a kind, if slightly strange, offer. Ali was the king's son; he wasn't someone you casually invited for tea. "Are you

sure? I wouldn't want to intrude."

"It's no intrusion at all. My friend runs a small orphanage. In truth, I thought it might be good for a Qahtani to be seen

there. They've fallen on rough times recently." Rashid shrugged. "Your choice, of course. I know you've had a long day."

Ali had, but he was also intrigued. "I'd like that very much, actually." He returned Rashid's smile. "Lead the way."

By the time they reached the heart of the Tukharistani Quarter, clouds had drawn past the

sky, veiling the moon and bringing

a light mist of rain. The weather did nothing to dissuade the crowds of merrymakers and evening shoppers, however. Djinn children

chased each other through the crowd, running after conjured-up pets of smoke while their parents gossiped under metal canopies

hastily erected to block the rain. The sound of the raindrops striking their battered copper surfaces echoed throughout the

quarter. Enclosed glass globes of enchanted fire hung from the storefronts, reflecting the puddles and dizzy array of colors

on the bustling street.

Ali narrowly avoided two men haggling over a glittering golden apple. A Samarkandi apple, Ali recognized; a lot of djinn swore

a single bite of its flesh was as effective as a Nahid's touch. Though Ali's Tukharistani wasn't great, he could hear pleading

in the prospective buyer's voice, and he glanced back. Rust-colored metal growths covered the man's face, and his left arm

ended in a stump.

Ali shuddered.

Iron poisoning

. It wasn't terribly uncommon, especially among djinn travelers who might drink from a stream without realizing it ran over

banks rich in the deadly metal. Iron built up in the blood for years, before striking violently and without warning, causing

limbs and skin to atrophy. Deadly and swift, it was nonetheless easily cured by a single visit to a Nahid.

Except there weren't any more Nahids. And that apple wouldn't help the doomed man, nor would the myriad other "cures" hawked

to desperate djinn by unscrupulous con artists. There was no substitute for a Nahid healer, and that was a dark truth that

most people--Ali included--tried not to think about. He averted his eyes.

Thunder rumbled, oddly distant. Perhaps a storm was brewing past the veil hiding the city. Ali kept his head down, hoping

to avoid both the rain and the curious glances of passersby. Even out of uniform, his height and royal finery gave him away,

provoking startled salaams and hurried bows in his direction.

When they reached a fork in the main road, Ali noticed a striking stone monument twice his height, built of worn sandstone,

roughly shaped like an elongated bowl, almost like a boat placed on its stern. The top had started to crumble, but as they

passed, he spotted new incense at its base. A small oil lamp burned inside, throwing flickering light on a long list of names
in Tukharistani script.

The Qui-zi memorial. Ali's skin crawled as he recalled what happened to the ill-fated city. Which Afshin's handiwork had that

atrocities been again? Artash? Or was it Darayavahoush? Ali frowned, trying to remember his history lessons. Darayavahoush,

of course; Qui-zi was why people started calling him the Scourge. A nickname to which the Daeva devil had thoroughly committed,

judging from the horrors he would later perpetrate during his rebellion.

Ali glanced again at the memorial. The flowers inside were fresh, and he wasn't surprised. His people had long memories, and

what had happened at Qui-zi was not a thing easily forgotten.

Rashid finally stopped outside a modest two-story dwelling. It was not a particularly impressive sight; the roof tiles were

cracked and covered in black mold, and dying plants in broken pots were scattered out front.

His secretary tapped lightly on the door. A young woman opened it. She gave Rashid a tired smile that vanished as soon as

she spotted Ali.

She dropped into a bow. "Prince Alizayd! I . . . peace be upon you," she stammered, her Djinnistani laced with the thick accent

of Daevabad's working class.

"You can call him Qaid, actually," Rashid corrected. "At least for now." Amusement simmered in his voice. "May we come in,

sister?"

"Of course." She held open the door. "I'll prepare some tea."

"Thank you. And please tell Sister Fatumai that we're here. I'll be in the back. There's something I want to show the Qaid."

There is?

Curious, Ali wordlessly followed Rashid down a dark corridor. The orphanage looked clean--its floors were worn but well-scrubbed--but

in terrible disrepair. Water dripped into pans from the broken roof, and mildew covered the books that were neatly stacked

in a small classroom. The few toys he saw were sad things: animal bones carved into game pieces, patched dolls, and a ball

made of rags.

As they turned the corner, he heard a terrible hacking cough. Ali glanced down the corridor. It was dim, but he spotted the

shadowy form of an older woman supporting a skinny young boy upon a faded cushion. The boy started to cough again, the hacking sound interspaced by choked sobs.

The woman rubbed the boy's back as he fought for air. "It's okay, dear one," Ali heard her say softly, bringing a cloth to

his mouth as he coughed again. She pressed a steaming cup to his lips. "Have some of this. You'll feel better."

Ali's eyes locked on the cloth she'd held to the boy's mouth. It glistened with blood.

"Qaid?"

Ali glanced up, realizing Rashid was halfway down the corridor. He quickly caught up. "Sorry," he mumbled. "I didn't mean to stare."

"It's all right. These are things I'm sure you're usually kept from seeing."

It was a strangely worded response, delivered with a hint of chiding that Ali had never heard from his mild-mannered secretary.

But before he could dwell on it, they reached a large room fronting an uncovered courtyard. Tattered curtains, patched where possible, were all that separated it from the chilly rain falling in the yard.

Rashid pressed a finger to his lips and pulled back one of the curtains. The floor was crowded with sleeping children, dozens

of boys and girls wrapped in blankets and bedrolls, packed close for both warmth and lack of space, Ali imagined. He took a step closer.

They were shafit children. And curled under a quilt, her hair already starting to grow out, was the girl from Turan's tavern.

Ali stepped back so quickly he stumbled.

We have a safe house in the Tukharistani Quarter

. . . Horrified realization swept over him.

Rashid's hand landed heavy on his shoulder. Ali jumped, half-expecting a blade.

"Easy, brother," Rashid said softly. "You wouldn't want to startle the children . . ." He clapped his other hand over Ali's

as Ali reached for his zulfiqar. ". . . nor run from this place covered in another's blood. Not when you're so easily recognized."

"You bastard," Ali whispered, stunned by how easily he'd walked into a trap so obvious in hindsight. He wasn't usually one

for swearing, but the words tumbled out. "You fucking trait--"

Rashid's fingers dug a little deeper. "That's enough." He pushed Ali down the hall, gesturing to the next room. "We just want

to talk."

Ali hesitated. He could take Rashid in a fight, of that he was certain. But it would be bloody, and it would be loud. Their

location was intentional. A single shout, and he'd awaken dozens of innocent witnesses. He had no good options, and so Ali

steeled himself and walked through the door. His heart immediately sank.

"If it isn't the new Qaid," Hanno said, greeting him coolly. The shapeshifter's hand dropped to the long knife tucked in his

belt, and his copper eyes flashed. "I hope that red turban of yours was worth Anas's life."

Ali tensed, but before he could reply, a fourth person--the older woman from the corridor--joined them at the door.

She waved Hanno off. "Now, brother, surely that's no way to treat our guest." Despite the circumstances, her voice was oddly

cheerful. "Make some use of yourself, you old pirate, and pull me up a seat."

The shapeshifter grumbled, but did as he was told, laying a cushion upon a wooden crate. The woman made her way in, helped

by a black wooden cane.

Rashid touched his brow. "Peace be upon you, Sister Fatumai."

"And upon you, Brother Rashid." She settled onto the cushion. She was shafit, that much Ali could tell from her dark brown

eyes and rounded ears. Her hair was gray, half-covered by a white cotton shawl. She looked up at him. "My, you

are

tall. You must be Alizayd al Qahtani then." The slightest of amused smiles lit her pale face. "We meet at last."

Ali shifted uncomfortably on his feet. It was far easier to rage at the Tanzeem men than this grandmotherly figure. "Am I

supposed to know you?"

"Not yet, no. Though I suppose these times call for flexibility." She inclined her head. "My name is Hui Fatumai. I am . . ."

Her smile faded. "Rather, I was one of Sheikh Anas's associates. I run the orphanage here and many of the Tanzeem's charitable works. For which I should thank you. It was only through your generosity that we were able to do so much good."

Ali raised an eyebrow. "That's apparently not all you were doing with my 'generosity.' I saw the weapons."

"And what of it?" She nodded to the zulfikar at his waist. "You wear a weapon to protect yourself. Why should my people not have the same right?"

"Because it's against the law. Shafit aren't allowed to carry weapons."

"They're also forbidden medical care," Rashid cut in, giving Ali a knowing look. "Tell me, brother, whose idea was the clinic on Maadi Street? Who paid for that clinic and stole medical books from the royal library to train its providers?"

Ali flushed. "That's different."

"Not in the eyes of the law," Rashid rebuked. "Both preserve the lives of shafit, and thus both are forbidden."

Ali had no response for that. Fatumai was still studying him. Something that might have been pity flickered in her brown eyes.

"How young you are," she remarked quietly. "Far nearer in age to the children sleeping in the next room than to any of us, I imagine." She clucked her tongue. "I am almost sorry for you, Alizayd al Qahtani."

Ali didn't like the sound of that. "What do you want with me?" he asked. His nerves were starting to get the better of him, and his voice shook.

Fatumai smiled. "We want you to help save the shafit, of course. Ideally by resuming our funding as soon as possible."

He was incredulous. "You must be joking. Anas was supposed to buy food and books with the money I gave him, not rifles and daggers. You can't possibly think I'd give you a coin more."

"Full bellies mean nothing if we can't protect our children from slavers," Hanno snapped.

"And we already educate our people, Prince Alizayd," Fatumai added. "But to what end? Shafit are forbidden from skilled work;

if our kind are lucky, they can find a job as a servant or bed slave. Do you have any idea how hopeless that makes life in

Daevabad? There is no betterment save the promise of Paradise. We're not allowed

to leave, we're not allowed to work, our

women and children can be legally stolen by any pureblood claiming they're related--"

"Anas gave me the speech," Ali interrupted, his voice more cutting than he intended. But he had believed Anas's words before,

and the knowledge that his sheikh had lied to him still stung. "I'm sorry, but I've done everything in my power to help your

people." It was the truth. He'd given the Tanzeem a fortune and even now was quietly delaying the harsher measures his father

wanted to put in place on the shafit. "I don't know what else you expect."

"Influence." Rashid spoke up. "The sheikh did not recruit you for money alone. The shafit need a champion at the palace, a

voice to speak for their rights. And you need us, Alizayd. I know you're stalling those orders your father gave you. The new

laws you're supposed to be enforcing? Hunting down the traitor from the Royal Guard who stole zulfiqar training blades?" A

slight grin played on his mouth at that. "Let us help you, Brother Alizayd. Let us help each other."

Ali shook his head. "Absolutely not."

"This is a waste of time," Hanno declared. "The brat is Geziri--he'd probably let Daevabad burn to the ground before turning

on his own." His eyes flashed, and his fingers again lingered on the hilt of his knife.

"We should just kill him." Bitterness

crept into his voice. "Let Ghassan know what it feels like to lose a child."

Ali drew back in alarm, but Fatumai was already waving him off. "Give Ghassan a reason to slaughter every shafit in the city,

you mean. No, I don't think we'll be doing that."

From out in the corridor, the little boy began to cough again. The sound--that hacking, blood-tinged cough, that sad little

sob--cut deep, and Ali flinched.

Rashid noticed. "There's medicine for it, you know. And there are a few human-trained shafit physicians in Daevabad who could

help him, but their skills don't come cheap. Without your aid, we can't afford to treat him." He raised his hands. "To treat

any of them."

Ali dropped his gaze.

There's nothing to stop them from turning around and spending whatever I give them on weapons

. He'd trusted Anas far more than he trusted these strangers, and the sheikh had still deceived him. Ali could not risk betraying his family again.

A mouse darted past his feet, and a drop of rain landed on his cheek from a leak in the ceiling. In the next room, he could hear children snoring from their makeshift beds on the floor. He thought guiltily of the enormous bed back in the palace that he didn't even use. It would probably hold ten of those children.

"I can't," he said, his voice cracking. "I can't help you."

Rashid pounced. "You must

. You're a Qahtani. The shafit are the reason your ancestors came to Daevabad, the reason your family now possesses Suleiman's seal. You know the Holy Book, Alizayd. You know how it requires you to stand up for justice. How can you claim to be a man of God when--"

"That's quite enough," Fatumai spoke up. "I know you're passionate, Rashid, but insisting a boy not even near his first quarter century betray his family lest he be damned isn't going to help anyone." She let out a weary sigh, tapping her fingers on her cane. "This is not a thing that needs to be decided tonight," she declared. "Think on what we've said here, Prince. On what you've seen and heard in this place."

Ali blinked in disbelief. He glanced nervously among them. "You're letting me go?"

"I'm letting you go."

Hanno gaped. "Are you mad? He's going to run right to his abba! He'll have us rounded up by dawn!"

"No, he won't," Fatumai met his gaze, her face calculating. "He knows the cost too well. His father would come for our families, our neighbors . . . a whole score of innocent shafit. And if he's the boy of whom Anas spoke so fondly, the one on whom he pinned so many hopes . . ." She gave Ali an intent look. "He won't risk that."

Her words sent a shiver down his spine. She spoke correctly: Ali did know the cost. If Ghassan learned about the money, if he then suspected others might know it was a Qahtani prince who'd funded the Tanzeem . . . Daevabad's streets would be flowing with shafit blood.

And not just shafit

. Ali wouldn't be the first inconvenient prince to be assassinated. Oh, it would be done carefully, probably as quickly and

painlessly as possible--his father wasn't cruel. An accident. Something that wouldn't make his mother's powerful family too

suspicious. But it would happen. Ghassan took kingship seriously, and Daevabad's peace and security came before Ali's life.

Those weren't prices Ali was willing to pay.

His mouth was dry when he tried to speak. "I won't say anything," he promised. "But I'm done with the Tanzeem."

Fatimai didn't look even the slightest bit worried. "We'll see, Brother Alizayd." She shrugged. "Allahu alam."

She said the human holy words better than Ali's pureblood tongue would ever manage, and he couldn't help but tremble slightly

at the confidence in her voice, at the phrase meant to demonstrate the folly of man's confidence.

God knows best

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13: Nahri

13

Nahri

It was as if they stepped through an invisible door in the air. One minute Nahri and Dara were scrambling over dark dunes,

and the next, they emerged in an entirely new world, the dark river and dusty plains replaced by a small glen in a quiet mountain

forest. It was dawn; the rosy sky glowed against silver tree trunks. The air was warm and moist, rich with the smell of sap and dead leaves.

Dara dropped Nahri gently to her feet, and she landed on a soft patch of moss. She took a deep breath of the cool, clean air

before whirling on him.

"We need to go back," she demanded, shoving at his shoulders. There was no trace of the river, though through the trees, something

blue glistened in the distance. A sea, perhaps; it looked vast. She waved her hands through the air, searching for the way

through. "How do I do it? We need to get him before--"

"He's likely already dead," Dara interrupted. "From the stories told about the peris . . ." She heard his throat catch. "Their

punishments are swift."

He saved our lives

. Nahri felt sick. She angrily wiped away the tears rolling down her cheeks. "How could you leave him there? It was him you

should have carried, not me!"

"I . . ." Dara turned away with a choked sob and abruptly dropped onto a large, moss-covered boulder. His head fell into his

hands. The weeds surrounding him started to blacken and a hazy heat rose in waves above the rock. "I couldn't, Nahri. Only

those of our blood can cross the threshold."

"We could have tried to help. To fight--"

"How?" Dara glanced up. His eyes were dim with sorrow, but his expression was resolute.

"You saw what the marid did to the

river, how Khayzur fought back." He pressed his mouth in a grim line. "Compared to the marid and peri, we are insects. And

Khayzur was right--I had to get you to safety."

Nahri leaned against a crooked tree, feeling ready to collapse herself. "What do you think happened to the ifrit?" she finally asked.

"If there's any justice in this world, they were dashed upon the rocks and drowned." Dara spat. "That . . .

woman

," he said scornfully. "It was she who enslaved me. I remember her face from the memory you triggered."

Nahri wrapped her arms around herself; she was still wet, and the dawn air was cool. "The one I killed said they were working with my

mother

, Dara." Her voice choked on the word. "That Manizheh they kept talking about." She reeled; Khayzur's death, the mention of her mother, an entire damned

river

rising up to smash them to pieces . . . it was all too much.

Dara was at her side in a moment. He took her by the shoulders, bending to meet her gaze. "They're lying, Nahri," he said

firmly. "They're demons. You can't trust anything they say. All they do is deceive and manipulate. They do it to humans, they do it to daevas. They will say anything to trick you. To break you."

She managed a nod, and he briefly cupped her cheek with one hand. "Let's just get into the city," he said softly. "We should be able to find sanctuary at the Grand Temple. We'll figure out our next step there."

"All right." The press of his palm on her skin made her think back to what they'd been doing before the ifrit attack, and

she flushed. She glanced away, looking around them for the city. But she saw nothing but silvery trees and flashes of the sun-dappled water in the distance. "Where

is

Daevabad?"

Dara pointed through the trees. The forest descended sharply before them. "There's a lake at the bottom of the mountain. Daevabad

is on an island at its center. There should be a ferry down by the beach."

"The djinn use ferries?" It was so unexpected and so human, she almost broke into laughter.

He raised an eyebrow. "Can you think of a better way to cross a lake?"

Movement drew her eye. Nahri glanced up, catching sight of a gray hawk perched in the trees opposite her. It stared back,
shifting on its feet as it settled into a more comfortable position.

She turned back to Dara. "I suppose not. Lead the way."

Nahri followed him through the trees as the sun climbed higher and filled the forest with a lovely, pale yellow light. Her

bare feet crunched through the underbrush, and as she passed a thick bush with spindly dark green leaves, she let her hands

drift out to briefly cradle a spray of salmon-colored buds. They warmed to her touch and began to blossom ever so slightly.

She glanced at Dara from the corner of her eye, watching as he gazed at the forest. Despite Khayzur's death, there was a new
light in his eyes.

He's home

, Nahri realized. And it wasn't just his eyes that were shining; as he reached to clear away a low-hanging branch, she caught

a glimpse of his ring, the emerald glowing bright. Nahri frowned, but as she moved closer to him, the glow vanished.

The forest finally began to flatten, the trees thinning out to give way to a pebbly shore. The lake was enormous, ringed by

mountains of green hardwood forests on the southern side and sheer cliffs in the distant north. The blue-green water was completely

still, an unbroken sheet of glass. She saw no island, nothing even hinting at a village, let alone a massive city.

But there was a large boat beached not far from where they stood, similar in shape to the feluccas that sailed the Nile. The

sun flashed off the dizzying black and gold designs painted on the hull, and a triangular black sail flapped uselessly in

the breeze, reaching for the lake. A man stood on the sharply curved bow with his arms crossed, chewing the end of a skinny

pipe. His clothing reminded Nahri of the Yemeni traders she'd seen in Cairo, a patterned waist-wrap and simple tunic. His

skin was as brown as hers, and his trimmed black beard the length of a fist. A

tasseled gray turban was tied around his head.

There were two other men on the beach below the boat, both dressed in voluminous robes of dark teal and matching head wraps.

As Nahri watched, one gestured angrily at the man on the boat, shouting something she couldn't hear and pointing behind him.

From the trees on the other side of the forest, a few more men appeared, leading camels laden with bound white tablets.

"Are they daevas?" she asked in an eager hush, noting the way their robes shimmered and smoked and their black skin gleamed.

Dara didn't look as excited. "Probably not their preferred term."

She ignored his hostility. "Djinn then?" When he nodded, she returned to watching them. Even after the months she had spent

with Dara, the sight before her still seemed unimaginable. Djinn, nearly a dozen of them. The stuff of legends and campfire tales in the flesh, haggling like old women.

"The men in the robes are Ayaanle," Dara offered. "Probably salt traders, judging from their cargo. That other man is Geziri,"

Dara said, looking at the ferryman with narrowed eyes. "Probably one of the king's agents, although he certainly doesn't look very official," he added snobbishly. He glanced back at Nahri. "Pull your scarf--what remains of it anyway--across your face when we get closer."

"Why?"

"Because no Daeva would travel with a shafit companion," he said plainly. "At least not in my time. I don't want to draw attention."

He plucked a bit of muck from his left sleeve and rubbed it carefully on his cheek to hide his tattoo. "Let me have my robe back. I need to cover the marks on my arms."

Nahri pulled it off and handed it over. "Do you think you'll be recognized?"

"Eventually. But apparently my choices are being arrested in Daevabad or returning to the Gozan to be murdered by marids and

peris for some unknown offense." He wrapped the tail end of his turban close around his jaw. "I'll take my chance with the djinn."

She pulled her scarf across her face. The men were still fighting when they reached the boat. Their language was raucous,

sounding like a mismatch of every language Nahri had ever heard in the bazaars.

"The king will hear of this, he will!" one of the Ayaanle traders declared. He angrily shook a piece of parchment at the boatman's

feet. "We were given a fixed contract by the palace for transport!"

Nahri watched the men in awe. All the Ayaanle were at least two heads taller than she was, their brilliant teal robes flapping

like birds. Their eyes were gold, but without the yellow harshness of the ifrit. She was utterly transfixed; she didn't even

have to touch them to feel the life and energy sparking just beneath their skin. She could hear their breathing, could sense

enormous lungs filling and puffing like bellows. The beat of their hearts was like wedding drums.

The Geziri boatman was far less impressive, though his slouch and stained tunic might have been to blame. He exhaled a long

stream of black smoke and orange sparks, dangling the pipe from his long fingers.

"A pretty piece of paper," he drawled, gesturing at the traders' contract. "Perhaps it shall serve as a raft if you don't

want to pay my price."

Nahri appreciated the man's logic, but Dara seemed less impressed. He stepped up, the others finally noticing them. "And what

price is that?"

The boatman gave him a surprised look. "Daeva pilgrims don't pay, you fool." He grinned wickedly at the Ayaanle. "Crocodiles,

however . . ."

The other djinn abruptly raised his hand, and sparks twisted around his fingers. "You dare insult us, you thin-blooded, wave-addled . . ."

Dara gently led Nahri to the other side of the boat. "They might be a while," he said as they headed up the narrow painted

ramp.

"They sound like they're going to kill each other." She glanced back as one of the Ayaanle traders started to bang a long

wooden staff against the boat's hull. The Geziri captain cackled.

"They'll agree on a fare eventually. Believe it or not, their tribes are actually allies. Though of course under

Daeva

rule, all passage was free."

She detected a hint of smugness in his voice and sighed. Something told her the squabbles

between the various djinn tribes

would make the war between the Turks and Franks look positively friendly.

But however nasty their argument, the captain and the merchants must have finally agreed on a price, because before she knew

it, the camels were being led into the belly of the ship. The boat lurched and swayed with each step, the sewn wooden planks

protesting. Nahri watched the merchants settle on the opposite end of the boat, gracefully crossing their long legs underneath their sweeping robes.

The captain jumped aboard and pulled the ramp up with a loud bang. Nahri felt her stomach flutter with nerves. She watched

as he plucked a short rod from his waist-wrap. As he turned it over in his hands, it became longer and longer.

She frowned, peering over the boat's side. They were still beached on the shore. "Shouldn't we be in the water?"

Dara shook his head. "Oh, no. Passengers only embark from land. It's too risky otherwise."

"Risky?"

"Oh, the marid cursed this lake centuries ago. If you put so much as a toe in the water, it'll grab you, rip you to shreds,

and send your remains to all the locations your mind has ever contemplated."

Nahri's mouth dropped open in horror. "

What?

" she gasped. "And we're going to cross it? In this rickety piece of--"

"There is no god but God!" the captain cried and slammed the rod--which was now a pole nearly as long as the boat--into the

sandy shore.

The boat shoved off so fast it was briefly propelled in the air. It slammed into the lake with a great crash that sent a wave

of water flying over its sides. Nahri shrieked and covered her head, but the captain quickly swept between her and the rising

wave. He clucked his tongue at the water and threatened it with his pole like one would shoo away a dog. The water flattened out.

"Relax," Dara urged, looking embarrassed. "The lake knows to behave. We're perfectly safe here."

"It knows . . . Do me a favor," Nahri seethed, glaring at the daeva. "Next time we're about to

do something like cross a marid-cursed
lake that

shreds

people, stop and explain every step. By the Most High . . ."

No one else seemed bothered. The Ayaanle were chatting among themselves, sharing a basket of oranges. The captain balanced
precariouly on the edge of the hull and adjusted the sail. As Nahri watched, he tucked the pipe into his tunic and began
to sing.

The words swept over her, sounding oddly familiar yet completely incomprehensible. It was such a strange sensation that it

took her a moment to fully realize what was happening. "Dara?" She tugged on his sleeve, drawing his attention from the sparkling
water. "Dara, I can't understand him." That had never happened to her before.

He glanced up at the djinn. "No, he's singing in Geziriyya. Their language can't be understood, can't even be learned by foreign
tribesmen." His lips curled. "A fitting ability for such a duplicitous people."

"Don't start."

"I'm not. I didn't say it to his face."

Nahri sighed. "What was that they were speaking to each other then?" she asked, gesturing between the captain and the traders.

He rolled his eyes. "Djinnistani. An ugly and unrefined merchant tongue consisting of the most unpleasant sounds of all their
languages."

Well, that was enough of Dara's opinions for now. Nahri turned away, lifting her face to the bright sun. It was warm on her

skin, and she fought to keep her eyes open, the rhythmic motion of the boat lulling her toward sleep. She lazily watched a
gray hawk circle and dip close, perhaps hoping for orange scraps, before it veered off toward the distant cliffs.

"I still don't see anything that looks like a city," she said idly.

"You will very shortly," he answered, peering at the green mountains. "There's one last illusion to pass."

As he spoke, something shrill rang in her ears. Before she could cry out, her entire body suddenly constricted, as if it had
been compressed in a tight sheath. Her skin burned, and her lungs felt full of smoke.

Her vision briefly blurred as the ringing
grew louder . . .

And then it was gone. Nahri lay flat on her back on the deck, trying to catch her breath.
Dara leaned over her, his face full
of worry. "What happened? Are you all right?"

She pushed herself upright and rubbed her head, dislodging her shawl and wiping away the
sweat that sheened her face. "I'm
fine," she mumbled.

One of the Ayaanle merchants rose as well. Upon seeing her uncovered face, he averted
his golden eyes. "Is your lady ill,
brother? We have some food and water . . ."

"She's not your concern," Dara snapped.

The trader flinched like he'd been slapped and abruptly sat back down with his fellows.

Nahri was shocked by Dara's rudeness. "What's wrong with you? He was just trying to
help." She let her voice rise, half-hoping
the Ayaanle could hear her embarrassment. She pushed away Dara's hand as he
tried to help her to her feet, and then nearly
fell over again as an enormous walled city loomed before them, so large it blotted
out most of the sky and entirely covered
the rocky island upon which it sat.

The walls alone would have dwarfed the Pyramids, and the only buildings she could see in
the distance were tall enough to
peek over them: a dizzying variety of slender minarets, egg-shaped temples with
sloping green roofs, and squat brick buildings
draped in intricate white stonework resembling lace. The wall itself shone brilliantly
in the bright sun, the light glistening
off the golden surface like . . .

"Brass," she whispered. The massive wall was entirely built of brass, polished to perfection.

She wordlessly walked to the edge of the boat. Dara followed. "Yes," he said. "The brass
better holds the enchantments used
to build the city."

Nahri's eyes roamed the wall. They were approaching a port of stone piers and docks that
looked large enough to hold both
the Frankish and Ottoman fleets. A large, perfectly cut stone roof sheltered much of
the area, held up by enormous columns.

As the boat pushed closer, she noticed figures skillfully carved into the wall's brass surface,
dozens of men and women dressed

in an ancient style she couldn't identify, with flat caps covering their curly hair. Some were standing and pointing, holding unfurled scrolls and weighted scales. Others simply sat with open palms, their veiled faces serene.

"My God," she whispered. Her eyes widened as they grew closer; brass statues of the same figures towered over the boat.

A grin like Nahri had never before seen lit Dara's face as he gazed upon the city. His cheeks flushed with excitement, and

when he glanced down at her, his eyes were so bright she could barely meet his gaze.

"Your ancestors, Banu Nahida," he said, gesturing to the statues. He pressed his hands together and bowed. "Welcome to Daevabad."